



Colours of Onam

Women make 'pookalam', a traditional rangoli made with fresh flower petals and leaves, during the Onam festival, in Karnataka's Chikmagalur on Wednesday. **R1**

BREAK-UP INEVITABLE

Farooq's swipe at Srinagar MP Ruhullah sparks resignation buzz

Bashaar Masood
Srinagar, August 26

THE RIFT between the National Conference and its Srinagar Member of Parliament Aqas Syed Ruhullah Mehdi now appears to be heading towards an inevitable break.

A day after National Conference president Dr Farooq Abdullah publicly challenged Ruhullah to seek a fresh mandate without the National Conference, Ruhullah has hinted at his possible exit.

"I can't happen that Dr Sahib asks for something and I don't give it to him, that I don't give him empty-handed," Ruhullah said. "I will respond to (senior Abdullah's call for resignation) in detail over the next few days."

This comes as the rift between Ruhullah and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has steadily grown over the last few months, especially given the Srinagar MP's increasingly independent political positions and growing criticism of the NC government.

The party's star campaigner in the 2024 J&K Assembly elections and a leader many candidates appeared to prefer over Omar, Ruhullah has accused the party of backtracking on promises made to the people during the elections and abandoning the fight for Jammu and Kashmir's constitutional rights taken away on August 5, 2019.

Silent over the growing rift between Ruhullah and his son for the last year, Farooq took a public swipe at the Srinagar MP, whom he brought into politics, this week.

Speaking to a local news channel, the NC patriarch Farooq Abdullah said: "Could Ruhullah sahib have ever won without the National Conference? I tell him, resign, resign

conversion case. Investigators said the Hyderabad-based women had travelled to Palghar through contacts established by Kamblid.

Investigation officer Pratik Pokale said Kunche allegedly offered some free of cost religious texts to the complainant and told him that reading them would cure illness and protect him from diseases.

The boy later informed other villagers, following which residents reportedly intercepted the group.

"We have not arrested anyone. They must be arrested," Pokale said. "The next step is investigation, recording statements of all the people they came in contact with, where they went, where they work and why they came particularly to Mokhada."

He said the Hyderabad-based women were allowed to leave because they had a train to catch for Hyderabad that evening, but would be required to cooperate with the investigation.

Pastor Sam K. Mathai, secretary of the Palghar Zilla Mission Sangati, an association of pastors, said the organisation was conducting its own inquiry. "As of now, it is difficult to say there was any sort of conversion in the matter," he said.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Nepal

populated. Rasuwai is known for its trekking routes, with 108 lakes in the region including the sacred Gosai Kund Lake. Some of the missing were trekking to the Gosai Kund Lake, coinciding with the local festival of Janai Purnima on Friday.

Though the monsoon season is less favorable for trekking in Nepal, it's a major season for Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, along the Rasuwa (Nepal)-Gyirong (Tibet) route.

Dozens of multi-storied buildings, trucks and vans were buried under the mud in Nuwakot, one of the worst-affected areas. Critical infrastructure, including at least a dozen hydro-power projects, was also destroyed, affecting about 700 MW of power generation. Gorkha, Nawalparasi and Chitwan were among the other districts affected.

Climate experts at the Kathmandu-based International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) said an avalanche from a glacier likely caused the flash floods. Initial reports suggested that an earthquake in the area could have triggered an avalanche and caused

the floods, Nepal's Foreign Minister Shishir Khandal also told Parliament on Wednesday, according to local media reports.

"Preliminary assessment based on video footage and information from affected areas suggest that a large volume of ice and rock debris may have entered the Lhendhe Khola, a tributary of the Bhoti Koshi River. Researchers say the event could have generated a sudden surge that carried water, sediment and large boulders downstream," ICIMOD said in a press release.

From its origin in Tibet, the Bhoti Koshi river empties into Nepal's Trishuli river that eventually flows into India as the Gandak River. The swollen Trishuli river engulfed the surrounding areas, leaving a wide swathe of destruction on either side of its course. At least half-a-dozen bridges over the river were swept away, including in the Malekhu area, affecting connectivity to the two tourist sites of Chitwan and Pokhara.

Security footage captured on the Chinese side of the Nepal-Tibet border showed many people fleeing before a torrent of rock, mud and water destroyed buildings, vehicles and took many lives.

China's official Xinhua news agency said the mudslide oc-

curred on the Nepal side and hit the Gyirong port, cutting roads, communication and power links in the Shigatse region near the border, but did not elaborate.

Chinese state broadcaster CCTV said the mudslide in Gyirong County near the border killed at least three and left 265 missing. A rescuer told CCTV that it would take at least four hours for the rescue team to reach the site due to the 15-metre deep sediment that blocked pathways leading to the affected area. The debris had surged upstream from the Nepalese side of the crossing, the rescuer said.

The exact cause of the mudslide could not be immediately determined, but the German Research Centre for Geosciences said there was a 4.4 magnitude quake around seven minutes before the time shown on the security footage time-stamp.

An initial study of Planet Labs satellite imagery indicated that a landslide of snow and rock debris from the Lhendhe Khola, about 20 km northeast of the Nepal-China Rasuwagadhi border crossing, Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said on X.

An ice-rock avalanche in the Lhendhe Khola on the Nepal side was the trigger, but the cause re-

mains unconfirmed, said Qiang-gong Zhang, head of climate and environmental risks at ICIMOD. "With a blockage still lodged upstream on the Nepal-China border river, authorities warn a second flood may occur," Qiang-gong said.

Prime Minister Balendra Shah called an emergency meeting of the Cabinet. "Instructions have been given to move the people living in the lower areas to safer places," he said.

Former King Gyanendra Shah also issued an appeal, calling for a coordinated safety campaign and tripartite cooperation between Nepal, India and China for long-term initiatives to contain flood. Last August too, the same regions in Nepal had seen similar flash floods when a glacial lake in Tibet overflowed because of high temperatures. Nine people were killed, and critical infrastructure, including a bridge connecting Nepal and China, was damaged at the time.

The Lhendhe Khola has flooded twice in fourteen months, this time triggered by an ice-rock avalanche from a glacier on the Nepal side that blocked the river and released a sudden surge downstream," said Saswata Sanyal, a disaster risk reduction specialist at the climate research group. **WITH AGENCIES**

hydropower project.

The Indian Embassy in Nepal said it "remained engaged with the relevant authorities of the Government of Nepal for early rescue and relief for Indian nationals affected by the flash floods. Rescue and relief efforts continue to be strengthened in coordination with the Government of Nepal". In a post on X, it also put out headline numbers for assistance and information referred to Indian nationals: 977 985 131 6807 and 977 970 910 7500.

The Nepal Tourism Board also issued a post on X, including a toll-free emergency number 1234, hotline 1144, and tourist police 9851289445.

The Indian Embassy in Beijing said on X: "In view of the recent flash flood in the border areas in the Tibet Autonomous Region, People's Republic of China, Indian nationals stranded in the vicinity can seek assistance from the following contact points: i) Chinese officials on the ground: 0086 139 8999 0012; ii) Embassy of India, Beijing: 0086 185 1428 4905 (can also be contacted through WhatsApp); iii) Embassy of India, Kathmandu: +977 9851 6807, +977 970 910 7500 (Both numbers can also be contacted through WhatsApp)".

Meanwhile, flood alerts have been issued in UP and Bihar, which border Nepal. Additional NDRF teams have been sent to both the states, with the swelling waters expected to flow downstream into the Ganges river.

While two NDRF teams have been sent to Bihar for deployment in West Champaran and Muzaffarpur, an additional NDRF team has been deployed in Kushinagar. With this, a total of 9 NDRF teams are in Bihar, while 11 NDRF teams are deployed in UP. **WITH DIVYAA**

India, China

of views on the boundary question.

According to the statement, the two sides reaffirmed their commitment to "uphold the guidance received from the leaders of the two countries, maintain peace and tranquility in the border areas" and "create an atmosphere for healthy and steady development of bilateral relations".

The two sides underlined their commitment to "advancing negotiations on a framework for the settlement of the boundary question in accordance with the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Settlement of the China-India Boundary Question signed in 2005 and the consensus reached in subsequent SR talks, in pursuit of a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable solution", it stated.

"The Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation and Working Group on Border Management under the WMCC would respectively advance discussions on an Early and Substantial Harvest of boundary delimitation and Border Management. The first task for both these groups would be to agree on their respective Terms of Reference," the statement said on the third outcome. The WMCC is the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs.

Incidentally, when Doval and Wang held talks in New Delhi on August 19, 2025, days before PM Narendra Modi's visit to Tianjin for the SCO summit, they had decided to form an expert group under the WMCC to explore early harvest of the boundary delimitation, and a working group under the WMCC to advance effective border management.

On the fourth outcome of the Beijing meeting, the statement said: "The two sides agreed that any situation on the ground would be addressed promptly through existing diplomatic and military channels, including the WMCC, local commander-level meetings and other agreed mechanisms, to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscal-

culations along the LAC. The two sides discussed ways to improve understanding of the LAC in appropriate areas for better border management."

The fifth outcome stated: "With the objective to improve the border management measures, an additional two meeting points were agreed for holding the General Level Mechanism/Senior Highest Military Commander meeting (SHMC). Similarly, two additional meeting points were agreed for holding the Eastern and Middle Sectors were agreed."

Last year, the two sides had agreed on general level mechanisms in the eastern sector (Arunachal Pradesh) and middle sector (Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand), in addition to the existing mechanism in the western sector (Ladakh).

The sixth outcome of the meeting stated: "Both sides noted the progress on trans-border cooperation. The Indian side appreciated the efforts made by the Chinese side to increase the number of Indian official pilgrims Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra (KMY) in the Tibet Autonomous Region of China. Both sides appreciated the reopening of the three designated border trading points. The two sides agreed to strengthen exchanges and cooperation in border trade, pilgrimages and other areas, with the view to work together to create an atmosphere featuring dialogue, peace, consultation and cooperation in the border areas."

The Chinese Foreign Ministry statement described the Tibet Autonomous Region as "Mount Gang Renpoche and Lake Mapam Yut Tso in Xizang Autonomous Region of China".

The seventh outcome was that "the two sides agreed to hold the next meeting of the China-India Expert-Level Mechanism on Trans-border Rivers in September and maintain communication on issues including hydrological data sharing, and renewal of relevant MoUs."

"This is especially important for the Brahmaputra, and timely sharing of data for river management."

Listing the eighth outcome, the statement said the two sides agreed to hold the 26th round of SR-level talks in India in 2027.

Ice-snow avalanche

there was no immediate causal link established between seismic activity and the flood.

"The same site devastated by last year's Rasuwa flood is once again under threat... An ice avalanche in the Lhendhe Khola is the suspected trigger, but the cause remains unconfirmed. With a blockage still lodged upstream on the Nepal-China border, authorities warn a second flood is imminent," Qiang-gong Zhang, head of Climate and Environmental Risks at ICIMOD, said in the press release.

An ice avalanche involves the sudden collapse and downhill movement of a large mass of ice from either a glacier that was hanging or from an ice-covered mountain.

ICIMOD noted the "exceptional speed and magnitude" of the flood and added that the Trishuli river's water levels reportedly rose by nine metres at Galchhi and by seven metres at Malekhu within 30 minutes. Both these areas are part of the Nuwakot district, one of the affected areas.

ICIMOD said experts are assessing whether debris temporarily blocked the river at a narrow section, forming a landslide dam. Such blockage, it said, could create a "secondary hazard" if impounded water is suddenly released.

Russia

energy relationship between Moscow and New Delhi. For about four years now, India has been one of the top buyers of Russian crude, the other being China. Russian oil, often sold at attractive prices after Western sanctions disrupted Moscow's traditional European markets in the wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, now accounts for the lion's share in India's crude imports.

Repeated Ukrainian drone attacks on Russian oil refineries, combined with routine refinery maintenance, summer summer season demand, and logistical bottlenecks, have compounded the problems for Moscow. Domestic supplies of both petrol and diesel are impacted, but the country is still relatively comfortable with regard to diesel as its refining system is geared to produce far more diesel than its consumption.

Nevertheless, Moscow has responded with restrictions on diesel exports as well in a bid to have a comfortable cushion ahead of the winter season. Petrol, however, is a different story. Exports are out of the question and reports indicate that limits have been placed on the volume of petrol that can be supplied to a vehicle across numerous fuel stations in various regions of the country.

Gasoline has been particularly exposed. Under normal operating conditions, Russian refinery output broadly covers domestic demand with only limited surplus available for exports, leaving the market with relatively little buffer when refinery throughput falls. With refinery runs remaining de-

pressed, Russia has responded by restricting product exports and played with product specifications across several barrels to protect domestic availability," Sumit Ritola, modelling and refining manager at commodity market analytics firm Kpler told The Indian Express.

As per Kpler data, about 12,000 barrels per day (bps) of gasoline was exported from India to Russia in June, with the volumes jumping to about 21,000 bpd in July. Taken together, this amounts to close to a third of petrol being sent to Russia during the two months. Additionally, some additional volumes are expected to have reached Russia from India through a series of ship-to-ship transfers and vessels with undeclared destinations.

"Most of the imported gasoline comes from Belarus. One of Belarus's refineries is 42% owned by a Russian consortium, and all the crude processed at both of them comes from Russia. Kazakhstan should be another primary option, but it cannot supply significant volumes... (it) is a net importer. The seaborne trade is more interesting. So far, Russia appears to have exported five gasoline cargoes... Three of them were cargoes of around 320,000-350,000 barrels from Vadinar," Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona told this newspaper.

Another cargo arrived via Morocco's Tangier terminal, although the details are unclear as Morocco does not have an active refinery. Another cargo of around 250,000 barrels was shipped from Turkey's Mersin port. Katona said that while there is no refinery near Mersin, a 500,000-barrel cargo from India had been discharged there about a week earlier.

Modi

provide all possible humanitarian assistance to Nepal. Our teams are coordinating closely on rescue and relief efforts," Modi said in a post on X.

Shah, in his response, said: "Thank you very much... for your kind call and deep condolences. We deeply appreciate your warm words of solidarity and your generous offer of assistance to Nepal during this difficult time. This gesture of solidarity is a reflection of the enduring bonds of friendship between our two countries, which we profoundly value."

In a post on X later in the day, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said: "Dispatched 10 tonnes of HADR (Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief) assistance and essential medicines to support Nepal's response to the devastating floods. Our thoughts are with the bereaved families and all those affected. In the face of this challenge, India stands with Nepal and its people."

Source said the IAF's C-130J is carrying 10 tonnes of relief material, including temporary shelters, blankets, hygiene kits, solar lamps and medicines.

Nepal's Foreign Minister Shishir Khandal said: "Thank you... for the generous humanitarian aid and critical medical supplies extended to support our flood relief efforts. India's swift response reflects the strength of our bilateral partnership and mutual solidarity in this difficult hour."

While over 100 Indians have been reported missing, sources said that besides tourists/pilgrims, these included several people working at the Trishuli

therein. It is not that this event was organised out of the blue or cropped up at the last moment. Invitation cards were printed and preparations were made in advance but deliberately the names of both the judges of the established institutional mechanism and that "the Supreme Court cannot allow individual complaints concerning judges to be determined through competing claims in the media".

"The CJT maintained that the contents of the letters cannot be adjudicated in the public domain and that the concerned judge must be given a fair opportunity to place his response before any conclusion is reached. The fact that allegations have been made, therefore, cannot by itself be treated as a finding against the judge," the statement said.

Currently, seven of the 25 High Courts across the country have acting Chief Justices. On August 6, the Collegium recommended the appointment of Chief Justices to High Courts in Patna, Bhopal, Calcutta and Punjab and Haryana. The Collegium is yet to make recommendations for Jammu and Kashmir, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan HC.

It is learnt that Justice Sharma's candidature was "actively being considered" for appointment as Chief Justice of the Rajasthan HC. He has been acting Chief Justice of his parent HC since September 28, 2025, the longest among the seven ACJs.

Justice Mehta said Supreme Court judge Justice Vijay Bishnoi and he "were both invited to the conference and gave consent for being present in the inaugural session which was to be headed by" the CJT.

"How the invitation card issued by the Rajasthan State Legal Services Authority does not bear any reference whatsoever to our names. What is more humiliating is even though my consent was taken to speak in the inaugural session but the minute-to-minute programme placed on the desk did not indicate so. Having noticed this, I immediately texted my Private Secretary to speak to the coordinating officer, i.e., the Member Secretary, Rajasthan State Legal Services Authority, who came to the desk after a few minutes and placed an amended program on the desk, featuring a formal apology. Apparently, this was a deliberate attempt of humiliating the sitting Judges of the Supreme Court whose parent High Court is the Rajasthan High Court," he said.

"On 1st August, 2026, after I had left Jaipur, I was informed that the programme was already scheduled to lay a foundation stone for a Guest House at the Rajasthan High Court Bench at Jaipur. It is shocking that the foundation stone of a building of significant importance was to be laid in the Rajasthan High Court and yet, both Supreme Court Judges from Rajasthan, i.e., myself and Justice Vijay Bishnoi, even though present at Jaipur, were neither informed nor invited to participate

Supreme Court judge

the State looking to its unbecoming conduct" and that that not doing so would be "wholly against the interest of the Institution".

Phone calls to the Registrar General of the Rajasthan High Court for comment did not elicit a response.

Incidentally, on April 25 this year, Ranjeet Joshi, president of the Rajasthan High Court Advocates Association of India, wrote to the CJT, urging him to consider the transfer of Justice Sharma "outside the state of Rajasthan... so that a harmonious atmosphere can be re-established between the Bar and the Bench".

Seeking the appointment of a permanent Chief Justice, Joshi said, "The lack of communication and treatment of advocates is leading to frequent disagreements and conflicts between the Bar and the Bench, which is detrimental to the smooth functioning of the Bar and the Bench. Furthermore, there are also issues regarding the basic needs of advocates such as providing small chambers/meeting spaces (e.g., 10x10 feet in sheds), for which the expected cooperation is not being received, due to which there is dissatisfaction among the advocates."

Elevated to the Rajasthan High Court in 2016, Justice Sharma was transferred to the Patna High Court in 2022. In 2023, the Supreme Court Colle-

gium turned down his request that he be sent back to Rajasthan on health grounds and instead be moved to the Punjab and High Court. In 2025, the Collegium accepted his request following which he became Acting CJ of the Rajasthan High Court. Justice Mehta alleged that "pursuant to taking charge as the Acting Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court, Mr. Justice Sharma has exhibited total lack of leadership qualities and behaviour unbecoming of a leader of the institution on more than one occasions."

"Several instances where cases listed in other rosters were suddenly withdrawn by exercising powers of the master of the roster, and shifted to the Bench of Mr. Justice S P Sharma without any justifiable cause and orders were passed raising serious question mark on the integrity of the decision-making process," he wrote to the CJT.

"There are innumerable instances of Mr. Justice Sharma, exercising powers as the Acting Chief Justice, in a manner unbecoming of the leader of the institution... I have received several complaints about the judicial functioning of Mr. Justice S P Sharma which, prima facie, raise doubts on his integrity," he alleged.

In one of the letters, Justice Mehta said that "the lack of camaraderie about the 'lack of camaraderie' had to suffer after being invited to a conference in Jaipur from July 31 to August 2,

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CJI seeks comments

that allegations against a sitting judge must be dealt with strictly through the established institutional mechanism and that "the Supreme Court cannot allow individual complaints concerning judges to be determined through competing claims in the media".

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22 women booked for conversion bid in Palghar; no arrest yet

Purnima Sah
Mumbai, August 26

THE MOKHADADA Police in Maharashtra's Palghar have booked 22 women for allegedly attempting to convert people to Christianity in Wakadpada village and hunting religious sentiments. No arrests have been made, and none are planned at this stage, police have said.

The FIR was registered on a complaint filed by an 18-year-old boy, who told police that a group of women had approached his house and offered him religious texts. He said he refused to accept them.

The women have been booked under Section 299 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), which deals with deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings, and Section 3(5), relating to acts done by several persons in furtherance of a common intention.

According to police, a group of 20 women from Hyderabad came to the village along with one woman from Uthasagar in Thane district and another from Palghar.

Police have identified Sanyaswari, a local, as one of the primary suspects in the alleged

OFFICIALS TOLD TO MONITOR SUPPLY, PREVENT HOARDING

First Kanda Express set to arrive today, Capital readies onion plan

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 26

WITH THE first Kanda Express expected to reach the Capital from Nashik on Thursday, the Delhi government has begun assessing the city's daily onion requirement amid the possibility of a further rise in prices.

"The first consignment is expected to reach Delhi on Thursday. There is currently no shortage of onions in the city. But if prices rise, we have to be ready so that people do not face any problems. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta held a meeting in this regard and directed the Food and Supplies department to prepare a detailed action plan," Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said on Wednesday.

Sirsa said the department was calculating the current requirement of onions in the city. "The plan will be ready by tomorrow. Once the onions arrive in Delhi, we will move forward with our demand and ask for 10 MT, 15 MT or more, as per the requirement," he added.

The minister further said



A truck in Nashik on way to deliver onions to Kanda Express. EXPRESS

Sirsa said the CM has directed the department to prepare a detailed action plan, including exploring making affordable onions available through camps across Delhi

will ensure that residents do not have to bear the additional burden.

"In such a situation, the government will procure onions and sugar from NAFED, a Central government institution, and arrange to make them available at various locations across the capital," he said.

The commodities would be sold at the price at which they are procured from NAFED.

Sirsa said the CM has directed the department to prepare a detailed action plan, including exploring making affordable onions available through camps across Delhi.

The government has further directed officials to monitor onion supplies received in Delhi, ensure that consignments reach the market properly and prevent hoarding. Action will be taken against those found violating the rules, he added.

"Delhi government will bear transportation and other related expenses and will not allow any additional burden to fall on the people of Delhi under any circumstances," Sirsa said.

On sugar, Sirsa said the union government had prescribed quantity limits to prevent hoarding.

"Delhi government will also take action under these provisions. If sugar is found to be stored or hoarded beyond the prescribed limit at any place, action will be taken against those responsible," he said.

"The department has also been directed to examine how sugar can be made available and supplied to people at affordable rates. A detailed plan has been sought for this purpose," he added.

CYBER CRIME COORDINATION CENTRE

Delhi gets nodal cybercrime unit to tackle online frauds

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 26

DELHI POLICE has set up Delhi Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (D4C), a nodal agency that will work towards preventing, detecting and investigating cybercrimes. Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu Tuesday gave his approval to the D4C, which will look into cyber-enabled financial frauds, online harassment, crimes against women and children, ransomware, online radicalisation, cyber sabotage and public-order disruption.

D4C, which will function as an apex cybercrime coordination and management body under the Delhi Police, will work under the administrative control of the Police Commissioner. It will be headed by a Chief Executive Officer of the rank of Joint Commissioner of Police who will report to the Special CP (Special Cell), and will be assisted by the DCP.

The existing Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations (IFSO) Unit, Dwarka, will be subsumed into the D4C. Its investigation wing, digital investigation lab, training and awareness centre, the 1930 cyber helpline

control room at Haiderpur, and the fraud mitigation centre will be part of the new centre.

As per the order issued by Principal Secretary (Home) Santosh D Vaidya, D4C will have functional jurisdiction across Delhi. It will comprise administrative, cyber investigation, operations and online crimes against women and children wings. Each wing will be headed by a DCP-rank officer.

The order stated that proposals for creation and sanction of posts for D4C will be processed separately and sent to the Union Home Affairs Ministry for approval. Until regular posts are created and filled, the Delhi Police Headquarters will deploy personnel from the force to the D4C.

The cyber investigation wing will be responsible for investigating high-value, multi-victim and complex cyber-crime cases. A D4C police station will also be established.

The wing will include investigation teams, a State Digital Investigation Support Centre and a legal and prosecution support cell.

The support centre will provide technical assistance to investigating officers across Delhi

Police and maintain advanced laboratories for mobile forensics, memory forensics, cloud forensics, network forensics, CCTV examination, and cryptocurrency investigations.

The Operations wing will function as the intelligence, analytics, and predictive-policing arm of the D4C. It will analyse crime data, cybercrime trends and behavioural patterns to identify emerging threats, hotspots and modus operandi," the order said.

The Cyber Threats Division will monitor cyber threats, analyse cybercrime trends, and generate actionable intelligence. It will include a Research and Innovation Unit, a Data Analytics and Response Team, a CyMAC Monitoring Cell and a dedicated Hoax Bomb E-mail Investigation Cell to probe offences involving VPNs, anonymisation technologies, spoofed or anonymous emails, hoax bomb threats and other technology-enabled communications.

The division will monitor, prevent and respond to cyber-security threats affecting government systems, critical infrastructure and public digital assets.

BAIL APPLICATIONS IN 2020 RIOTS
LARGER CONSPIRACY CASE

Khalid and Imam are 'masterminds', detention justified, Delhi Police tells HC

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, August 26

OPPOSING THE bail pleas of 2020 riots larger conspiracy case accused Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam before the Delhi High Court, the Delhi Police has reiterated that they are the "masterminds" of the conspiracy, and thus their continued detention is justified.

Responding to their bail pleas by way of a short note on August 24, the Delhi Police has relied on the Supreme Court judgment in January, which had denied the two activists bail while granting the same to five other co-accused in the case.

The SC, in its verdict, had established a hierarchy of the role of the accused.

It had also specified that Khalid and Imam will be at liberty to seek bail either after the examination of the protected witnesses or expiry of one year from the date of the SC's order, whichever is sooner.

Delhi Police is seeking dismissal of their bail pleas on this ground. It contends that while neither of these two conditions have been satisfied, the two have already moved bail pleas.

"The contention of (Khalid and Imam)... that the aforesaid operative portion (of the SC verdict) was merely 'liberty' and not a 'condition' for consideration of a fresh bail application is a deliberate misreading of the order," Delhi Police has contended.

Notably, till date, charges have not been framed in the case. Examination of witnesses only takes place after the trial begins after framing of charges.

The SC, in its January 5 order, had established a "hierarchy of participation" in the riots. In this hierarchy, Umar and Sharjeel were classified to be on a "higher footing" compared to the five others who were granted bail.



Sharjeel Imam; (top) Umar Khalid. FILE

However, a SC judgment in May had expressed "serious reservations on various aspects of the judgment" of January.

Both Khalid and Imam are relying on the divergent views taken by different benches of the SC for seeking bail under terror law Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, even as a reference to a larger bench for deciding the issue remains pending before the top court.

Two other co-accused — Tasleem Ahmad and Abdul Khalid Saifi — were also granted interim bail by the SC on this ground.

Delhi Police has, however, contended that for Khalid and Imam, the SC verdict holds regardless of divergent opinions and the pending reference among the court's benches.

"...the said reference to a larger bench cannot, in any manner, unsettle the law already declared by the (SC in Khalid and Imam's) own case (in the January order) and the hon'ble courts remain bound by the decision in (January order) till the said reference is decided by the larger bench," Delhi Police has said.

another case," Hussain contended in his appeal.

He further alleged that the witnesses in the case have been planted and statements of genuine eyewitnesses have been manipulated and that the actual perpetrators have not been brought to book.

Hussain sought setting aside of a trial court's July 31 conviction order and July 13 sentencing order, contending that the court had believed the statements of completely unreliable witnesses and relied upon those who did not witness the incident and completely ignored the tainted probe.

PTI



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Deadline approaches

Cross marks painted on walls of houses at Bhai Ram Camp, which is part of slum clusters near the Prime Minister's official residence, in New Delhi on Wednesday. The Delhi High Court on Tuesday directed residents of three slum clusters — Bhai Ram Camp, Masjid Camp, and DDO Colony — to vacate their camps within six weeks and relocate to Savda Ghevra. TASHI TOBOVAL

'EXPIRED FOOD, PEST INFESTATION'

FSSAI notices to two luxury hotels over food safety violations

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 26

THE FOOD Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) Wednesday issued notices to two luxury hotels in Delhi's Aerocity, citing several alleged "serious food safety violations", including "spoiled" food and "pest infestation".

The authority stated that these were based on observations made during inspections conducted at the premises of the two premium hotels: JW Marriott and Andaz Hotel.

Among these observations were expired food products, including "approximately 87 kg of expired sweets, an expired cake base and expired bread packets" at Andaz Delhi, stated the FSSAI.

The authority said that at the same hotel, it found a "pest infestation", including cockroaches near freezers, mosquitoes in grinding room, houseflies and spider webs.

It stated that in addition to expired stock, it found duplicate date-marking over expired bread packaging and "severe unpleasant odours and chillers situated directly between two bathrooms with exhaust venting into the chiller service area".

It stated that in a similar inspection at JW Marriott, it found spoiled or fungally af-

fectured food, "improper food storage" and "cross contamination risks". It added that these included "fungal growth on apples, rotten tomatoes, uncovered food, damaged storage containers".

At the same hotel, the authority allegedly also observed "serious hygiene and sanitation deficiencies", including "unclean utensils and food-contact surfaces, visible particulate matter in drinking water, inadequate pest control, cockroaches and fruit flies".

At both premises, it stated, "improper segregation of vegetarian and non-vegetarian food" and "improper storage of food" were also noticed.

At JW Marriott, the authority said it found that food products were being retailed under the hotel's name "without the requisite endorsement in its (Food Business Operator's) FSSAI license" while at Andaz Delhi it grinded it found that the hotel had lacked in supplier verification "including failing to check FSSAI licenses of vendors".

The FSSAI further said that it has collected surveillance samples of items such as honey, ghee, paneer and milk powder from both hotels for analysis.

When contacted, the two hotels declined to comment on the matter.

IIT-D revamps panel to probe student's death by suicide

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 26

AFTER IIT-DELHI agreed to change the composition of the committee that will inquire into the death by suicide of a Masters student, the institute late Wednesday reconstituted the panel.

The protests began after Rishikesh Kumar, who was studying for an MSc in physics, allegedly jumped to his death from the sixth floor of a building on campus on Saturday.

The reconstituted committee is led by Justice Mukta Gupta, a retired judge of the Delhi High Court, serving as Chairperson. It also comprises Prof Pratap Sharan, Head of Department of Psychiatry at AIIMS New Delhi, alongside yet-to-be-named student representatives.

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Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 26

THE SPECIAL Intensive Revision (SIR) of Delhi's electoral rolls has produced a pattern at the draft stage: constituencies with lower voter turnout in the 2025 Assembly elections are more likely to have below-average digitisation rates, potentially putting a relatively higher share of their electorate at risk of exclusion from the draft electoral roll, an analysis by *The Indian Express* shows.

Delhi has 70 Assembly constituencies. An analysis of the data shows that 17 of the 18 constituencies with the lowest voter turnout in the 2025 elections — about a quarter of all Assembly seats — had digitisation rates below Delhi's average of 67%, data accessed by *The Indian Express* shows.

During the enumeration phase, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) go door to door to distribute enumeration forms, help electors fill them out, and collect the completed forms. The BLOs then upload the details to the Election Commission of India's (ECI) official portal, a process referred to as digitisation. The digitisation rate indicates the proportion of electors whose forms have been uploaded and who are likely to be included in the

• Turnout in 2025 Delhi Assembly elections

Constituency	Turnout %	Digitization rate %
Mehrauli	53	59
Model Town	53	63
R.K. Puram	54	56
Kasturba Nagar	54	56
Malviya Nagar	54	61
Karol Bagh	54	60
Kalkaji	54	57
Greater Kailash	55	65
Okhla	55	55
Wazirpur	56	63
Tughlakabad	56	52
Chandni Chowk	56	61
Timarpur	56	66
Adarsh Nagar	56	70
New Delhi	56	58
Badarpur	56.81	57
Jangpura	57.41	58
Rithala	57.71	64

SOURCE: ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA

draft electoral rolls.

Only Adarsh Nagar breaks the pattern, recording a turnout of 56% but a digitisation rate of nearly 70%.

Mehrauli, which recorded

the lowest turnout at 53%, has digitised around 59% of its electors. Kasturba Nagar, where turnout was 54%, has a digitisation rate of nearly 56%. In Tughlakabad, turnout was 56%

and digitisation stands at around 52%.

The pattern is broadly consistent with the Election Commission's explanation for the SIR exercise: areas with a larger number of electors who have shifted, died or are otherwise ineligible may record lower turnout, and could also see a larger proportion of names classified as uncollectible during the revision. These constituencies are spread across Delhi and include both affluent neighbourhoods and lower-income areas.

Significantly, the analysis of data, however, does not support a similar pattern for constituencies with large Purvanchal or Muslim populations.

Of the 15 constituencies where Purvanchal voters are considered a dominant political force, seven have digitisation rates below the Delhi average while eight are above it. Sangam Vihar has a digitisation rate of 59%, Buzarri 63% and Rithala 64%. But other Purvanchal-dominated constituencies have significantly higher rates: Matiala stands at 76%, Dwarka at 72% and Babarpur at 73%.

The seven constituencies with a significant Muslim population also do not, as a group, show unusually low digitisation. Five have rates above the city average, while two fall

below it. Okhla has one of the lowest rates at nearly 55%, while Chandni Chowk stands at 61%. At the other end, Matia Mahal has digitised around 75% of its electors, Babarpur 73% and Mustafabad around 72%.

The final scale of exclusions, however, will not be known until the final electoral roll is published on November 4. The draft roll is scheduled to be published on August 31, after which voters whose names are missing can seek inclusion.

The enumeration phase ended last week. During the nearly one-and-a-half-month-long process, forms of around 97.51 lakh electors — 67% of the 1.45 crore electors initially on the rolls when the SIR exercise began in Delhi — had been collected and uploaded to the EC portal, according to data from the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Delhi.

The remaining 47.58 lakh electors, who constitute about 33% of the electorate, have been marked "uncollectible". The category includes electors who were absent, may have moved or died, duplicate entries and those listed under 'Other' reasons. Their names are set to be excluded from the draft roll, though the revision process will provide an opportunity to seek inclusion.

Amid Gurgaon's monsoon woes, another crisis now piles up: A mountain of garbage

14,000 contractual sanitation and fire workers are on strike for 21 days

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 26

FOR 20 days, Gurgaon's garbage has been piling up across its most expensive neighbourhoods and commercial areas as more than 14,000 contractual municipal workers remain on strike. On Wednesday, the 21st day of the protest, the agitation was extended by four days, amid a standoff with the Haryana government.

Hundreds of sanitation workers — who accused the government of backing out of previously agreed demands and adopting an unyielding stance — gathered at the old municipal corporation office and marched to the Mini-Secretariat, where they submitted a memorandum addressed to Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini through Sub-Divisional Magistrate Hiten Sharma.

The Nagar Palika Karamchari Sangh (Haryana) and Fire Department Employees Union subsequently announced that the strike, which was to continue until August 30, they warned that failure to issue official orders implementing the agreement reached with the government on May 13 would lead to an indefinite statewide strike.

RWAs want control of sanitation

With rain worsening the situation, residents said decom-

posing waste was raising fears of dengue and malaria. Several Residents' Welfare Associations (RWAs) have demanded that sanitation management and the funds allocated for it be handed directly to them.

In Sector 40, where 100 square yard residential plots command upwards of Rs 3 crore, residents said waste has been accumulating along internal roads and vacant plots for weeks.

"The entire sector is choking on garbage... The administration has turned living conditions into a nightmare," said Abhimanyu Yadav, president of the Sector 40 RWA.

"If these conditions persist, the Municipal Corporation of Gurgaon (MCG) will not be able to contain a dengue spread in Sector 40," he said, adding that the RWA wanted control of sanitation and the funds allocated for it so residents could manage the workforce and ensure regular waste collection. Residents also highlighted "gaps" in the sector's sanitation deployment. While Sector 40 has a sanctioned strength of 21 sanitation workers, only 14 contractual workers — a supervisor and 13 sweepers — are assigned on the ground, they claimed.

They alleged that absenteeism and proxy attendance further reduce the workforce available on the ground.

In Uppal Southend, RWA president Col (ret'd) Suresh Yadav said residents had been



The situation at Gurgaon's Sector 23A on Wednesday. EXPRESS

spending Rs 2 lakh a month since last year to hire an agency for sanitation. "The strike is just an excuse. Now even more of their workers do not show up," he alleged.

Vinita Sinha, RWA president of Subharti Lok A and Al blocks, said residents had hired their own sweepers to sweep roads and also lift garbage. "Open plots in our society have not been cleaned since the strike and lots of garbage is getting accumulated there. We are spending our own funds now," she said.

Sinha claimed that the problem predated the strike. "Thirty sanitation workers are supposed to show up... even before the strike, hardly a dozen would... We have been telling the MCG to hand over sanitation functions to us, like they have done for parks," she said.

Bhawani Shankar Tripathy, a resident of Sector 23A, said the area had become a "stinking mess".

"There is a risk of disease... We are tired of repeatedly tel-

ling the jurisdictional engineers and senior MCG officials of the situation."

'Cannot raise families on Rs 18,000'

For the protesting workers outside the old MCG office, the strike is against conditions that have made their jobs increasingly precarious.

"I supervise 13 workers at Sector 40; our team is responsible for the area's cleanliness. We do not want to cause inconvenience to the public, but we have been left with no choice," said Tej Pal, a contractual sanitation supervisor.

"Currently, we earn just Rs 18,000 to Rs 19,000 a month. In a city like Gurgaon, it is impossible to raise children, pay rent, and run a household on these wages. We only want our jobs regularised, basic dignity, and wages so we can return to work and serve the city," he added.

On the garbage crisis, Pal said workers also wanted the strike to end, but maintained

that the government first needed to act on their demands.

A 17-point dispute

Union leaders said the May 13 agreement covered 17 demands, including regularisation of 13,000 contractual municipal workers and 175 fire personnel; scrapping private outsourcing and bringing sanitation staff directly onto department rolls; and reinstatement of 3,480 retrenched sanitation workers in Gurgaon.

The demands also include a monthly risk allowance of Rs 5,000, uniform allowances, medical coverage, revised ex-gratia provisions and a Rs 5 lakh retirement gratuity for eligible contractual staff.

"For over a decade, successive administrations have avoided permanent recruitments, forcing workers into precarious conditions under private contractors," alleged Basant Kumar, state vice-president of the Nagar Palika Karamchari Sangh.

• Skywatch

Forecast: August 27, 2026
Cloudy sky. Light rain during morning, forenoon.
MAX: 33-35
0.9°C above normal
MIN: 25-27
0.6°C above normal
• Sunrise: 5:57 am (August 28)
• Sunset: 6:48 pm (August 28)
• Moonrise: 6:23 pm (August 27)
• Moonset: 5:52 am (August 28)

• AQI Tracker

Delhi Cantt
Good
AQI: 28
Najafgarh
Satisfactory
AQI: 77
Bawana
Moderate
AQI: 155
Anand Vihar
Poor
AQI: 231
● Good (0-50)
● Satisfactory (51-100)
● Moderate (101-200)
● Poor (201-300)
● Very Poor (301-400)
● Severe (401-500)

• DELHI LAKSHMI YOJANA: SANCTION LETTERS DISTRIBUTED

A small fund of their own: Women in Capital look forward to monthly aid

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 26

FOR YEARS, 35-year-old Renu has spent what she earns on her family. On Wednesday, as she sat among hundreds of women at Talkatora Stadium, she found herself thinking about what she might finally buy for herself.

A domestic help who earns Rs 8,000 a month, Renu was the only woman from the 300 servant quarters in Pandara Road selected to attend the distribution of sanction letters for the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana on Wednesday.

"I have not decided yet what I will do with the money. Let it come into our account first, then I will believe it," says Renu,

whose husband, who does odd jobs, earns roughly Rs 15,000 a month.

As Renu spoke to other women around her, she realised they had something else in common. They too spent whatever they earned on their husbands, children and household needs.

But this time, they might keep a little for themselves. Renu may buy a suit for herself with the money.

The Delhi government on Wednesday launched Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, one of its key poll promises from last year's Assembly elections, when the BJP returned to power in the Capital after nearly three decades.

Chief Minister Rekha



CM Rekha Gupta with beneficiaries of Lakshmi Yojana at an official letter distribution ceremony at Talkatora Stadium in New Delhi on Wednesday. LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu and other leaders were also present.

Gupta, Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, union Minister and Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra and other ministers symbolically handed sanction letters to 65 women. Around 4,100 beneficiaries attended the event.

Under the scheme, women aged 21 to 60 will receive Rs 2,500 a month from September 1. Of this, Rs 1,000 will be available through a digital wallet for spending, while Rs 1,500 will go towards a Fixed Deposit or Recurring Deposit to build savings.

For 40-year-old Roopa Saini, who runs a small tailoring shop in Palam, the money means she may finally be able to save.

"My husband is a contractor, but work has been irregular. I earn Rs 12,000 every month

from my shop, of which Rs 8,000 goes towards rent. The rest is spent on household items... We are not able to save for an emergency," Roopa says.

For 42-year-old Anuradha Devi, the assistance will help with medical expenses.

Her husband works as a security guard and earns around Rs 15,000 a month. Recently, she was diagnosed with spinal issues and a partially blocked vein in her brain. "I get treated in a government hospital, but we have to buy medicines from outside... We have been borrowing from friends and family," Anuradha says.

She hopes to repay those loans with the savings she builds through the scheme.

The government said 9.22

lakh women had registered for the scheme and around 6.6 lakh had submitted their final applications by Tuesday.

According to the Chief Minister, the scheme was aimed at giving women financial security and greater confidence to make their own decisions.

But for some beneficiaries, the monthly assistance is only part of what they want from the government.

Sangam Vihar resident Anjum Gupta (37) says while the money would help with daily expenses, better public services would make a bigger difference.

"The government should focus on improving schools and hospitals. That will ease our burden even more," she says.

'Highly malicious, motivated': India rejects UN rights panel's findings

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 26

INDIA ON Wednesday rejected a report by a UN panel that alleged discrimination against various ethnic and religious groups in the country.

The UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (UN-CERD) on Tuesday flagged concerns over human rights violations against people belonging to scheduled tribes, scheduled castes and Rohingya refugees in India.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India rejects "any politically motivated highly malicious references in the report with all the contempt that it deserves".

He said India's commitment to combating racial discrimination "remains unwavering". During the review, he highlighted India's constitutional safeguards, robust legal framework, pluralism and sustained efforts to protect disadvantaged communities," he said.

"While we will respond to the committee's observations through the established procedure, the inter-ministerial delegation, which was led by the Solicitor General of India, Tushar Mehta, had already rejected the generalisations, unsubstantiated allegations, or tendency to exceed the Convention's mandate during the review meeting," Jaiswal added.

The UN human rights panel had raised concerns about violations against marginalised communities in India, and urged New Delhi to protect them from alleged abuse, torture, extrajudicial killings, and stripping of citizenship.

It also sharply criticised the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in Assam, and raised concerns about the subjecting of Bengali-speaking Muslims to "systematic and structural racial discrimination".

It had called for India to suspend the NRC and review its legislative framework.

India & UK to ink pact, develop propulsion systems for Navy

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 26

INDIA AND the UK are "very soon" set to sign an inter-governmental Agreement (IGA) aimed at developing maritime electric propulsion systems for four Landing Platform Docks (LPDs) for the Indian Navy, British officials said Wednesday.

They also indicated that a second inter-governmental agreement between the countries is set to be inked soon for the procurement of British Lightweight Multirole Missiles (LMMs) for the Indian Army.

Responding to a question from The Indian Express, a top British official said an IGA for the maritime electric propulsion system for four LPDs will be signed "very shortly".

As part of the collaboration, GE Vernova and Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd will establish India's first maritime Land-Based Testing Facility to support the development of the Integrated Full Electric Propulsion (IFEP) system.

Indian warships at present do not have electric propulsion systems. They are currently powered by diesel engines, gas turbines or steam turbines. The Queen Elizabeth-class aircraft carriers of the UK Royal Navy are integrated full electric propulsion vessels.

The electric propulsion capability is meant to power bigger warships of the Indian Navy, with a displacement of over 6,000 tonnes and will be first tested on Landing Platform Docks.

A joint statement issued by both countries in November last year highlighted the intent to finalise the IGA for maritime electric propulsion systems.

The official quoted above said that negotiations and working groups have been on-going and have been productive, adding that both sides have also been in talks over in-

development of the Integrated Full Electric Propulsion (IFEP) system.

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A second agreement between the two will see the procurement of British Lightweight Multirole Missiles for the Indian Army

India's naval fleet modernisation programme, which will also include retrofitting of certain legacy ships with electric propulsion systems, aside from looking at other modern warships of the Indian Navy.

A Statement of Intent (SoI) on Cooperation on Design and Development of Electric Propulsion Systems for the Indian Navy was signed by India and the UK in Portsmouth on 28 November, 2024, during the third meeting of the Joint Working Group on Electric Propulsion Capability Partnership.

A government statement at the time mentioned that the SoI provided a framework for cooperation in the co-design, co-creation and co-production of electric-propulsion capabil-

ities for future Indian vessels. On the deal for LMMs, British officials said hundreds are set to be procured by India—as compared to October, when both sides had signed a 350-million-pound (\$468 million) contract to supply the Indian Army with the missiles.

The announcement was made during former British Prime Minister Keir Starmer's India visit.

The India-UK joint statement, issued in October 2025, stated that both sides have agreed to proceed via the government-to-government route on an initial supply of LMM systems. "This will further support India's air defence capabilities and, in the spirit of Atmanirbhar Bharat, meet the current

and future requirements of the Indian Ministry of Defence, and support a long-term collaboration on complex weapons between the two countries," it had stated.

According to Thales UK, the LMMs are equipped with a triple-effect warhead and proximity fuse, and thus respond to various threats like light-armoured, wheeled and tracked vehicles or aerial platforms.

The missiles weigh 13kg, have an range of over 6 km and a velocity of Mach 15.

They can address various surface threats, from vehicles to static installations and provide surface-to-air capability targeting UAS and helicopters. It can provide very fast re-engagement and fire-on-the-move capability, and is available on shoulder launch, tripod and vehicle configurations, Thales stated.

The signing of the order will make India one of the largest customers of the missile.



Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu speaks during the Monsoon Session of Assembly, in Shimla, Wednesday.

'No child to be identified by caste': Himachal CM orders column removal from admission forms

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, August 26

CHIEF MINISTER Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Wednesday directed the state education department to remove the 'caste' column from admission forms in all state-run schools from the next academic session.

"The government is committed to eliminating caste-based discrimination in society and promoting fraternity and equality, and the removal of the caste column would be a step in this direction," Sukhu said.

The new system will be implemented from the academic session 2027-28, the CM said, adding, "We are looking to curb casteism from the grassroots level up. No child should be identified by his or her caste in schools."

Sukhu issued the direction while chairing a meeting of the Himachal Pradesh Scheduled Caste Welfare Board in Shimla.

Further, he clarified that the removal of the caste column from admission forms would not deprive eligible students belonging to Scheduled Castes and other socially and educationally backward sections of welfare schemes.

Secretary (Education) Rakesh Kanwar said the department would soon formulate a detailed policy and mechanism

Anthem row: BJP moves privilege notice against Sukhu

THE BJP on Wednesday submitted a notice for breach of privilege against Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu for making false allegation that the Opposition members disrespected the national anthem on the opening day of the monsoon session.

Leader of Opposition Jai Ram Thakur said the party would withdraw the motion if CM tenders an apology. Meanwhile, Sukhu reiterated his stance and announced that the Congress would bring a breach of privilege motion against Opposition members. ENs

for implementing the policy. "The CM has taken a decision. A policy will be chalked out to implement it," he said.

The move is expected to require changes in the admission process and related school records while ensuring that caste-related details, whether legally or administratively required for extending welfare benefits, remains accessible.

DA arrears, OPS: Punjab braces for 'Maha Hartal' by govt staff

Raakhi Jagga
Patiala, August 26

A SCHEDULED meeting with Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann over their demands notwithstanding, government employees in Punjab will proceed ahead with a 'Maha Hartal' on Thursday.

The Sanjha Mulazam Manch and Sanjha Mulazam and Pensioners' Front have called the hartal. It is expected to disrupt functioning across departments, with employees in Deputy Commissioner and tehsil offices, directorates, the Punjab Civil Secretariat, schools, colleges, hospitals and other government establishments joining the agitation.

The principal demand is the release of pending DA arrears, which employee unions say have remained unpaid since January 2023. The state gov-

ernment employees currently receive 22% DA, against 60% for central government employees and that of the neighbouring Haryana.

The restoration of the old pension scheme (OPS) also features among their demands.

Earlier, the Punjab and Haryana High Court had directed the Punjab government to release the pending DA. The state subsequently challenged the decision before a single bench, which upheld the judge's order and directed the state to clear the arrears within 15 days.

That deadline is over, invoking a contempt petition.

The 'Maha Hartal' call, the organisers said, is limited to government departments, meaning markets, highways and private establishments are expected to function normally.

Under the banner of the Punjab State Ministerial Ser-



Government staffers in Faridkot submit mass casual leave letter to Keshav Goyal, ADC (General), Faridkot, on Wednesday.

vices Union (PSMSU), Category II, III and IV employees in all 23 DC offices and 78 tehsil offices will participate. Employees in around 40 directorates and the Punjab Civil Secretariat in Chandigarh are also set to join.

The agitation has received support from the farmer organisations, including the Sa-

myukta Kisan Morcha and Kisan Mazdoor Morcha.

The Punjab Civil Medical Services (PCMS) Association, too, has backed it. "OPDs will remain closed in all government hospitals. However, doctors will remain present and cater to emergency services and at mother-and-child hos-

pitals," said its state vice-president Dr Inder Manjit Singh. Nursing, paramedical and Class IV employees in government hospitals will also join.

The functioning of the state-run schools is expected to be affected, with a large number of teachers planning to take mass casual leave. One lakh teachers work in over 19,000 schools in Punjab.

Transport services could also be affected, with regular employees of Punjab Roadways and PPSU Roadways expected to participate. Sources said some outsourced employees and drivers attached to VIPs and MLAs could also join.

Meanwhile, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema said employees have the right to protest, "but the CM is reaching out to the employees and I am sure some positive will come out of their meeting."

ADVERTORIAL

A Legends in Healthcare feature

Dr. Nishant Nagpal has spent over 18 years inside the gut, literally. As Director of Gastroenterology at Fortis Hospital, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi, he has performed more than 25,000 therapeutic endoscopic procedures, ranging from routine gastroscopy and colonoscopy to advanced interventions like ERCP, endoscopic ultrasound (EUS), enteroscopy, and POEM (per-oral endoscopic myotomy), a minimally invasive procedure that has replaced major surgery for certain esophageal disorders. A graduate of Manipal Academy of Higher Education (MBBS, MD – General Medicine) with a DNB in Gastroenterology from Army Hospital (Research & Referral), New Delhi, he is a member of the Delhi Medical Council, the Delhi Medical Association, and the Indian Society of Gastroenterology/American College of Gastroenterology Society GEI.

Dr. Nagpal doesn't mince words about what he sees in his clinic every day: a generation of Indians, increasingly young and urban, developing gastrointestinal and liver diseases once seen mainly in older patients. Nearly half of Delhi NCR, he says, is now estimated to be living with fatty liver disease, most without knowing it. Diabetes affects roughly one in three residents. Fatty liver is showing up in South Delhi schoolchildren at rates as high as 50-60%. What follows is an edited, condensed transcript.

WARNING SIGNS

Gastro issues are often dismissed as "just acidity." What are the warning signs people should never ignore?

Always be precise with your doctor. "Just acidity" means different things to different patients — burning, bloating, discomfort while passing stool are all lumped under one word. Describe your symptom clearly; don't label it.

As per the medical science — unintentional weight loss, blood in the stools, or black, tarry, foul-smelling stools all point to something significant happening inside the gut, possibly a bleed. Persistent, progressive difficulty swallowing, worse with solids than liquids, can signal a mechanical blockage in the esophagus, potentially marking esophageal cancer, and needs immediate attention. Persistent vomiting, night-time abdominal pain, and unexplained anemia are red flags too.

There's a specific pattern I'd flag: a change in bowel habits lasting more than two to three weeks, combined with reduced food intake and iron deficiency anemia. That combination, especially with weight loss and dark stools, points to colon cancer until proven otherwise.

"Iron deficiency anemia, with weight loss, and with black or dark stools, that means colon cancer until proven otherwise. These should not be ignored."

WHY IT'S HAPPENING — AND HAPPENING YOUNGER

Digestive disorders are rising sharply among younger, urban people. What's driving this?

The pattern is clear: these disorders are rising among the young, and more so in cities than in villages. Something about urban life is responsible: erratic eating times, long commutes, shift work, common across

EXCELLENCE IN Healthcare

"The Gut Talks to You Long Before It Screams": Dr. Nishant Nagpal on India's Silent Digestive Health Crisis

Delhi NCR, and a culture that doesn't sleep enough, layered with ultra-processed, high-glycemic food, sedentary jobs, and stress that never switches off. There's a circadian rhythm to our digestive enzymes. Eating irregularly, or sleeping immediately after a meal, disrupts it and leads to IBS, fatty liver, acidity, and bloating. Casual antibiotic use, inconsistent water quality, smoking, and alcohol keep the gut microbiome under constant siege. The result: people are developing GERD, IBS, and fatty liver in their twenties, a decade or more earlier than previously observed.

How much of this is genetics versus lifestyle?

Genetics loads the gun, lifestyle pulls the trigger. Indians tend to develop fatty liver or cardiac disease at a lower BMI than Western populations; that's genetic predisposition. But poor eating, sedentary habits, and ultra-processed food push the age of onset much earlier. Roughly 20-30% is genetic, 70-80% is modifiable. That's exactly why there's hope: most of what's driving this epidemic is something we can change.

"Genetics loads the gun, lifestyle pulls the trigger." In Delhi NCR, roughly one-third of the population is estimated to have diabetes, and half of them don't know it. Nearly half has fatty liver disease, again mostly unaware. Data from South Delhi schools shows fatty liver prevalence as high as 50-60% among children, with regional prevalence of 20-30% for fatty liver and IBS-type conditions in kids. We're raising a generation that will be fighting these diseases as adults. Parents, doctors, and society—all of us have become somewhat helpless against technology and modern lifestyle pressures. We need to act before this becomes irreversible.

PREVENTION, SCREENING, AND WHAT'S CHANGED

Are more patients coming in for preventive screening rather than only after symptoms appear?

Yes, and that's encouraging. Social media awareness, family history of colorectal cancer, and people in their 40s turning more health-conscious post-COVID have all played a role. When someone in an office or family has a cardiac episode or cancer diagnosis, the entire family often comes in for checkups. Corporate wellness programs and insurance riders



In conversation with **Dr. Nishant Nagpal**, Director – Gastroenterology at **Fortis Hospital, Vasant Kunj**, on why digestive disease is striking Indians younger than ever, what symptoms should never be dismissed as "just acidity," and why the next decade will test the health of an entire generation.

covering screening endoscopies have helped too.

My concern is that we should build incentives around staying healthy, rather than tying career growth only to performance. Japan's "Metabo Law" is worth looking up; past a certain age, if waist circumference crosses a threshold, dietary counselling and lifestyle correction kick in. We need something similar here—

because without health, none of our other ambitions matter.

"If health is gone, everything is gone."

How have advances in gastroenterology changed patient outcomes?

Enormously. Zoom and magnification (NB) endoscopy lets us pick up mucosal changes early, diagnosing cancer and precancerous changes far sooner than before. Endoscopy, once mainly diagnostic, can now treat almost every kind of bleed and manage early gastric cancers through endoscopic submucosal dissection and resection. Endoscopic ultrasound lets us sample tissue that once required surgery.

POEM has turned achalasia cardia from major surgery into a next-day-discharge procedure. Capsule endoscopy and manometry let us evaluate the small bowel non-invasively. And FibroScan, a two-minute test measuring liver fat and fibrosis, has become widely available given how common liver disease now is. We have a complete toolkit for prevention, treatment, and palliative care that simply didn't exist for earlier generations.

GUT HEALTH, PROBIOTICS, AND SOCIAL MEDIA Is the social media buzz around probiotics backed by science?

There is real science, but a lot gets lost by the time it reaches Instagram. Probiotics are living organisms, not drugs, so they aren't regulated like pharmaceuticals; anyone can market a proprietary strain as the next big thing. There's solid research on specific strains, for antibiotic-associated diarrhea, for IBS, and combinations like VSL#3 and Saccharomyces boulardii. But that data doesn't automatically apply to any product on a shelf.

My honest advice: look at India's own regional traditions. Homemade curd, Punjab's chaas, Gujarat's fermented chutneys, the Northeast's fermented bamboo shoot preparations, and seasonal low-oil pickles are time-tested and linked to gut health, immunity, and mood. Don't blindly trust every influencer touting the latest concoction; trust the well-defined, time-tested things instead.

MYTHS THAT WON'T GO AWAY

What myths do you correct most often?

First, "gas"—pain around the navel is often small bowel colic, not gas; the umbilicus is fixed, it's the intestine behind it that's inflamed. Second, spicy food doesn't cause ulcers on its own; H. pylori, smoking, and NSAID overuse are the real culprits. Spice can aggravate an existing ulcer, but it can't create one.

"Spicy food alone doesn't cause ulcers. H. pylori, smoking, and painkiller overuse are the real culprits; spice can aggravate an existing ulcer, but it can't create one."

Third, skipping meals doesn't heal the stomach; it worsens acidity. Fourth, "natural" herbal remedies aren't automatically safe; several unregulated products have well-documented links to drug-induced liver injury and gastric ulcers when overused. And finally, endoscopy isn't the ordeal people imagine; with sedation, it's a safe, quick procedure with rare side effects.

One more habit worth flagging: self-medicating with antacids for months without addressing the underlying cause. This can let ulcers, H. pylori infection, or early cancer progress silently, while long-term PPI use carries its own risks: poorer bone health, disrupted gut microbiota, and higher infection risk.

WHO SHOULD GET SCREENED AND WHEN

Which age groups or risk factors should prompt a routine checkup, even without symptoms?

Globally, anyone above 45 should discuss colorectal cancer screening with their doctor. With a family history of colon cancer, start ten years before the age at which the relative was diagnosed. Patients with obesity, diabetes, or metabolic syndrome should get a liver check regardless of symptoms, as fatty liver is present in nearly half our population.

A family history of gastric cancer, inflammatory bowel disease, celiac disease, or hepatitis B, hepatitis C, or autoimmune liver disease is reason enough to consider periodic screening, since these conditions tend to run in families.

THE TAKEAWAY

What's your one key message to readers about digestive health?

Your gut talks to you long before it screams. Come in when symptoms are mild, don't wait until they've crossed a line. Any persistent symptom lasting beyond two to three weeks, or any of the alarm symptoms we've discussed, deserves a specialist's attention, not a home remedy, and not a suggestion from the nearby pharmacist.

Digestive health isn't just about avoiding discomfort. It's often an early window into your overall metabolic health. Don't ignore it.

This interview has been edited and condensed for length and clarity as part of the Legends in Healthcare series, in partnership with Fortis Hospital, Vasant Kunj.



Critics, Clarity

WITH NEW YORK City Mayor Zohran Mamdani opposing Mohan Bhagwat's Madison Square Garden event and describing the RSS's vision as "exclusionary", the Sangh appears to have chosen dialogue as its response. In a statement, RSS prachar pramukh Sunil Ambekar described Bhagwat's August 29 event as an "interfaith gathering" rooted in "open dialogue and mutual respect". He also extended an invitation to anyone interested in understanding the RSS's "vision and philosophy" to "attend the event in open forums. The message is that the Sangh wants its critics — and the curious — to come and hear it out.

New Initiative

THE AGRICULTURE Ministry's pro-Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan has launched a new initiative — "Know Your Ministry" — to improve coordination and understanding among its officials. Under the initiative, officers from different divisions make presentations every week outlining their roles, responsibilities and key areas of work. According to sources, the initiative is aimed at familiarising officials with the functioning and contribution of the ministry's various divisions.

Two more Opp MPs write to Birla over 'bid' to evict Mahua from circuit house

New Delhi: Two more opposition MPs have written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla over Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra allegedly being asked to vacate a circuit house in West Bengal late at night, seeking a reference of the matter to the Committee of Privileges. Congress MP K Suresh and AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh are the latest to approach Birla over the August 14 incident. Before them, Samajwadi Party MP Dharmendra Yadav, NCP (SP) MP Supriya Sule, Shiv Sena (UPT) MP Arvind Sawant and CPI MP K Radhakrishnan had written to Birla, seeking an inquiry and action against the officials involved. Suresh termed the incident an "unequivocal breach of parliamentary privilege" and said it also posed a threat to Moitra's personal safety. Suresh pointed out that a crowd had gathered outside the circuit house gates, shouting hostile slogans. PTI

AMERICAN SINGER MARY MILLBEN DEFENDS THE RALLY — TO BE HELD AT MADISON SQUARE GARDEN

NYC Mayor Mamdani opposes RSS chief Bhagwat's Aug 29 event

Yoshita Singh
New York, August 26

NEW YORK City Mayor Zohran Mamdani has said he does not support the planned event at Madison Square Garden featuring RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, who is scheduled to address the Indian diaspora later this week. Mamdani, however, noted that the city may not have jurisdiction to cancel the "private" event. Bhagwat, who arrived in the US on Tuesday, is visiting the country as part of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's (RSS) century-year global outreach programme. His outreach tour also includes Canada and the UK.

In the US, he is scheduled to address a gathering of around 5,000 people at the iconic Madison Square Garden (MSG) on August 29.

The planned appearance has drawn criticism from several civil rights organisations. The Indian Overseas Congress,

which is an international arm of the Congress party, has questioned the RSS's effort to project itself to American audiences as a cultural body promoting "universal oneness" and "civillisation dialogue".

On Tuesday, responding to a question during a press conference on the RSS chief's planned event and protests against it, Mamdani said, "I don't support the rally, but I don't know if the city has any jurisdiction on cancelling a private event."

Mamdani, who described himself as the first Indian-American mayor in New York City's (NYC) history, said his mother's family is still in India. He said the vision of India he was taught by his family and grew up familiar with was that of "a pluralistic society" and "a secular republic" that believed in the belonging of each and every person from India.

The 34-year-old NYC mayor said it had been "incredibly



"I don't support the rally, but I don't know if the city has any jurisdiction on cancelling a private event"

ZOHRAN MAMDANI,
MAYOR, NEW YORK CITY.

troubling" to see the rise of a movement based on an "exclusionary vision", without specifying elaborating on the context of his observation.

He said he was in "deep opposition" to it both as an Indian-American and as mayor of a city

that believes deeply in the belonging of every person, regardless of their colour, creed, religion, faith or where they are from. Several interfaith and civil rights organisations — which include Hindus for Human Rights, Indian American Muslim Council and Interfaith Centre of New York, among others — have opposed Bhagwat's planned appearance at the MSG and urged the iconic venue to cancel the event.

AHEAD Forum, a public policy and research trust, is hosting Bhagwat in the US, with its planned programmes under the banner of "Universal Oneness Celebration". It said in a social media post that the RSS chief's visit "carries a timeless and universal message: The world is one family", as it called upon people to look beyond "artificial divisions and differences".

Bhagwat's ongoing foreign visit is aimed at presenting a "factual and positive perspective on India, Hindu society and

the RSS", the organisation's joint general secretary C R Murkunda said in a press conference in Visakhapatnam last week.

In a statement, the Indian Overseas Congress's US chapter (IOCUSA) on Tuesday said the RSS could not be evaluated merely through the language used during an overseas public relations campaign and argued that its ideological record also needed to be considered.

"Hinduism, one of the world's great and ancient religious traditions, must not be confused with Hindutva political ideology," it said.

Meanwhile, American singer Mary Millben has criticised Mamdani for opposing the Bhagwat event. "Mamdani and all these socialist nuts are opposing the Madison Square Garden (MSG) event featuring Mohan Bhagwat because they oppose PM @narendramodi and the @BJP4India," Millben said in a post on X. PTI

'BJP is turning police into weapons to evade accountability': Rahul on Bihar stir

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 26



Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi

LOK SABHA Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday hit out at the BJP-led government in Bihar over the student protests in the state, and accused the government of weaponising the police to evade accountability.

Students and job aspirants in Bihar are protesting at Gardanibagh over recruitment examinations and government jobs. The protesters' demands include a proposed fourth Teacher Recruitment Examination (TRE-4), including a single-stage PT-mains examination, removal of negative marking, and 100% domicile-based recruitment.

Gandhi said the students in Bihar have a very straightforward question: "Why are there irregularities in recruitment exams? Why no action on allegations of paper leaks? And how long will this tampering with the future of the youth continue?" he said in a post on X.

"The controversy over BPSC (Bihar Public Service Commission) exams is not of today. Students have been on the streets for a long time over the recruitment process, exam patterns, delays, and transparency. But instead of answering (them), what is the government doing? It's wielding batons and water cannons. It's taking students into custody,"

In Siwan, there was even firing on protesters with an AK-47, he said.

"This is not just a question of police action; this is a question of the mindset of the BJP government, which has no answers. That is why it is turning the police into a weapon to evade accountability," Gandhi added, in a post on X in Hindi. "You can't snatch away someone's future by instilling fear. The students of Bihar will keep asking questions. And now, it's not just answers they want; they demand accountability," Gandhi said.

Fresh tensions had broken out in Patna on Tuesday (August 25) as hundreds of protesters marched from Gandhi Maidan towards Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary's residence, breaking through barricades and clashing with security personnel at Dak Bungal Chowk.

BJP showcase to MLA over remarks on Union Minister

Press Trust of India
Kolkata, August 26

THE STATE BJP unit on Wednesday issued a notice to the party's Gangarampur MLA Sayendra Nath Roy for allegedly making controversial social media remarks against Union Minister and Balurghat MP Sukanta Majumdar.

Roy was served the notice by state BJP disciplinary committee head Pratap Banerjee who gave the accused MLA a week's deadline to provide a written explanation. "Your immoral social media remarks against the honourable Union minister are shameful and violate the party's constitution. They have resulted in a loss of face of the party," the notice said. It was issued in response to a video message Roy

recently posted on his Facebook timeline, the authenticity of which PTI couldn't verify, where he questioned party dynamics in Dalkish Dinajpur district and alleged a "close and cozy relationship" between Majumdar and the district's TMC MLA Biplob Mitra, while claiming some BJP members had "secret ties" with the Trinamool Congress.

Roy alleged that the two leaders share a relationship equivalent to that of "maternal cousins". The MLA's remarks came in the wake of Mitra allegedly praising Majumdar for his development activities in the district at one of TMC's recent district-level meetings.

Mitra has shifted allegiance from the Mamata Banerjee-led wing to the dissident Ritabrata Banerjee faction of the party.

Karnataka minister set to step down as Congress looks to preempt BJP's moves

Johnson T A
Bengaluru, August 26

WITH THE Opposition BJP in Karnataka announcing a 170 km padyatra from Raichur to Ballari from September 1 to demand the resignation of Planning and Statistics Minister B Nagendra over an alleged corruption case being probed by the CBI, the ruling Congress is set to clinch his resignation ahead of the BJP march.

The indications of Nagendra's exit emerged Wednesday when he reportedly called up Chief Minister D K Shivakumar to offer his resignation in the Congress's interest. "Everybody in our party is a disciplined soldier, be it an MLA or a minister. All of them are very disciplined. This is what I can say," Shivakumar said in a cryptic reference to Nagendra's reported offer to resign.

On his part, Nagendra denied that he called the CM. "The reports currently being aired in the media are completely untrue. I have not received any call from the CM's Office, and there has been no discussion regarding any resignation. I request your cooperation," his office said in a statement.

However, the Congress dispensation's bid to secure the resignation of Nagendra — who was inducted into the Shivakumar Cabinet on August 3 — is a clear shift from its stand during a disrupted monsoon session of the state Legislature when the party had claimed it would not relent on the BJP's demand for his removal.

The Congress's changed approach was seen as a clear message. "He sat for hours and listened to each of the new office-bearers. He made them talk about themselves and how they came up in the party," said a leader who was at the meeting.

"PM saab has always been clear. He had told us earlier that while the angst against the UPA brought us into power in 2014, it was the initiatives taken for the poor and the country's security that brought us back in 2019. In 2023, he told us that the BJP had to fight the Lok Sabha election on organisational



Karnataka's Planning and Statistics Minister B Nagendra

ister to the State Cabinet for its approval in the coming days.

While the BJP's threat of stealing the new Congress CM's thunder by launching a padyatra, coupled with the Governor's possible move, could be the apparent motive for Nagendra's offer to resign, the development may also facilitate changes in the Cabinet, which currently does not have any woman minister even as ex-CM Siddaramaiah has called for induction of an OBC leader.

The expected resignation of Nagendra, a Scheduled Tribe (ST) Valmiki Nayak leader from Ballari, may allow the Congress to replace him with Annapurna Tukaram in the Shivakumar Cabinet, who is a first time woman MLA from Ballari. She also belongs to the ST Valmiki Nayak community.

The minor Cabinet rejig may also involve the induction of a Siddaramaiah's nominee — Byadgi MLA Basavaraj Shivapannavar or Bengaluru MLA M Krishnappa — into a remaining vacant slot. Shivakumar is likely to visit Delhi on Thursday to meet the Congress top brass to discuss Nagendra's resignation besides the need to fill up the vacant ministerial berth.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Chirag Paswan constitutes new team with eye on Gen Z voters

Santosh Singh
Patna, August 26

THE LOK Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) on Wednesday announced its new over 100-member national executive committee, blending experience with younger leaders and grassroots workers as it prepares for Assembly elections in seven states in the near future. The changes reflect the party's efforts to expand its footprint beyond Bihar and strengthen its appeal among younger voters.

While the party appointed Surendra Vivek new state president for Bihar, Samastipur MP Shambhavi Choudhary was made head of its student wing. LJP (RV) national spokesperson Vineet Singh told *The Indian Express*, "The new team reflects new energy, new outlook and loads of creativity. We have got new faces while maintaining balance with a good deal of experience as well. With polls due in seven states in 2027, the new team is also in sync with our expansion plan."

Union Minister and LJP (RV) chief Chirag Paswan retained his positions as national president and chairman of the party's parliamentary board, while veteran leader Abdul Khaliq continued as national general secretary. Khaliq has been a long-time party loyalist, dating back to the tenure of Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) founder and patron Ram Vilas Paswan.

The restructuring comes at a time when Chirag has also been seeking to project himself more actively on issues beyond electoral politics. He recently visited protesters in Bihar, signalling the party's intent to remain connected with grassroots concerns as it expands its political campaign.

Vivek, an engineer by train-



Union Minister Chirag Paswan meets a delegation led by Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and LJP MP Rajesh Verma, at Lok Sevak Awas, in Patna, on Tuesday. ANI

ing who unsuccessfully contested the 2025 Bihar Assembly polls, replaced MLA Raju Tiwari as the new Bihar state president. Tiwari has been inducted into the national team as one of 12 national general secretaries.

The choice of Vivek, who belongs to the Bhumihar community, reflects the party's aspiration to maintain its social balance while retaining its core Dalit support base. Vivek has risen through the party ranks, and his appointment signals a targeted push to strengthen the LJP (RV)'s presence in Bihar's evolving political landscape.

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Bihar's 'Police Didis' get scooters to boost women's safety

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 26

BIHAR ON Wednesday flagged off 4,700 two-wheelers for the police's 'Abhaya Brigade', commonly called Police Didis, with the state government saying the deployment will strengthen patrolling around schools, colleges and other areas frequented by women and girl students. CM Samrat Choudhary launched the vehicles at an event at Gyan Bhawan in Patna

ahead of Raksha Bandhan. Of the 4,700 vehicles, 2,700 scooters were allocated to women police personnel and 2,000 motorcycles to male constables, according to the Home Department.

Director General of Police Vinay Kumar said women's safety was "the most important responsibility of the police." He said nearly 40,000 women had joined and been trained in the police force and were deployed across districts.



2,700 scooters have been given to women police personnel. ANI

"The new vehicles will allow women police personnel to conduct dedicated patrols, par-

ticularly around educational institutions. Our focus will largely be on schools, colleges and university campuses where our girls go to study, and also on adjoining areas," the police chief said.

He said two-hour beats had been fixed across cities, centred on colleges, with patrol timings adjusted to coincide with school timings and college dispersal hours. "At other times, when educational institutions are closed, the teams would patrol

surrounding areas," the DGP added. Around 4,700 scooters and motorcycles were being sent out from Patna, with districts receiving different numbers of vehicles.

The Abhaya Brigade was announced by the Bihar Police Headquarters in December 2025 after then Home Minister Samrat Choudhary, soon after taking charge of the portfolio, said special squads would be deployed outside schools and colleges to curb eve-teasing.

PM GIVES PARTY'S NEW OFFICE-BEARERS A PEP TALK, ADVISES THEM AGAINST ANY COMPLACENCY: 'THIS MESSAGE WAS THAT ... WE CANNOT TAKE OUR WINS FOR GRANTED'

Is BJP feeling uneasy? Uncertainty within party ranks, Gen Z on the ground

CAPITAL CONTEXT
BY LIZ MATHEW

A WEEKLY LOOK AT POLITICS IN A STATE FROM THE VANTAGE POINT OF NEW DELHI

AS THE BJP's new national office-bearers gathered at the party's national headquarters in Delhi last week for a closed-door meeting, the mood in the room was far from triumphant.

The leaders met with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and party president Nitin Nabin to discuss the new plan of action. Modi struck a mild but firm note, advising the office-bearers not to grow complacent on the back of repeated electoral wins in the last couple of years, sources said. Nabin, they

added, cautioned that power had created a distance between the party's leaders and people.

The leaders who were at the briefing in Delhi said the PM exuded confidence about the new team and had sent out a clear message. "He sat for hours and listened to each of the new office-bearers. He made them talk about themselves and how they came up in the party," said a leader who was at the meeting.

"PM saab has always been clear. He had told us earlier that while the angst against the UPA brought us into power in 2014, it was the initiatives taken for the poor and the country's security that brought us back in 2019. In 2023, he told us that the BJP had to fight the Lok Sabha election on organisational

strength. His message was that the party leaders and the cadre have to be back at the forefront and we cannot take our wins for granted," the leader added.

The meeting came at a time when there is a sense of growing unease among sections of the leaders and the cadre in various states.

Some BJP insiders said uncertainty about the new organisational team — it took months for it to be put in place — and the long-spectated government reshuffle had created a climate of uncertainty among senior leader leaders. As one state BJP leader described it, this put several such leaders in a "self-preservation mode," and that indecisiveness percolated down to the states. "With uncertainty and anxiety over one's



Prime Minister Narendra Modi speaks during an organisational meeting chaired by BJP national president Nitin Nabin at the BJP headquarters, in New Delhi. FILE/ANI

own position, each senior leader in the party and the government has been in a self-preservation mode. The fear of change has been hanging over

their head. While governance becomes a casualty, ordinary karyakartas feel frustrated," said the leader.

To add to the BJP's con-

cerns, even the RSS has conveyed the "growing disconnect" and the "fatigue factor" among state leaders, it is learnt.

A senior BJP leader with deep ties to the Sangh said that public venturing by some senior ministers on the Gen Z protests and their issues appeared to have backfired. "When the ministers say the issues raised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and its leaders are correct, but they had ulterior motives, how does such an argument hold? If the issue is correct, how does it matter who raises it? Such responses could create an impression that the party or the government does not have better arguments and the minister's remark would just keep the Opposition

leaders and the critics in the limelight."

Several leaders are also apprehensive about how deployment of Union Ministers to universities will play out. "If a minister visits a university, basically a domain of students and democratic space, a monologue will be disastrous. If he or she enters into a dialogue, each response of the minister may turn into a huge spectacle if it is not handled with care or utmost maturity. It may end up creating scenes for the CJP and other Opposition to target the party and the government," said a leader.

BJP leaders said the party had been receiving feedback along similar lines from across the states on the youth protests

that have now happened in Patna after the CJP-led protests in Delhi and then the demonstrations in Ranchi. Party leaders pointed out that the discourse had shifted to basic issues such as education and jobs. In a state such as Uttar Pradesh, which is slated to hold polls early next year, this anxiety over the Gen Z disconnect has become enmeshed with a larger concern over the internal factionalism and friction along caste lines. In UP, voters in the Gen Z age bracket of 18-29 years are estimated to account for over 20% of the electorate and issues such as alleged irregularities in recruitment exams and unemployment have made them volatile, said BJP leaders from the state.

ALL EYES ON RIVER LEVEL IN GANDAK BASIN AFTER FLASH FLOODS IN NEPAL

Flood alert sounded in Bihar, UP

5,000 evacuated in Bihar, districts in UP on alert; NDRF and SDRF on standby

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 26

AS AN earthquake in Tibet triggers floods in Nepal, the bordering state of Bihar has been put on high alert, with authorities evacuating thousands and keeping its disaster response force on standby.

The earthquake in Tibet triggered an avalanche and flash floods in Nepal's Bhotokoshi river, causing it to surge Wednesday morning, with officials in Bihar anticipating a similar rise in the Gandak, into which the river feeds. Officials in Bihar project a massive inflow of around 250,000 cuces through the Gandak Barrage—a sharp jump from its current discharge rate of 80,000 cuces. All 36 gates of the Gandak Barrage were opened at Valmikinagar "as a precaution", one official said.

A technical team led by a superintendent engineer has also been sent to the barrage from the department headquarters to monitor the situation," the official said. "Warning messages have also been issued to all districts located in the Gandak river basin. Departmental officials have been directed to remain on continuous alert and monitoring, while arrangements have been strengthened for the storage of flood-response materials and continuous inspection of embankments."

In Nepal, the Gandak River—called Narayani there—was at 4.77 metres at the Devghat gauging station. The danger level at the site is 9 metres, while the warning level is 7.30 metres. Officials said that once the water level rises at Devghat, it could take about 35 hours for the increased flow to reach the Gandak Barrage.

The floods could affect districts in West Champaran (Betthar), East Champaran (Motihari), Gopalganj, Saran, Muzaffarpur and Vaishali. Sitamarhi and Sheohar are also being treated as sensitive dis-

tricts. Around 5,000 people were moved from the riverine area of West Champaran, officials said. Another official said floodwaters from Nepal reached the Gandak Barrage at Valmikinagar around 8:30 pm, with the water discharge increasing by approximately 20,000 cuces.

"The water level is expected to reach its peak by around 11 pm, after which the discharge is likely to begin declining. The maximum discharge is expected to remain around 2 lakh cuces." According to the Water Resources Department, the maximum discharge recorded so far this year was 24,000 cuces, on July 14. On September 28, 2024, the discharge had reached 562,500 cuces.

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary also held a separate meeting to review the situation with the Chief Secretary, Principal Secretary of the Disaster Management Department and Secretary of the Water Resources Department.

Meanwhile, the Central Flood Control Cell at Sinhai Bhawan in Patna said it had been activated round the clock. "People can report any flood-related emergency, including embankment seepage, piping, erosion, damage or deliberate damage to embankments on the toll-free number 1800-345-6145," an official said.

The department has also provided the telephone numbers 0612-2206669 and 0612-2215850, and mobile numbers 7463889706 and 7463889707 for information and complaints.

Officials said the "situation is expected to remain normal", but authorities remain on high alert.

In Uttar Pradesh, border districts Maharajganj and Kushinagar have been put on alert. Describing the damage caused by the severe flooding in Nepal as deeply concerning, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath directed the local administration in the two districts to ensure all necessary preparedness measures.



Rescuers use an earthmover to carry a victim to safety along the Trishuli river in Nepal's Nuwakot district. PTI

37 TN pilgrims unaccounted for; 77 Isha group members stranded

Arun Janardhanan
& Nikhila Henry
Chennai, Hyderabad,
August 26

AT LEAST 37 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu remained unaccounted for Wednesday night after a flash flood tore through the Nepal-Tibet border corridor used by Kailash Mansarovar travellers, severing communications and producing contradictory accounts of who was safe.

The flood surged from the Tibetan side into the Bhotokoshi river around 9 am, hitting Nepal's Rasuwa region. At least 46 people died, and nearly 50 were reported missing. Those reported missing included 105 Indian tourists and 37 non-resident Indians; at least 59 Indians were Kailash pilgrims.

By late Wednesday, the status of the Tamil Nadu groups remained unclear, with government sources putting the number of those unaccounted for at between 37 and nearly 50. Tour coordinator Thennarasu told the state government monitoring cell that four groups totalling 106 people from Tamil Nadu had travelled through four agencies. Fifty-seven left through a Kumbakonam operator on August 23 and 49 from Chennai. The state's Commissioner of Rehabilitation and Welfare of Non-Resident Tamils opened 24 hotlines in Kathmandu listed +977 985 131 6807 and +977 970 910 7500 for assistance.

The Kumbakonam contingent comprised 36 women and 21 men from Kumbakonam, Thanjavur, Tiruchi, Cuddalore, Mayiladuthurai, Hosur, Soalgar and Namakkal, among other places. According to the office of Thanjavur Collector R Revathi, 20 people, including 11 women, had been accounted for. "We are awaiting more information," she said. One group of 17 sent an audio message saying it was safe, government sources confirmed. The pilgrims were in three buses, and their agency relayed an unverified report that one had plunged into a gorge.

The 57-person group was travelling from Kathmandu through Syabrubesi toward the Rasuwagadhi-Gyirong border crossing. The state's Commissioner of Rehabilitation and Welfare of Non-Resident Tamils opened 24 hotlines in Kathmandu listed +977 985 131 6807 and +977 970 910 7500 for assistance.

Information on Isha Foundation members
Isha said one of its Kailash groups had been caught in the flooding at Gyirong while returning through immigration, where the building and much of the town appeared to have



Relief supplies and medicines being loaded onto an aircraft as India dispatches 10 tonnes of essentials to support Nepal's response to the devastating floods. PTI

flooded. "There has been no official information on the whereabouts of any of the people who were at the immigration office. We are working with the authorities to see if we can get to the location and stand ready to be part of the rescue efforts, regardless of the risk involved."

Of Isha's 21 groups, 495 people had returned safely, 745 were in Tibet, 148 in Nepal. 77 had been at the immigration centre, and three volunteers were in Timore, Nepal. The statement did not identify how many of the 77 were from Tamil Nadu.

"To the families and loved ones of those in our group and hundreds of others who are affected in the region, I share your pain, and we are sparing no effort during this profoundly difficult time. I am personally in the region to ensure the best can be done in the given circumstances," it said.

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister's

Office said they have directed the senior officials of the Tamil Nadu House in New Delhi to take all necessary actions to swiftly rescue those from the state who have gone missing and to provide the required assistance to those affected.

"In the situation where Tamils stranded in Nepal require help, emergency telephone numbers have been announced to facilitate contact from them or their relatives in Tamil Nadu... Furthermore, through the Ministry of External Affairs and the Indian Embassy in Nepal, information regarding individuals from Tamil Nadu is being obtained, and necessary actions are being swiftly taken to ensure their safety."

However, a top executive from the foundation later said none of the 77 was Indian.

Isha Foundation sends people to the Kailash-Mansarovar pilgrimage every year, the executive said.

"To enrol for the trip, participants have to go through the Isha meditation programme. This batch that had gone missing is from our overseas batch of pilgrims who participate in sacred walks," the executive said. Another employee said the group was at the immigration centre because it was meant to travel back. "They were supposed to travel to Kathmandu from there. They would have returned to their respective homes," the Isha Foundation official said.

Another employee expressed shock at what had transpired. "We have never faced such a dire situation. Our thoughts and prayers are with those who have gone missing and their families," the foundation member said.

• BRIEFLY



Survivors airlifted to safer locations in Nepal on Wednesday. PTI

FOR AREAS ALONG TIBET-NEPAL BORDER

Indian Embassy in China sets up helplines for those stranded

THE INDIAN Embassy in China on Wednesday issued an advisory providing contact points for Indian nationals stranded in flash floods in areas along the Tibet-Nepal border to seek assistance. Nearly 100 people were killed and over 750, including 133 Indian nationals, remain missing after a massive flash flood originating in Tibet swept through central Nepal. Indian nationals can contact Chinese officials on the ground at 0086 139 8999 0012, it said. They can also contact the Embassy of India in Beijing at 0086 185 1428 4905, including through WhatsApp, and the Embassy of India in Kathmandu at +977 985 131 6807 and +977 970 910 7500, both of which can also be contacted through WhatsApp, the mission said. PTI

Andhra pilgrims group stranded in Tibet region

SEVERAL PILGRIMS from Andhra Pradesh are among those stranded in and around Darchen in China's Tibet Autonomous Region after flash floods damaged roads and blocked routes in the region, said a pilgrim from Adoni, Kurnool district on Wednesday. Nivarthi Ranganath Sastri, who is currently in Darchen with his family, said, "Groups associated with the Isha Foundation were also present in the region, with each group having at least 150 members, and that around 15 such groups were operating in the area," Sastri told PTI. PTI

World Bank pledges aid for flood-hit Nepal

THE WORLD Bank on Wednesday offered Nepalese Rs 25 billion in emergency financial aid to flood-hit Nepal for the rescue, relief and reconstruction of affected areas, according to the Ministry of Finance. Soon after news of the flood spread, the World Bank's Country Director for Nepal, David Sleslen, informed Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle that up to NRS. 25 billion could be mobilised from various sources as emergency assistance. India and China have offered relief supplies to support Nepal's response to the flood-affected areas. PTI

Centre keeping a close watch on situation; Shah speaks to UP, Bihar CMs

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 26

THE CENTRE is closely monitoring the situation arising from a flash flood in Nepal, with the impact expected to travel downstream through the Gandak river into India, a Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) spokesperson said on Wednesday.

The spokesperson said Union Home Minister Amit Shah spoke with the chief ministers of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh regarding the disaster and directed authorities to remain vigilant in border areas likely to be affected.

In a post on X, Shah described the devastation caused by the floods in Nepal as deeply tragic and expressed condolences to the families who lost loved ones.

He said the government of India stands with Nepal in the

hour of crisis.

The MHA spokesperson said an advisory issued by the Central Water Commission (CWC), along with media reports, indicated a sudden rise in the water level of the Trishuli river at Purke Khola in Nepal. The location is around 160 km from the Indian border.

The rise in water levels has been attributed to suspected flash flood or glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF) activity near the Nepal-China border, the spokesperson said.

Officials from the MHA, Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry of Jal Shakti, and Ministry of Defence are continuously monitoring developments, the spokesperson said.

The CWC has informed the Centre that water levels in reservoirs on the Nepal side are receding and that the situation is currently under control.



Personnel of Nepal Army waded through sludge to rescue a woman in Nepal. ANI

• INDIANS IN NEPAL

TAMIL NADU Whereabouts of 37 of the 57 tourists are yet to be ascertained, said state officials. The tourists were on their way to a temple in the Himalayas. Isha Foundation said 77 of its members who were at an immigration centre were missing.

UTTAR PRADESH Several people were believed to be stranded in Nepal. Farmer leader Rakesh Tikait, who had gone to Nepal via road with his associates, was stuck in Pokhara.

MAHARASHTRA 4 tourists from Mumbai and Pune are stuck in Nepal, but are safe, officials said.

KERALA A team of 36 people touring Nepal was safe and away from the areas hit by the flash floods, state officials said. PTI

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

For Gen Z and under-40, to be MP or MLA, it helps to be Gen D—dynast

chunk of the Gen Z demographic cannot count elections. But even among those who are 40 years old or younger, 37.8% (aged 40 or under), or those born in 1986 or later, account for a projected 65.4%, or 93.3 crore, of the 2026 projected population figures.

The BJP has lowest share in percentage terms. The party has nine Lok Sabha MPs, out of 240, in the under-40 age bracket. Of them, five are dynasts. Out of the Congress's 98 MPs, seven are in the under-40 bracket and four are dynasts. Similarly, seven of the Samajwadi Party's 37 Lok Sabha MPs are in this category and six of them are dynasts. Four of the Telugu Desam Party's (TDP) 16 MPs are under 40 and all of them are dynasts.

● The BJP, which is in power in 22 states and UTs either directly or as part of an alliance, has 1,811 MLAs. Out of them, 121

are in the 40-and-under age bracket and 41 are from political families. The Congress, whose political footprint has shrunk in recent years and is now in power in four states directly and in one in alliance, has 662 MLAs in total. Of these state legislators, 52 are in the 40-and-under bracket and 23 are dynasts.

Lok Sabha
In the Lok Sabha, 40 MPs are 40 years old or younger, including the six Gen Z parliamentarians. While five of the six Gen Z MPs are dynasts, 19 of the 34 MPs in the 30-40 age bracket come from political families.

Some of the notable MPs among them are:
● Abhishek Banerjee (38), nephew of Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee
● Yaduveer Walia (34), a BJP MP from the erstwhile royal family of Mysore and adopted son of ex-MP Srikanthadatta Narasimharaja Wadiyar
● Raksha Khadse (39), daughter-in-law of former BJP Cabinet minister in Maharashtra Ekant Khadse
● Karan Bhushan Singh (35), the son of former Wrestling Federation of India chief and ex-MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh
● Congress's Priyanka Jarkhadi (29), daughter of Karnataka minister Satish Jarkhadi and member of the prominent Jarkhadi political family
● Rashtriya Lok Dal's (RLD) Chandan Chauhan (38), grandson of UP's first Deputy Chief Minister Narayan Singh
● Samajwadi Party's (SP) Aditya (38) and Akshay Yadav (39), nephews of former UP CM Mayawati and brother of the prominent Mayawati Singh Yadav and cousins of party chief Akhilesh Yadav
● Shiv Sena's Shrikant Shinde, son of party chief and Maharashtra Deputy CM Eknath Shinde
● Telugu Desam Party

(TDP)'s GM Harish Balayogi (35), son of former Lok Sabha Speaker GM C Balayogi
● Bharat Mathukumilli (37), grandson of an ex-MP and a son-in-law in the prominent Nandamuri-Nara Film and political family in Andhra Pradesh

This group of 40 MPs also includes 11 women, or 27.5%, well above the share of women across the entire Lok Sabha at 14%. Eight of them are dynasts.

Legislative Assemblies

Across the 31 legislative Assemblies, 344 MLAs are aged 40 or younger. Of them, 121, or 35.2%, are dynasts. The MLAs aged 40 and under account for 8.3% of India's total 4,131 MLAs.

Only three states do not have any MLAs aged 40 or younger and another two do not have any such MLAs from a political background. In seven states, there are more dynastic MLAs than those with no political background in

the 40-and-younger bracket, while in 21 states, a majority of these younger legislators have no direct political connections.

The highest share of MLAs from political families in this age band is in Odisha, where 14 of 16 such MLAs have direct political connections. The next most dynastic states in this age group are Maharashtra (12 of 16), Uttar Pradesh (23 of 32), and Karnataka and Haryana (five of nine).

States such as Tamil Nadu, Kerala and West Bengal, which went to polls earlier this year, are notable outliers for having a sizable number of MLAs aged 40 and under, but only a handful who are dynasts. Just three of Tamil Nadu's 47 MLAs in this age bracket are dynasts, while of West Bengal's 45 MLAs aged 40 and younger, just five are from political families. In Kerala, 16 such MLAs include just 1 from a political family. Punjab has just one dynastic legislator among 12

MLAs aged 40 or under.

As a share of the Assembly strength, Tamil Nadu has the most MLAs aged 40 or under at 20.1%, followed by Meghalaya at 18.3%, West Bengal at 15.3%, Bihar at 13.2%, and Kerala at 11.4%. In 16 states, MLAs aged 40 and under account for less than 10% of the Assembly strength.

Some of the notable MLAs aged 40 or under are:
● In Bihar, 36-year-old Tejashwi Yadav is the de facto leader of the RJD that was founded by his father and ex-CM Lalu Prasad.

● In Haryana, Congress leader Randeep Surjewala's son Aditya, 27, is the state's only Gen Z MLA, while MLA Arjun Chautala, 34, of the Indian National Lok Dal is the grandson of ex-CM OP Chautala.

● In Himachal Pradesh, Cabinet minister Vikramaditya Singh, 36, is the son of ex-CM Virbhadra Singh and former

state Congress chief Pratibha Singh.

● Among the BJP's Jammu & Kashmir MLAs is Devyani Rana, 31, niece of Union minister Jitendra Singh and daughter of ex-MLA Devender Rana, who earlier represented her Nagrota seat.

● In Madhya Pradesh, former CM Digvijaya Singh's son Jaivardhan Singh, 40, has been a Congress MLA for over a decade and served as a minister in the short-lived Kamal Nath government.

● In Odisha, state veteran and state party chief Bhakti Charan Das, 34, is an MLA. ● In Uttar Pradesh, Wrestling Federation of India's (WFI) ex-chief Brij Bhushan's son Prateek Bhushan Singh, 38, is a BJP MLA, while the Samajwadi Party's first MP has several MLAs. ● In Jharkhand, Prapat Singh, Nishad Party founder Sanjay Nishad's son Sarwan, 36, is an MLA, as is 34-year-old Abbas Ansari, whose father Mukhtar Ansari was a gangster-turned-politician who died while in prison.

MLAs, including former Manipur CM Okram Ibobi's 38-year-old son Surjakumar Okram of the Congress and the children of former Meghalaya CMs Donkupar Roy and Mukul Sangma's. Roy's son Balajied Kumar Syiem, 38, is a United Democratic Party MLA and Miani Shira, 36, is a TMC legislator. In Sikkim, 36-year-old Aditya Goley of the ruling Sikkim Krantikari Morcha is the son of sitting CM Prem Singh Tamang.

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Maharashtra paper leak: Accused turned ‘whistleblower’ after breakup, say police

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, August 26

AN ALLEGED breakup has lent a new twist to the investigation into the Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MSPC)'s Drug Inspector recruitment exam's paper leak, with the man who alerted the commission about the leak now among six persons arrested in the case.

The Mumbai Crime Branch claimed whistleblower Lokesh alias Gaurav Patil, 24, himself got the leaked paper from his friend, Rutuja, before the exam on March 22. However, after the paper broke up, police alleged Patil approached the MSPC about the leak because he feared she would secure a government job and forget him.

The Crime Branch has also issued a notice to Rutuja, who went on to secure seventh rank in the recruitment exam.

Crime Branch DCP Raj Tilak Roushan said Patil, who initially approached the MSPC claiming to have information about the leak, was found during the investigation to have been involved in the paper leak himself. "In all, six persons, including three MSPC employees, have been arrested. A notice has been issued to Rutuja," Roushan said.

The investigation found that ahead of the March 22 examination, Amrut Patil, Rutuja's father, allegedly contacted a



The accused being taken to court in the MSPC leak case. EXPRESS

man named Pravin Patil, who is from Nandurbar. Police said Amrut is a teacher at a zilla parishad school in Nandurbar and has in past received best teacher award by the government.

Pravin is a teacher at a coaching class and knew Amrut. Police are probing if the papers were handed over to students of his coaching class as well. Gaurav worked with pharmaceutical company and was preparing to give the drug inspector exam.

Pravin allegedly knew three MSPC employees — assistant section officers Vishveshwar Nakate, Gopal Marate and under-secretary Abhijeet Lendave — who allegedly helped procure the question paper.

According to police, Pravin allegedly paid Rs 5 lakh to the MSPC employees, with more money promised later. Amrut allegedly handed the paper to Ru-

tuja a few days before the exam. Rutuja then passed on the paper to Gaurav on WhatsApp two days prior to the exam.

Rutuja subsequently appeared for the examination and secured seventh rank. But by the time the results were declared, Gaurav and Rutuja had broken up. Police alleged it was after the breakup that Gaurav turned whistleblower as he feared that once she became an officer, she would forget him.

He emailed the MSPC claiming to be a friend of an applicant and alleged the March 22 examination paper had been leaked.

He followed up on the complaint, while NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar separately raised the issue towards the end of July, alleging that candidates at a coaching institute in Nandurbar had received most of the questions two days before the exam.

The MSPC then approached the Mumbai Police, and the Crime Branch's Property Cell took over the probe.

Investigators initially recorded Gaurav's statement. But as the probe progressed, police said, he sensed that investigators were closing in on him. He approached the MSPC again and tried to backtrack on his complaint, claiming he had been confused about the exam process.

The Crime Branch, however, continued its probe and found that the paper had indeed been leaked and Gaurav too had received it before the exam. "If he was indeed a whistleblower, he should have alerted the MSPC before the exam," said an officer.

The Drug Inspector recruitment examination was conducted on March 22 for posts in the Food and Drug Administration. Around 44,500 candidates appeared at centres across the state's six revenue divisions.

The Crime Branch conveyed its findings to the MSPC Tuesday and registered an FIR. The six accused were arrested Wednesday and produced before a court, which remanded them in police custody.

Following the Crime Branch report, the MSPC cancelled the examination and said a fresh one would be conducted. Candidates who were part of the cancelled recruitment process will not have to apply again.

UP night safari project needs fresh appraisal, SC panel told

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, August 26

THE SUPREME COURT's Central Empowered Committee (CEC) has been urged to process the proposed Kukrail Night Safari and Zoological Park in Lucknow—billed as India's first urban night safari project—arguing that the changes it directed in the original proposal require fresh appraisal.

The representation argued that even as Supreme Court allowed the project to proceed on July 15, changes made to the original proposal mean the environmental clearance and zoo-related approvals may not stand.

The court's go-ahead for the project was based on the CEC's recommendations, which had rejected a proposal to shift Lucknow's Nawab Wajid Ali Shah Zoological Park, setting up an adventure park, and widen a road into four lanes.

"In light of the conditions imposed by this committee, it is submitted that the Kukrail Night Safari and Day Zoo project as proposed by the State of Uttar Pradesh can no longer be developed," former Indian Forest Service officer Prakriti Srivastava said in a representation made to the court's Central Empowered Committee (CEC) on August 21. Srivastava is one of the peti-

"The CZA has approved our master layout plan of 850 acres, and if there are changes, we will approach CZA again... Facts and details regarding the project were placed before the Supreme Court as a matter of record, and we will comply with all conditions," said Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests Ram Kumar

titioners in a case under which the UP government sought permission for the project from the SC. While clearing the project, the SC had allowed parties to submit suggestions regarding implementation of CEC conditions. It has been argued that the Central Zoo Authority's (CZA) approval and environmental clearances were granted to the composite project, which involved moving Lucknow Zoo.

The representation stated that Uttar Pradesh has to therefore prepare a new project pro-

posal and get approvals from the CZA and environmental clearance from Centre. "Until and unless these fresh proposals are obtained, the project cannot be permitted to proceed," it added.

Srivastava also sought a personal hearing with the CEC to explain the issue. One of the key issues flagged to the CEC was the project area as mentioned in the detailed project report and approved by the CZA and the changes made to it.

It was argued that the project area is 855.07 acres, whereas the detailed project report (DPR) cites an area of 390.75 acres. "Therefore, the DPR needs a re-look and any approval based on the 'outdated' DPR has to be set aside," it said.

Citing conditions laid down in the environmental clearance granted for the project, the representation argued that the safari project required a forest clearance before work starts.

The project is situated on reserved forest land. The representation stated that the project also involves constructing an auditorium, 7D theatre, and amphitheatre, all permanent structures on forest land.

When contacted, CEC Chairperson Chandra Prakash Goyal told The Indian Express, "We will seek comments from the concerned departments."

Speaking to The Indian Express, Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests Ram Kumar, who is also the project's director, said, "The CZA has approved our master layout plan of 850 acres, and if there are changes, we will approach CZA again. As on date, as per the amended Forest Conservation Act, 2023, zoos and safaris are considered forestry activity. Facts and details regarding the project were placed before the Supreme Court as a matter of record, and we will comply with all conditions."

The SC approval following the UP government's approach after an earlier order prohibited setting up zoos or safaris in forest areas without its permission.

The large batch of petitions, in which Srivastava is a co-petitioner, also challenge the Centre's amendments to the Forest Conservation Act designating safaris as a forestry activity.

The Kukrail project, estimated to cost Rs 1,510.57 crore, is proposed over an area of 855.07 acres in the northeastern part of Lucknow in the Kukrail forest. The first phase will include a night safari, and the second phase will include a day zoo. It also includes ecotourism plans.

The CZA and the State Environment Impact Assessment Authority approved proposal.

Life convict jumps parole in 1984, retires as govt teacher, gets arrested after 40 years

Ashish Shaji
New Delhi, August 26

HE WAS supposed to return to prison in March 1984 after a short parole. Instead, the life convict stayed out for the next 40 years — securing a government teaching job, winning a "best teacher" award in 2004, and retiring before being arrested and sent to prison in 2024.

When his wife came challenging the three-year ban on seeking parole for the 73-year-old convict, the Telangana High Court dismissed her plea on August 17 and ordered creation of a tracking system for prisoners released on parole.

Justice T Madhavi Devi issued the direction while dismissing the plea saying, "This instance of not being able to track a prisoner for a period of forty years during which, he gets appointed to a Government job and renders service without interruption till he attains the age of superannuation reflects poorly on the attempts of the jail

Telangana High Court dismissed his wife's plea on Aug 17 against the 3-year bar on his parole

authorities in keeping track of the prisoner when they are granted parole without guards and would embolden many others to adopt such methods of overstay and deception." The court directed the authorities concerned to constitute special task forces to keep strict vigilance over prisoners on parole.

According to the records, the petitioner's husband was convicted in 1983 in a murder case and sentenced to life imprisonment. He was released on parole on December 17, 1983, initially for 30 days, with the period subsequently extended until March 17, 1984. He was required to surrender on March 18, 1984, but did not return to prison.

He remained outside prison

for over four decades before being apprehended by a special task force on May 16, 2024. He was subsequently transferred to the central prison. The convict's wife challenged an order under which his entire earned remission of around 27 days was forfeited, and he was denied parole and furlough for three years.

The petitioner argued that the authorities had taken action after an unexplained delay of nearly 40 years. She also submitted that her husband had been working as a government teacher, retired in 2013, and had even received a "best teacher" award in 2004.

On the other hand, the state opposed the plea and submitted that the punishment awarded to the petitioner's husband was as per the rules and there was no illegality or violation of the principles of natural justice. It was further stated when the petitioner's husband jumped parole and did not report back, several letters were addressed to the superintendent of police, and ul-

timately, a special task force team was formed for apprehending petitioner's husband.

The counsel said parole is not an absolute right for prisoners and they cannot claim it as a matter of right. It was further added if a prisoner who is released on furlough/leave commits a breach of any of the conditions of furlough/leave, he may be awarded punishment of non-inclusion of furlough/leave period towards sentence.

The court noted petitioner's husband did not voluntarily report to the central prison after the expiry of the parole period. It observed he intentionally evaded arrest and his claim of having worked as a government teacher until retirement also indicated he had deliberately concealed his conviction and obtained a government employment "by deception".

"The petitioner's husband has been successful in leading the prime period of his life out of prison and enjoyed all the benefits," the court said.

National tribal commission seeks report from J&K govt on girl's rape, fatal pregnancy

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 26

THE NATIONAL Commission for Scheduled Tribes (NCST) has given the Jammu and Kashmir administration five days to submit a report on the alleged sexual assault of a tribal teenager by her headmaster in J&K's Kishtwar district, leading to a fatal pregnancy.

The headmaster and his brother — both of whom are said to have accompanied the teenager for the failed abortion attempt — have been arrested. The education department has initiated an enquiry and suspended the headmaster.

The scheduled tribes commission on August 25, the commission said it was invoking its powers under Article 338A of the Indian Constitution and asked the J&K chief secretary, the director general of police and the SSP of Kishtwar to respond within that period.

The notice came after a complaint from Kabir Ahmed, member trustee of the Tribal Gujjar Bakewell Welfare Foundation, Dhanote. The minor had allegedly been abused by the headmaster for several months, leading to her death on August 20 after a failed abortion attempt last week. The death led to protests across the district.

The headmaster and his brother — both of whom are said to have accompanied the teenager for the failed abortion attempt — have been arrested. The education department has initiated an enquiry and suspended the headmaster.

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 NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

Open Tender Notice No.:
SrDEE-TRD-BSB-2026-27-T29
Date 25-08-2026
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/
TRD, North Eastern Railway, Varanasi
for and on behalf of President of India

invites seeking "OPEN" E-Tender for the following work:-

SI. No.01. Name of work: 25 KV Electrification work in connection with Extension and Siding at Platform for 24 Coaches at Rasid & Jankhana, Part-B of the project of the Government of India, Ministry of Railways, New Delhi. Tender No. SO/DT-TR/HSB-2026-27-272, Approx. Cost (in Rs.) 1,65,14,185.90, Earnest Money (in Rs.) 1,30,300.00. Cost of tender documents (in Rs.) Nil. E-Tender closing date and time: 17/09/2026 up to 14:45 Hrs. Completion period: 09/Months.

• Open E-Tender-Online will be submitted up to 14:45 Hrs. on date 17/09/2026.

• For full details and submission of bid kindly visit the Official website of Indian Railway i.e., www.ircorp.gov.in

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/TRD
CPRO/UDV-165 Varanasi

**Neuver travel on
roof and foot boards.**

ERS LIMITED

ce: Scope Complex, Core -III,
website: www.nationalfertilizers.com
11-24360066, 24361252

Meeting
(AGM) of the Members of National
and day of September, 2026 at
Audio Visual Means ("OAVM")
to transact the business as set
20/2020 dated May 5, 2020 read
Circular No. 17/2020 dated
22, 2020 (**collectively referred**
of India ("SEBI") circulars No.
P-PoD-2/P/CIR/2024/133 dated
referred to as "SEBI Circulars")
the SEBI (Listing Obligations and
g with the Annual Report for the
those Members whose e-mail
depositories. In accordance with

viz. www.nationalfertilizers.com
v) viz. www.evoting.nsdl.com.

copies of the Notice of AGM and annual report will be provided to you in accordance with Regulation 13.2B-link, including exact path to the documents for members whose e-mail IDs are registered with the company.

es Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of 14, as amended from time to time (e-voting Requirements) Regulations, provide e-voting (Remote e-voting) to cast their vote electronically from 08.08.2026 through the e-voting system and the eligibility to vote through

on a resolution is cast by the
y.

h e-voting at the AGM. Members
M may attend the AGM through
ed procedure for remote e-voting

VC/OAVM facility only. Members
purpose of reckoning the quorum
or joining the AGM are provided in
match of Notice of AGM, but on or
a request at evoting@nsdl.com
shareholder and holding shares in
structions of notice.

Want to update their e-mail address
communications electronically.

SR-1, SR-2 and send to Floor, Okhla Industrial Area, Participant(s) with whom your meeting held on 12.08.2026 has ₹ 10 each for the Financial Year . The Final Dividend, if approved shareholders whose names appear dividend to security holders (holding . Accordingly, payment of final holders shareholders whose, folios

by the Finance Act, 2026, the
Accordingly, the Company shall be
time of making the payment to

details (for receiving electronic

Floor, Okhla Industrial Area,

Participant(s) with whom your
the details, if any, required by

Company Secretaries (CP: 11532)
voting and e-voting at the AGM

entment of proxy by members will

authorized representatives are
their representative to attend and
shall be sent to the Scrutinizer by
mail.com with a copy marked to

e-voting, e-voting at the AGM and
in case of any queries/ concern/
of Members and Remote e-voting
www.evoting.nsdl.com or contact
on Toll Free No. 022- 4886 7000 /
Service Limited through email at

the Notice of the AGM and in
ough remote e-voting or e-voting

for National Fertilizers Limited,
Sd/-
(Ashok K)

Company Secretary

The Indian EXPRESS
- FOUNDED BY -
RAMNATH GOENKA
IN 1932

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Language & religion diktats shrink Mumbai

WOSTORIES are unfolding in Mumbai on the watch of the Devendra Fadnis government. Since his first term in office, the Chief Minister has become the face of a welfare governance and infrastructure-building push in the country's financial capital. The other story is disquieting by itself, and also potentially undermines the gains of the first — take the Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Act, which comes into force this week. Christian pastors across the Mumbai Metropolitan area have asked congregants to submit a "self-declaration" that they attend prayer meetings of their own volition — this is because the Act comes against the backdrop of harassment of congregants and disruption of meetings by groups like Bajrang Dal and VHP, and in the aftermath, the police's one-sided action. Over the last month, seven of the 11 FIRs registered have been against those who organised prayers — and two against the Bajrang Dal. The Act is draconian, and flies in the face of the Supreme Court ruling in *Rev. Stanislaus v. State of Madhya Pradesh* (1977), which laid down the parameters for the constitutionality of laws against conversion. The recent spate of anti-conversion laws in several states reverse the burden of proof. The Maharashtra law prescribes harsh punishments, asks for intimation to the district magistrate in advance and allows parents, siblings and relatives to sue. It sends out the message that the government is focusing more on a narrow and performative politics of identity even as it takes a toll on the city's economic activity, and undermines citizens' right to work and mobility. The fact that members of a minority community that is part of the fabric of Mumbai feel the need to sign pre-emptive declarations is a stain on the Constitution's promise of freedom of conscience and the right to practice and propagate religious belief. It is now for the government and ruling party to ensure that these fears are allayed. The financial capital of the country cannot flourish if it tries to dictate the language the people speak and what they believe.

A death at IIT-Delhi, many invisible struggles

YALL accounts, Rishikesh Kumar from Bihar was a bright young man who had made it to IIT-Delhi in pursuit of a dream. Physics fascinated him; poetry offered another outlet for his creativity. Yet beneath the promise and ambition was a young man struggling with mental-health challenges. His death, allegedly by suicide on August 22, has once again brought into focus the helplessness that can lurk beneath the surface of hyper-competitive institutions. Kumar's death was the eighth such incident at the campus since 2023.

Over the last five years, the IITs have been proactive in acknowledging that access does not always translate into merit and belonging. Measures such as supernumerary quotas for women and athletes in undergraduate courses to enhance diversity, and the creation of posts such as the dean of student well-being, recognise that the pressures within elite campuses are shaped as much by the collision between identity and expectation as by an intensely competitive environment. The pressure does not end with securing a place at an IIT; for many, it simply changes form — from the struggle to get in, to the struggle to keep up and fit in. A 2023-24 IIT-Delhi bulletin described a culture of post-coaching burnout, and alienation among marginalised and first-generation students. It makes every setback — from a failed relationship to an inadequate score — feel unusually consequential.

Following protests, IIT-Delhi has set up a committee to conduct a probe into Kumar's death. But the questions go beyond the campus. Parto often, mental health is looked at through the prism of individual histories. But for young people who have demonstrated remarkable fortitude in coping with pressures along their journey to some of the country's premier institutions, what explains their inability to deal with what follows? It is this contradiction that parents and educators must address with urgency. How can environments be built where ambition and well-being go hand in hand, where counselling creates safe spaces, where empathy shows youngsters how to regulate their response to life's vagaries? The road ahead must involve a rethinking of the culture of competition itself, so that institutions do not merely produce high achievers, but are home to thriving young people.

Dolly Parton pushed her way in, and stayed

FOR OVER half a century, the force called Dolly Parton, who died at 80 after a brief battle with cancer, was not just a global star, she was a fact that instantly recognisable artist who looked indestructible. Before she marched into living rooms all over the world, she was everywhere in America — on radio, TV, stage and films. She always showed up with that trademark over-the-top aesthetic — towering blonde hair, theatrical make-up ("I apply it with a trowel," she'd say) and rhinestones. Beneath the spectacle, however, was razor-sharp wit, enormous ambition and an instinct for survival. "Just because I am dumb, I don't think I am dumb," she sang in her 1966 single 'Dumb Blonde'.

Growing up in a Smoky Mountain, the fourth of 12 children in a family with little money but plenty of music, Parton emerged from the time she could by four, she was harmonising with her siblings, by seven she was playing the guitar and writing songs and soon performed publicly. After high school, she moved to Nashville, the heart of country music. This was the '60s, and in country music, women were still treated as second-class citizens. But Parton pushed her way in and became a household name with musician Porter Wagoner's nationally syndicated TV show. But Parton wanted more. She decided to leave, crossed over to LA and to pop and reached the much larger audience with "Here You Come Again" (1977), which won her a Grammy. Then came the songs that made her immortal: "Jolene," "I Will Always Love You," "Coat of Many Colours," among others. She never retired.

Her final personal wish was to be laid to rest in a "beautiful bed of plush cotton." She felt she deserved comfort after a lifetime of wearing heavy rhinestones. She always knew exactly what she wanted.



P R KUMARASWAMY

HEAD OF the October 27 Knesset election, it appears that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu will go to any lengths to return to office. The controversy over building 1,200 housing units in E-1 is just the latest example. East 1, or E-1 for short, is a small piece of territory, about 12 square kilometres, in the West Bank. It is part of the municipal limits of the settlement of Ma'ale Adumim and lies east of East Jerusalem. Ma'ale Adumim was established as a settlement in 1975, when Yitzhak Rabin was prime minister, and was upgraded to city status in 1991. With close to 35,000 Israeli citizens (2015 figures), it is one of the largest Israeli settlements in the occupied territories.

Since the Oslo Accords of 1993, there have been plans to connect Ma'ale Adumim to Jerusalem's municipal boundaries. The purpose was twofold: To provide territorial continuity between the two and to expand and consolidate Jerusalem's demographic and strategic security.

Under the Taba Agreement of September 1995 (signed just weeks before Rabin's assassination), the E-1 enclave was part of Area C, where Israel has complete security control. The area is largely uninhabited and covers

about 12,000 dunams, or about 12 square kilometres. Since January 1994, weeks after the signing of the Declaration of Principles with Palestinian leader Yasser Arafat, various Israeli governments have toyed with the idea of establishing a settlement in E-1. Under the Clinton Parameters of December 2000, E-1 was supposed to be part of a swap deal in which Israel would annex Ma'ale Adumim, including E-1, in return for withdrawing from 94-96 per cent of the West Bank. To curb Israeli efforts, the Palestinians have been building individual housing units in the area, which Israel periodically demolishes. Israel's prolonged reluctance to pursue new settlement activity has largely been shaped by American and international criticism.

The latest effort comes amid the forthcoming election. While Likud, led by Netanyahu, still leads the opinion polls, several surveys indicate a dip in the party's seat count. From 32 seats in 2022, pollsters predict a range of 20 to 23 seats in most forecasting seats in the 20s. Centre-right and right-wing parties appear to be the main gainers at Netanyahu's expense. According to observers, Itamar Ben-Gvir, the leader of the ultranationalist and pro-nouncedly anti-Arab Otzma Yehudit (Jewish Power) party, is the real challenger to Netanyahu. As the minister of national security and a member of the security cabinet, Ben-Gvir has been a key factor in Netanyahu's hardline security stance since October 7.

While Israel's response to Hamas, Hezbollah, and the Islamic

Republic of Iran has delivered tangible short-term military gains, Netanyahu is struggling to translate them into political gains. Israel is more secure today than in October 2023. The disarmament of Hamas and Hezbollah has become a precondition for peace, stability, and the reconstruction of the Gaza Strip and Lebanon, respectively. Except for Iran, no major power endorses, let alone contributes to, the survival and strengthening of the "Axis of Resistance". Under President Ahmed al-Sharaa, Syria is no longer the conduit for Iranian arms supplies to the Shia militant groups in Lebanon.

Yet, if the opinion polls are any indication, the military "victory" is proving insufficient to win more votes for the Likud. Within the party, Netanyahu has established unchallengeable authority over seat allocations. Out of the top 30 seats, he managed to reserve 11 for candidates considered loyal to him. This pushed several other Likud figures to the margins, with no real chance of entering the Knesset.

However, securing broader endorsement of his leadership among the Israeli population is more challenging. A considerable segment of the population has not forgotten his role, or lack thereof, in the October 7 terror attack. Several senior military and security figures admitted responsibility and resigned. This has not been the case for the political leadership. PM Netanyahu has not taken any direct personal responsibility for Israel's 9/11 moment. True to his style, he has shifted the blame and has not

gone beyond saying that "everyone, from the top to the bottom, shares responsibility".

Above all, Netanyahu and his cabinet have consistently resisted public calls for a national inquiry commission headed by the sitting president of the Supreme Court (equivalent to the Chief Justice of India). In the past, Israel had two such commissions, led by Shimon Agranat (over the Yom Kippur War of 1973) and Yitzhak Kahane (over the Sabra and Shatila massacre of 1982). Under Israeli law, everyone, including the prime minister, would have to testify under oath and could be cross-examined. So far, Netanyahu has been dodging this. However, should he feel it necessary, he might reverse course and make it an electoral promise.

The new settlement construction in E-1 is part of Netanyahu's efforts to shore up support for his political alliance. A victory of the right-religious coalition is essential to Netanyahu's political future. Losing a few seats to the far right is preferable to handing them to the centre-left Opposition. One should view Netanyahu's reluctance to endorse and embrace the American disarmament plans for the Gaza Strip in this context. Appearing weak or submitting to US President Donald Trump's diktats will cost him more votes than a defiant posture. Thus, despite the near-unanimous Arab-European case against his E-1 plans, Netanyahu is driven more by electoral calculations on an issue that has remained dormant for over three decades.

The writer teaches contemporary Middle East at Jawahar Nehru University

Rural India needs jobs, not wage guarantees



PURVI MEHTA

SEVERAL REPORTS earlier this month noted a nearly 50 per cent drop in employment generated under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin), the VB-GRAM-G. The scheme, launched last year as a successor to the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, guarantees 125 days of rural wage employment, faster payments, and a technology-enabled delivery system built for a Viksit Bharat. It is the world's largest public-works programme, backed by a budget of Rs 95,692 crore.

The initial dip is too early to judge the scheme's efficacy. The low numbers do pose a more important question, however: Is a wage-guarantee model, however well designed, the right instrument for rural India in 2026? Public employment guarantees have a long lineage, from Depression-era America to empires who commissioned public works, including temples, to generate wages. The logic was straightforward: When private employment cannot absorb surplus labour — because industry is nascent, services are thin, and agriculture is overcrowded — the state must step in as an employer, providing wages through public works to prevent destitution. That logic held force in India when manufacturing was underdeveloped, and the services boom was an urban phenomenon. For rural households, a guaranteed unskilled wage job was often the only buffer between subsistence and distress.

But the India of 2026 is seeing sustained industrial expansion and a rapidly diversifying rural non-farm sector, and has a digital economy that has reached deeper into villages than most of us appreciate. Rural users now account for the majority of the country's roughly 950 million active internet users. That connectivity has translated into consumption. Rural FMCG demand, for example, has been growing at roughly four times the rate of urban demand and is projected to reach \$220 billion, a nearly tenfold rise from a decade ago. India's rural markets are no longer passive recipients of government programmes.

Nearly 64 per cent of India's population and roughly two-thirds of its 378 million young people live in rural areas. Wages create livelihoods, not careers. The rural youth today are more educated, more connected,

and more exposed to opportunity than any previous generation, but they are also less willing to queue for 125 days of manual wage labour on public works when better alternatives exist or could exist, especially closer to home. This arguably could be the real story behind VB-GRAM-G's disappointing opening month.

The question is no longer how to guarantee more days of wage labour, but how to create genuine, durable employment in sectors that already sit close to rural India's comparative advantage. Sectors that convert local resources, local produce and local labour into local livelihoods while leveraging on the increasing global connectivity.

Food processing is one example. The sector is projected to nearly double from its current size by 2030, built substantially on raw materials that rural India produces — milk, fruit, grain, spices. Renewable energy offers another example: India's clean-energy targets could generate over 44 lakh jobs by 2030, with local, decentralised and labour-intensive production. Strengthening the ecosystem of rural manufacturing and service industries — not necessarily giant factories, but clusters of SMEs producing textiles, farm equipment, healthcare devices, renewable-energy components, construction materials and consumer goods — offers the kind of localised but large-scale rural employment a public-works scheme tries and often fails. Rural healthcare, agri-logistics, and small-scale manufacturing round out a portfolio of sectors where demand, resources and workforce already co-exist in rural India. Capital, skilling, and market linkages, not manual labour opportunities, are what Viksit Bharat demands.

This is not an argument for abandoning income support for India's most vulnerable rural households. That safety net remains necessary, but it should no longer be the principal mechanism of rural employment policy. The next iteration of India's rural employment architecture cannot simply focus on executing the old idea better. It must revise the idea itself. Wages are a short-term transaction. They buy a household immediate relief. Jobs provide the nation with a future workforce. Viksit Bharat will outgrow its need for wages as welfare; it will demand productive jobs.

The writer is a senior agriculture industry advisor. Views are personal



SHASHANK R JOSHI

LAST WEEK in my OPD, two lives sat side by side. One was 42 — diabetes, high blood pressure, fatty liver — already carrying three medicines. The other was 89, from a quiet village near Ratnagiri. Clear eyes, unhurried gait, not a single tablet. She walked three kilometres every morning as naturally as she breathed. I asked her, "What is your secret?" She smiled, touched the small *tulsi* plant carefully placed in her cloth bag, and answered in the soft certainty of those who have never doubted the old ways: "Doctor, *haridra* is my best friend. *Haridra* is the *king of all medicines*. *Radih shatam* [may we live a hundred autumns]." In that single prayer, the entire science of longevity was already present.

We speak with wonder of Okinawa, Sardinia, and Ikaria. Yet across our own land, living Blue Zones — where people live long, healthy lives — have never disappeared: The high villages of Himachal, where apricots, glacier water, and daily walking at altitude shape both body and mind; the coastal belts of Kerala, nourished by coconut, fish, and turmeric; the Jain communities of Gujarat, who still honour early dinners, weekly fasting, *sattvik* food, and the quiet strength of *sangha*. No gyms. No calorie apps. Only a way of life the Vedas and Ayurveda described, which never truly left us. Science confirms these five pillars the *rishis* gave us. First, *aahaara* — food as sacred offering. *Annam Brahma* (food is Brahman). Eat what is fresh, seasonal, and *sattvik*. Millets, dal, a measured spoon of ghee, vegetables first, the evening meal completed before the night deepens. This *ritual* lowers the markers that shorten life today.

Second, *vihara* — movement as living. *Shriramnam dharmam sadhanam* (the body is the first instrument of dharma). Walking, climbing, squatting, tending the earth. This is not "exercise," but refusing the stillness that modern life mistakes for rest. Third, *nidra* — sleep as the body's deepest medicine. Rise in *Brahma Muhurta*. Sleep with the turning of the Sun. Seven to eight hours of unbroken rest. When sleep is broken, insulin resists, blood pressure rises, and immunity weakens. Fourth, *sanga* — companionship as longevity. *Sangachchhadhwam* (walk together). Those woven into family, neighbourhood, and seva live longer. Fifth, *sadhana* — stillness as healing. Ten minutes of prayer, *japa*, or *anulom-vilom*. Breath that is regulated softens cortisol and cools the fires of chronic inflammation.

In the clinic, I write two prescriptions. One is of medicine — metformin, statins, insulin when required. The other is of life: Walk 10 minutes after every meal. Receive 15 minutes of morning sunlight. Honour protein and fibre on every plate; let sugar and maida recede. Keep the same hours of sleep and waking. Offer one deliberate act of gratitude or prayer each day. This is not a turning away from modern medicine. It's a necessary companion.

Laboratories across the world search for the secret of a long and healthy life. India has kept it alive in its kitchens, temple courtyards, village paths, and in the quiet discipline of its grandmothers

The writer is a Mumbai-based endocrinologist

40 YEARS AGO

August 27, 1986



Five killed in Pakistan violence

THE KILLING of five persons, including two policemen, a self-immolation bid by two Pakistan People's Party workers, and the burning of a railway station shattered the eerie silence in the volatile Shindher province, according to latest reports. The agitation by the 10-party alliance of the Movement for the Restoration of Democracy assumed a new dimension when two PPP workers set their clothes ablaze in Dadu, one of the worst-hit towns in the nearly two-week-long violence.

Search for survivors

RELIEF TEAMS searched for survivors from the toxic gas disaster at a volcanic lake in

western Cameroon that killed at least 2,000 people and left the area looking like it was hit by a "nuclear bomb". The President, Paul Biya, said the death toll could be higher, but that most of the gas appeared to have dissipated from around Lake Nyos, where an explosion at the bottom of the lake loosened a huge pocket of gas that swept through lakeshore communities.

Informer shot at in Punjab

A POLICE informer was shot at and injured by a wanted terrorist, Bhola, who escaped despite being fired at by security men in Amritsar. Five suspected terrorists were taken into custody in Faridkot and Amritsar districts. The situation in the curfew-bound

town of Giddarbaha was stated to be tense but under control. Four have been rounded up in connection with the killing of three persons in a car near Moga, a police spokesman said in Faridkot. He said the "real culprits" were expected to be nabbed soon, following the interrogation of the four persons.

More customs, excise reliefs

THE FINANCE MINISTRY announced more concessions in customs and excise duties in response to industry representations during open house meetings. The ministry decided to extend the concessional rate of 55 per cent ad valorem customs duty for project imports to railway electrification projects under the World Bank loan agreement.



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Young found their voice. Opposition needs to find its language

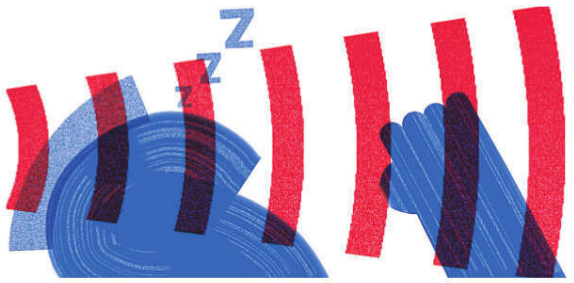


ILLUSTRATION: C R SAKSHI



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

AS COMMENTATORS analyse the significance of the Gen-Z revolt in Indian politics, the signals sent by the ensuing by-elections in Bankipur and Datia, and the unsettling indications that the seemingly invincible BJP cannot take its electoral assumptions for granted anymore, not even in the Hindi heartland, it's time to also examine the lessons the rest of us can learn from the events of recent weeks.

The Cockroach Janta Party movement emerged not from the traditional bastions of caste or communal solidarity, nor even from the more modern phenomenon of the laptops of established political strategists, but from a moment of condescension that struck a raw nerve across India. When Chief Justice of India Surya Kant seemingly dismissed unemployed youth and social media activists as "cockroaches and parasites" he unwittingly handed a frustrated generation its defining label.

Conceived as a satirical digital counter-offensive, the movement swiftly evolved into a nation-spanning political force. By channelling the deep-seated anguish of millions of young Indians over rampant exam paper leaks, arbitrary test cancellations, and chronic underemployment, the CJP achieved what mainstream political coalitions had struggled to accomplish for years: It seized the national narrative, ignited similar protests across the country, and forced a major government retreat, culminating in the resignation of the education minister.

For India's institutional opposition parties, this episode serves as a wake-up call for our current strategies to mobilise the young, offering us object lessons in modern civic mobilisation. We have all tried to seize the moment, and the stirring sight of Rahul Gandhi accompanying a pellet-gun victim to a police station to demand the filing of an FIR shows that he has heard the call. His current campaign among the

youth has seized the national imagination.

The earlier slowness of mainstream opposition parties to tap into this groundswell reveals a persistent blind spot in traditional Indian politics. For over a decade, opposition rhetoric has oscillated primarily between caste-based electoral arithmetic and abstract defences of secular constitutionalism. While both remain crucial axes of political struggle, they missed the immediate, material anxieties of India's growing middle-class and aspiring youth. The young people who filled protest spaces like Jantar Mantar and flooded digital platforms were not animated by high-level political posturing. Instead, they were anguished by a specific breakdown that touched their daily lives: Years of lost educational effort, the mounting financial strain placed on their families by a predatory coaching ecosystem, and a climate of official apathy that routinely dismissed their frustrations as lazy internet outpourings. When traditional leaders attempted to raise these issues, their critiques were largely discounted as standard partisan opportunism, whereas the CJP spoke not as a power-seeking party (in fact, despite its name, it is not a party at all), but as the authentic collective voice of the aggrieved.

At the root of the Opposition's inability to capture this energy lie severe institutional bottlenecks, particularly the gatekeeping inherent to top-down, quasi-feudal party hierarchies. For an ordinary,

talented young person without a political lineage or financial resources, like that in Jantar Mantar, there is no clear path to entering mainstream politics via the opposition, and even entry through established students' organisations or youth wings of such parties rarely offers meaningful agency. Young workers in established parties are frequently reduced to staging pre-approved photo opportunities in which they stand behind the entrenched leadership, amplify senior leaders on social media, or supply attendance numbers and logistical muscle for rallies. The top-down "high command" culture in all Opposition parties denies them any substantive role while they are still young and "junior".

We also must acknowledge the psychological barrier for aspirational youth, who naturally assume their own talents will always be circumscribed by the advantages enjoyed by legacy heirs and entrenched leaders, bearing well-known names and commanding political patronage networks. The CJP bypassed these barriers entirely by lowering the entry threshold to zero, embracing satirical eligibility criteria that "gamified" civic participation, and allowing young citizens to feel like co-creators of a movement rather than mere foot-soldiers. Furthermore, while most opposition parties remained limited by their conventional approaches, public relations processes and hierarchical decision-making, the CJP oper-

At the root of the Opposition's inability to capture this energy lie severe institutional bottlenecks, particularly the gatekeeping inherent to top-down, quasi-feudal party hierarchies



LAILA GHEZAL AZIMI

YEKI BOOD, yeki na bood. Once, there was, and there was not. This is how stories begin in Kabul, my hometown. With an acknowledgement of ambiguity. Believe me if you will, or don't. Maybe this is a true story, maybe it is just my version of the truth. Maybe it is not even my story at all — me being Laila, an Afghan woman living as a refugee in Delhi for nearly a decade. Maybe it's a story of other women, from other times.

Once there was or there was not a girl named Laila who dreamed of riding a bicycle. Maybe that girl never existed. Or maybe she did, and she simply grew up, left Kabul, and carried her unfinished dream with her.

I woke to a phone beep, a message from my friend Sagor, an Afghan woman now living in Canada: "So have you learned yet?" "No, not yet. I'm trying. It's hard." The difficulty wasn't in learning to ride a bicycle. Every time I lost my balance and fell, I told myself: I at least have the right to fall; many girls in my homeland don't have that right. If I was carrying the weight of all their dreams on my wobbling shoulders.

It is August, a time of short-lived remembering of Afghan women by people across the world. For me, it is a reminder of a month when millions of Afghan girls were forced to stop dreaming. Over 1,605 days

This year marks five years since the Taliban's return. For the women of Afghanistan, these years have been a story of silenced voices, of schools and universities closed, and of the loss of the simplest freedoms

have passed since the ban on girls' education. Once, I used to keep count. I stopped when I realised the number would only keep rising.

I never learned to ride a bicycle as a child. But now, at 34, every morning before sunrise, I go to a park to learn. My teacher is Mehran — a 44-year-old Afghan boy who left Kabul at the age of eight. When I told him I didn't own a cycle, he borrowed one from an Indian friend. The first day, I was more anxious than excited. Mehran kept saying, "Just keep your balance." But every time I put my foot on the pedal, I felt as if every passerby was watching me and laughing. I lost my balance and fell hard. The first thing I did wasn't check my wounds. I looked around to see if anyone had seen me fall. We had been taught that certain things weren't for women. Perhaps that's why I feared the gaze of others more than the pain of falling. "I told you not to be afraid. Everyone learns this way," Mehran said. That day I understood that the pain of falling is never as heavy as the regret of not trying.

This year marks five years since the Taliban's return. For the women of Afghanistan, these years have been a story of silenced voices, of schools and universities closed, and of the loss of the simplest freedoms. A bicycle, a book, a classroom — these simple things

ated with digital agility, reclaiming an insult and turning it into a badge of honour through cultural fluency and relentless, meme-driven irony.

If India's Opposition wishes to translate the widespread discontent exposed by this movement into effective political mobilisation, we must undergo fundamental structural and operational change. First, all parties must democratise their internal workings by establishing genuine pathways for young leaders, creating open talent incubators where young organisers and policy researchers are given real decision-making authority based on merit rather than political pedigree.

Second, the Opposition needs to switch from largely abstract slogans or those espousing specific sectoral interests (like caste), toward concrete governance issues that impact the everyday lives of all Indians, grounding our platforms in tangible demands such as strict criminal liability for paper leaks, statutory timelines for public job recruitment, and real economic security for gig workers and students. Congress came closest to this approach during the recent crisis.

Third, rather than attempting to hijack or disparage organic civil-society movements like the CJP, opposition parties should act as force multipliers, offering parliamentary questioning, legal aid, and logistical support without demanding that activists subordinate themselves to, or march under, a specific party banner.

Finally, opposition leaders must abandon over-familiar speeches in favour of a direct, authentic, and culturally resonant language that acknowledges systemic failures without resorting to outdated rhetoric. To their credit, leaders like Rahul Gandhi and Akhilesh Yadav have been doing this increasingly.

The CJP movement demonstrated that India's youth are far from politically indifferent; they possess an immense reservoir of democratic energy, waiting for outlets that respect their intelligence, reflect their culture, and address their aspirations. Unless established Opposition parties open up hierarchies and adapt to this new reality by providing channels for their energy, future waves of mobilisation will continue to pass us by. It cannot be our epitaph that we became irrelevant because we failed to listen.

The writer is a fourth-term Congress MP (Lok Sabha) from Thiruvananthapuram

Centre-state compromise on mines, minerals is in tatters



ROHIT CHANDRA

IN THE 1950s, B C Roy made a trip to Poland to talk to coal-mining companies about bringing their technologies to India. As Chief Minister of West Bengal in a newly independent India, he had an economic vision for his state that relied on coal-based industrialisation; his vision was somewhat divergent from the Planning Commission's goals at the time. He could afford to think this way because the coal industry had not been nationalised, state governments could still make major claims on major minerals within their boundaries, and the model of industrialisation during that era relied on these natural resources.

No chief minister in India can have similar ambitions today. The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957 (MMDR) and its amendments have progressively dispossessed state governments of the right to exploit major minerals within their boundaries. These rights now lie with the Union government, but in return there has been an uneasy federal compromise around minerals for the last half-century. The Union would allocate mining rights for major minerals, states would be allowed to tax these minerals or the underlying land at some kind of periodically renegotiated rate.

With the recent passing of the MMDR Amendment Act, 2026 in both houses of Parliament, any vestiges of this compromise are lost now; it gives the central government control over all mineral and mineral land taxation. Effectively, it is a declaration of war on fiscal federalism writ large, and a potentially unconstitutional erosion of the 2024 Supreme Court ruling around states' rights over mineral taxation. The Act turns what was once a fiscal right of states into a discretionary allocation that can be altered by central rules at any point. For states with large mining economies, this could affect anywhere between 10 and 20 per cent of their annual revenues. Ironically, the states most affected by this at the moment are currently politically aligned with the Union; one wonders how state finance ministers feel about this potential cut to their budgets.



stead of politicians) to defend it.

Perhaps there is an imaginary world where state governments are the entire problem, that ease of doing business is hobbled by them only, that the kleptocracy and fiscal profligacy of the periphery can only be reined in by the righteous fiscal discipline of the core. That certainly seems to be the current narrative. However, this does not explain why after having Union government control over multiple states, sometimes for decades, mining still evades ease of doing business.

Part of the answer to this lies in how localised mining, its impacts and its induced economies are. Because of the density of approvals, regulations and negotiations, only a few large companies in India have been able to navigate the ecosystem at scale. Mining is both essential to industrial and energy policy in India and socially and environmentally devastating. It requires delicate negotiation and repeated interaction for local communities and politicians to have any faith in mining companies; our public-sector mining companies have been much better at this than private miners. Mining should never be too easy; companies need to earn the social and political right to mine, not simply pay for a licence or lease and proceed how they want.

As this law manifests the unending fiscal hunger of the Union government, there's a lesson to be learned from how China managed its fiscal transition. In 1994, Beijing dramatically centralised its fiscal management by keeping a much larger share of overall taxes. However, it opened an escape valve by trusting provinces to financially innovate through other instruments: this included direct, unmediated access to capital markets. Such policy was crucial to the development of regional models of growth in China's provinces. India has kept all of these escape valves closed for now and its fiscal policies are steadily increasing pressures on states. Perhaps it's time to open them before overbearing fiscal dominance causes an explosion.

The writer is assistant professor, School of Public Policy, IIT-Delhi

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A new conversation

RAHUL GANDHI telling an auditorium of young women that they belong to themselves, not to their relationships with men, was genuinely refreshing, coming from a mainstream political stage that rarely makes room for such conversations ("In Pune, a stage and a space, new and old", *IE*, August 26). The Pune moment showed a real instinct for where a younger India is heading. Yet the Congress also retreated into the comfortable old habit of making a secular statement through sullen refusal rather than principled legislative action, letting the Vande Mataram law sail through Parliament in 15 minutes without serious opposition.

Veda Chinanand, Bengaluru

ADelhi for all

WE NEED master plans that prioritise the needs of those at the grassroots, not just the city's elite ("To build Delhi's future, learn from past missteps", *IE*, August 24). Such plans must focus on growth that is public transport-led and also takes into account the neighbourhood's capacity to support more lives and livelihoods.

Rajesh Raj, New Delhi

Follow the Sun

THE AUTHORS rightly argue that India's renewable energy challenge is no longer just about producing electricity but also about connecting it effectively to the grid ("How to make a solar-heavy grid stable & affordable", *IE*, August 26). Their focus on flexible electricity use — such as charging electric vehicles at workplaces, using different electricity rates at different times, and increasing industrial electrification — is a practical way to reduce dependence on expensive battery storage. India should now move from simply matching electricity supply with demand to actively shifting demand to times when solar power is most available.

Bablu Kumar Gupta, Lucknow



AKASH JOSHI

IS GURUGRAM worth living in? Or, for that matter, is a fancy apartment in Koramangala or a gated colony in South Delhi? For much of the time, most of the year, those who have done well enough — thanks to circumstances, inheritance, luck and, of course, hard work — to buy their way out of the tribulations that the majority of Indians suffer through don't even really ask the question. We can go from an air-conditioned private vehicle — Ubers and Olas included — to an air-conditioned office, looking at the heat, sun and those who live on the street through tinted sunglasses. Our children do not need much from this estate — their school

is private, their care and that of the home often outsourced, wholly or in substantial measure, to the "help". Healthcare can be afforded and availed in private hospitals that rival hotels in their swankiness.

Lives of luxury that would be unathomable to most of our counterparts in the West, made possible by being well off in a poor country. We complain, of course, but deep down, we are bound to realise that for all the whingeing about bad roads and poor systems, life isn't all that bad. Sometimes, though, this island of privilege is breached, if even for a few hours or a day or two at most. The harrowing tale of Siddharth Kasid, reported in this newspaper, will resonate with many. The 39-year-old resident of Uniwold Gardens, Gurugram, who works at an investment bank, was forced to wade through waist deep water to rescue his

daughter and other children stranded on the highway. Their school bus, among several others carrying children as young as four and five years old, was not moving for hours — thanks to the flooded roads that are a consequence of Gurugram's poor civic infrastructure. Kasid summed up his ordeal with the following conclusion: "Gurgaon is simply not worth living in anymore. We don't want to live here. My family goes

For the many who live on the roads that are now flooded, traverse them in public buses, and walk the terrible footpaths, the monsoon havoc is just a different degree of what they face every day

through this hell every single year despite the high taxes we pay to the government and the hefty rents. We are now seriously mulling moving out of Gurgaon once this academic session ends."

The parent's anger is understandable. Like so many of us, he faced the brutality of life in India not as routine but as a rupture. He was shocked at the fact that "In my professional life, I manage a team of 45 people, and we make sure there is basic courtesy and communication; here, the authorities showed none". How many of us, though, treat everyone in our lives with the same dignity that we expect? How many of the colonies in Gurugram, Noida and all over the country have "service lifts" for workers whose collars aren't white?

His colony, like many others, is green, well-constructed and has many amenities

within its gates. But sewage and stormwater drains, roads and public infrastructure are not private goods. For the many who live on the roads, the rain is not flood, traverse them in public buses (even the Metro is sometimes too expensive for working people in NCR) and shared rickshaws, and walk the terrible footpaths, the monsoon havoc is just a different degree of what they face every day. Their children, too, are stuck in more ways than one.

None of this is to say that the government should not provide basic infrastructure or not be held accountable. For that, though, people with a voice and privilege will have to stop walling themselves off. Or just move because we can afford to.

The writer is associate editor, The Indian Express. aakash.joshi@expressindia.com

Six killed, 14 injured as bus crashes into stationary truck in Telangana

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 26

SIX PEOPLE were killed and 14 others injured after a passenger bus rumbled into a stationary truck in Telangana's Suryapet district early Tuesday, with the impact mangle the front of the bus and trapping several passengers inside.

As many as 42 people were travelling in the bus when the accident occurred around 4.45 am near Komarabanda village in Kodad mandal on National Highway-65.

Of those who died, five were women, and one was a man. All victims are from Andhra Pradesh.

"Of the 14 injured, two to three people are critically injured," K Narasimha, Superintendent of Police, Suryapet, told *The Indian Express*. "Five of the 14 injured suffered from head injuries. The rest have suffered fractures."

The Kodad police told *The Indian Express* the electric bus, operated by Esw/Transit Pvt Ltd of Balanagar, Hyderabad, was travelling from Hyderabad to Vijayawada when the accident happened. The truck was travelling to Eluru, the police said.

"In our investigation, it was found that the truck had already met with an accident as it climbed onto the divider even before the bus approached. Half the truck was on the road and half on the divider," Narasimha said. In a statement, CMA A Revanth Reddy expressed deep condolences to the families of those killed in the Suryapet road accident. He directed the chief secretary to ensure that the injured "receive the best possible medical treatment".

Court convicts conman Sukesh for posing as SC judge

Arguments on the quantum of sentence will take place on August 27

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, August 26

A DELHI court last week convicted conman Sukesh Chandra shekar for impersonating a sitting Supreme Court judge in his attempt to pressure another judge to grant him bail in a corruption case.

"He operated under the dangerous belief that if he is only grand enough and uttered with sufficient audacity, the rule of law will simply bow its head and step aside. He forgot that impersonating a bureaucrat or a political broker is a transactional crime born of greed, but impersonating a Supreme Court judge or his secretary is an act of institutional defilement," said Chief Judicial Magistrate Hrishika Mishra in her judgment dated August 20.

The arguments on the quantum of sentence will take place on August 27.

"He assumed the judiciary would respond with the same quiet compliance as his other corporate targets. What Sukesh failed to calculate in his risk assessment is that the judiciary does not negotiate its authority with shadow callers. In attempting to flex non-existent judicial muscles from behind a phone screen, he overplayed his hand so completely that he collapsed his own house of cards," she added while convicting him under Sections 170 (impersonating a public servant), 189 (threat



Sukesh Chandra shekar

of injury to a public servant) and 507 (criminal intimidation through anonymous communication) of the IPC.

The allegations against Chandra shekar pertained to another corruption case which was pending before a Special Judge in Delhi. He was in custody in that case in April 2017. As per the Delhi Police, the conman obtained access to the mobile phone of Constable Manjeet and called the judge who was hearing his corruption case and introduced himself as the personal secretary to a Supreme Court judge.

Another person then allegedly came on the line and claimed to be the SC judge, stating that he was calling on behalf of the Union Home Ministry. The caller directed the Special Judge to release Chandra shekar on interim bail immediately and threatened her with repercussions if she didn't do so.

The Special Judge reached out to the Supreme Court and spoke to the actual private secretary of the SC Judge being impersonated. She was then informed that no such call had been made by the judge's office.

The court also strongly criticised the Delhi Police investigation in the case, describing it as "superficial, shoddy and marked by apathy".

Nuclear power operator plans new design unit to support pvt players

NPCL vertical to help deploy indigenous heavy water technology

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 26

MONTHS AFTER the country's tightly regulated nuclear power sector was opened to private participation, the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL) plans to set up a new design vertical which will provide technological support to private players and state governments seeking to deploy indigenous nuclear reactor technology.

The proposal for the new vertical is currently under process, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

With the draft rules under the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Act — it was enacted in December, 2025 — now released and expected to provide greater clarity on the legal framework around licensing for new nuclear projects once notified, the state-owned company plans to streamline its

E. EXPLAINED

Why PHWRs are key to n-xpansion

Domestic PHWRs are considered the most viable nuclear option, at around Rs 18 crore/MWe, for the price-sensitive Indian power market. Imported Russian, French and US technologies cost a lot more. Established design standards and a mature domestic supply chain are being flagged as key advantages for deployment of PHWRs in the initial phase of nuclear expansion.

interested in setting up PHWR plants. Therefore there is a compelling requirement for a dedicated and independent entity to provide technical support to other utilities," the CEA said.

It suggested that the proposed agency could be established under the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE), with experts drawn from the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC), the Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research

and other specialised DAE units.

Queries sent to the DAE and NPCIL by *The Indian Express* did not elicit a response.

Among global nuclear reactor technologies, India's indigenous PHWR is seen as the most cost-effective option for its price-sensitive power market, where high project costs can undermine nuclear power's competitiveness.

India has seen similar challenges previously. The proposed French-assisted nuclear power project at Jaitapur in Maharashtra has remained stalled for years, with the high projected cost of electricity emerging a key hurdle to its progress.

Industry insiders said foreign reactor technologies such as light water reactors (LWRs) or pressurised water reactors (PWRs) are more expensive than indigenous PHWRs. Some estimates peg the cost of Indian reactors at around Rs 18 crore per megawatt-electric (MWe), compared with about Rs 34 crore per MWe for Russian reactors, while the reactors from France and the US are estimated to cost much more.

"The cost of foreign technologies can be viable in India only with bulk purchases. But that is difficult at this stage as

no one is likely to order 15 or 25 reactors in one go. So, unless the cost of foreign reactors comes down, private players are most likely to initially opt for PHWRs, which are currently more cost-effective," a nuclear industry sector expert told *The Indian Express*.

Industry executives also point to established design standards and a mature domestic supply chain as key advantages for deploying PHWRs during the initial phase of India's nuclear expansion.

Last week, executives from two leading Indian private companies, Adani Atomic Energy and Jindal Steel, said the existing 700 MWe PHWR design could provide a practical starting point for scaling up nuclear capacity, given the availability of established design standards, a mature domestic supply chain and an established ecosystem of vendors and technical expertise.

According to them, foreign reactor technologies and small modular reactors (SMRs) could play a role at a later stage as the sector matures.

Both Adani Group and Jindal Steel are planning to develop 10 GWe and 18 GWe of nuclear capacity, respectively, in the coming years.

'Qualifying standards cannot be diluted': Govt on screening test for foreign medical graduates

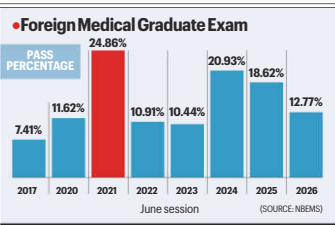
Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, August 26

UNDERLINING THAT the Foreign Medical Graduate (FMG) exam is a screening test for foreign-trained medical students to practice in India and not an entrance examination, officials of the National Board of Education in Medical Sciences that conducts the biannual test have said that qualifying standards for the test should not be diluted.

NBEMS statement comes amid doctors protesting against the high-difficulty level of the test, lack of transparency, and test centre infrastructure, among others. Responding to the doctors, who have been protesting for seven days now, NBEMS officials said, no grace marks will be given to students who gave the test in June, with those who actually prepared passing the examination.

"The minimum qualifying standard exists because doctors must be competent to handle potentially life-threatening situations such as myocardial infarction (heart attack), stroke, sepsis, complicated pregnancy, and paediatric emergencies," said the official.

Even though the overall pass



percentage is low, the official said, the pass percentage among first-timers — those who are more likely to have thoroughly prepared for the test — was higher. The attempt-wise data shows that the pass percentage among first-time candidates was 35.74% as compared to 21.45% among second-time candidates, and 3.29% among those who have appeared over five times.

The official added that the pass rate among first-timers was higher at 47.53% in the December 2025 test, against 5.58% among candidates with more than five attempts. "These figures underline why the overall pass percentage alone cannot be

Manraj Grewal Sharma
Karnal, August 26

IT BEGAN reportedly as a contest between two young men over who was the "baap" (godfather) of Karnal. It had ended up as a show of strength between two caste groups, with a gangster basking in the spotlight.

The saga began with the brazen killing of Biru Balmiki, 25, on the evening of August 5. Two men drew up beside him as he rode his Scooty on Hansi Road and shot him in the head. Karnal, which has only emerged as an epicentre of state politics since Manohar Lal Khattar became the chief minister in 2014 and made it his pocket borough, was stunned by this targeted hit.

More was to follow. Angry over Biru's killing, the Balmiki community brought Karnal to a halt, with community leaders from across the region joining a sit-in held at Karnal, along with Hindu Raksha Dal members.

Local BJP MLA Jagmohan Anand promised swift justice. As protesters shouted "goli ke badle goli" (a bullet for a bullet), the MLA reportedly told them, "Sham tak result milega, kore kaurang pe dastak khati kara lo" (You'll have a result by the evening, get my signature on a blank paper if you want)."

On the morning of August 7, less than two days after Biru was killed, police shot down the two alleged shooters — Harsh, 23, a Ror from Kala Majra near Nikheri, and Birbal, about 29, a Dalit youth from Matara, Kherin Kaithal — in an alleged encounter.

The Rors, a small but in-



Left: The family members hold a portrait of Harsh Kalyan, who was shot dead in a police encounter in Karnal, and (above) Biru Balmiki who was killed on August 25.

fluent upper caste group spread across Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan — which counts javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra and Haryana Speaker Harvinder Kalyan among its own — now took up the hatchet. Pointing out that Harsh and Birbal were not named in the original FIR, they accused police of killing them in a staged encounter.

On August 16, Hindu Raksha Dal members and Balmiki leaders were present for Biru's bhog ceremony, raising slogans of "Jai Bhim, Jai Balmiki and Jai Shri Ram."

On Monday, the Rors held a mahapanchayat in Karnal, calling it the biggest-ever "rosh pradashan (expression of anger)" in the town's history. Nirmal Singh Staudni, a former vice-president of the National Ror Mahasabha, sought justice for Harsh and action against MLA Anand.

The Rors are also demand-

ing a probe by the CBI or a sitting High Court judge, and reject the SIT appointed by the government. They also want the SP to be transferred while the probe is on.

Biru's father Tony and his cousin Ravi Sauda told *The Indian Express* the encounter was justified: "Had Biru killed someone, he would have also met the same fate."

Hovering over both narratives is a 23-year-old who is believed to be based in Europe and alleged to have links with the "Trishul gang" — Vansh Sharma alias 'Shooter Samana', who had threatened Biru in the past, and who has claimed responsibility for his death on Instagram.

After the killing, accounts linked to Sharma called the two dead shooters "shaheed (martyrs)". A newer video shows him displaying weapons and a grenade while talking of a fresh "mission".

in their FIR, was arrested at Mumbai airport on August 16 after deportation from Dubai. Police claim Kapoor has also named Harsh and Birbal as the shooters and said Sharma had arranged the weapons.

"Does this look like the house of a gangster?"

In Kala Majra, a village of around 150 people, about 15 km from Karnal, Harsh's family tells a different story. Orphaned at a young age, they say Harsh dropped out after Class 9 to work as a welder and supported his two younger brothers.

"Look at the condition of this house. Does it look like that of a gangster?" says his uncle Banarsi Das, pointing to the small brick-lined rooms without plaster that leak during rains.

The family also asks what concrete evidence links Harsh to Biru's murder. His brother Rohit, 21, says the CCTV footage provided by police is too grainy to identify the shooters. Kumar also vouches for Harsh, saying he had only been in conflict with the law once, when he was jailed over a matrimonial case last year.

Harsh's wife left him with their daughter seven months ago, and was not present at his cremation.

Nirmal Staudni calls the police version "full of inconsistencies." "We don't want any job or compensation... Give us a CBI probe."

The demand has resonated across the Ror belt spanning Karnal, Kaithal, Kurukshetra, Panchkula, and parts of Sonapat and western UP, driven less by doubt over Harsh's innocence than by fear that the state bent to street pressure.

DESPITE FALLING SHORT ON POLICY AND GOVERNANCE MATTERS, THE CONGRESS-LED REGIME HAS SCORED A HIT WITH ITS ANTI-DRUG CAMPAIGN AND FREE BUS SCHEME FOR WOMEN

100 days of UDF govt in Keralam: CM Satheesan still seeking a firm footing

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 26

OVER ITS first 100 days in office, the Congress-led UDF government in Kerala has yet to leave a decisive imprint on several key policy matters, reflecting the political and organisational constraints facing Chief Minister V D Satheesan.

Unlike the previous CPI(M)-led LDF government, led by a strong political and administrative power centre in Pinayyil Vijayan, the Satheesan government is yet to project a sense of cohesion and direction.

Satheesan does not exercise control over either the Congress organisation or his council of ministers. Differences within the ruling front have delayed action on issues such as PM SHRI and the reconstitution of the Waqf Board. The appointment of private secretaries to some ministers was finalised

only last week after prolonged efforts to build consensus.

Some of Satheesan's Congress colleagues have also publicly declared their loyalty to AICC general secretary K C Veangopal, whom they credit with architecting the UDF's historic victory, winning 102 of the 140 Assembly seats.

In the absence of a strong organisational leadership and a full-time KPCC president, Satheesan has increasingly found himself taking decisions on contentious issues where policy and politics overlap. His first 100 days have also been marked by controversies over appointments. Several decisions were either kept in abeyance or rolled back following opposition from within the party and among alliance partners. This has allowed the Opposition to portray him as a "U-turn Minister".

The delay in reconstituting government boards, corpor-



Several decisions have been kept in abeyance or rolled back following opposition from within the Satheesan-LDF alliance.

members, in accordance with the amended law, have given the Opposition ammunition.

The government had also initially decided to implement PM SHRI, a move the Congress had strongly opposed when the CPI(M)-led government was in power. Following protests from Muslim organisations, the decision was put on hold.

sert its authority over the administration.

The BJP, however, has adopted a different line of attack. With three members in the Assembly, it has sought to portray the Congress-led government as being heavily influenced by Muslim organisations, particularly the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), a key UDF constituent.

A visible anti-drug campaign

Among the government's more visible initiatives have been the anti-drug campaign, Operation Toofan, led by Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala.

The campaign has boosted Chennithala's public profile after he lost the chief ministerial race. It has also received wide acceptance in Kerala society.

Another major decision was the introduction of free bus travel for women in ordinary services operated by the state-

run transport corporation. The measure has been widely welcomed by women and has strengthened the government's welfare credentials. However, it has also added to the financial difficulties faced by a section of private bus operators.

Accessible CM

If the government's first 100 days have produced a mixed record on policy and governance, Satheesan has established a distinctly different style of functioning.

He has sought to make the government more accessible to the public, marking a departure from his predecessor Vijayan. After weekly Cabinet meetings, Satheesan has regularly briefed the media and responded to issues of immediate political and public interest.

Ironically, several controversies during the first 100 days have centred on Satheesan himself. His decision to use a state-

leased helicopter for a private visit drew widespread criticism and questions over propriety.

The road ahead

Policy formulation remains the biggest challenge for the government as it navigates administrative constraints and the competing demands of coalition politics.

The choice of the next KPCC president will be particularly important for Satheesan, who is yet to secure the unequivocal loyalty of his Cabinet colleagues. Satheesan, who also holds the Finance portfolio, was among the most vocal critics of the previous LDF government's financial management. Yet, in his first 100 days, he is yet to offer a clear roadmap to address Kerala's financial crisis, even as the government has loosened its purse strings to provide benefits to various sections of beneficiaries ahead of Onam.

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• HEALTH

How AI can help target protein that contributes to pancreatic cancer

Arnav Chandrasekhar
Bengaluru, August 26

RENOWNED US-BASED medical centre Mayo Clinic recently announced that it has co-developed a cancer treatment with Bengaluru-based artificial intelligence (AI) startup Sravathi AI Technology, under an intellectual property sharing arrangement. This treatment targets a specific protein called GIPCI that, in certain circumstances, can contribute to the growth of many different types of cancer, including pancreatic cancer — one of the deadliest forms of cancer. The findings were published in the scientific journal *Cell Reports*.

A difficult target

GIPCI does not cause cancer on its own. Experts from Sravathi AI said when there is a problem in the expression or signalling of this protein in the body, then cancer cells can use the "pathways" associated with this protein to grow excessively or invade other parts of the body.

Pancreatic ductal adenocarcinoma (PDAC) — the most common type of exocrine pancreatic cancer — remains highly aggressive, with a five-year survival rate under 13.3% owing to late diagnosis, rapid progression, and therapeutic resistance. GIPCI, which is overproduced in PDAC, drives tumour growth and resistance to chemotherapy but has remained "undruggable" due to its PDZ domain.

The PDZ domain is made up of amino acids (also the building blocks of proteins) and is found in the signalling proteins of bacteria, yeast, plants, viruses, and animals.

On why this protein is so hard to target during treatment, Sravathi CEO Parag Tipnis told *The Indian Express*: "Its PDZ domain interacts with multiple proteins through broad, shallow surfaces, making it difficult for conventional small molecules to bind effectively. It is also a signalling hub, so blocking one pathway may not be enough to stop the others that remain active."

DEADLY DISEASE

● Pancreatic ductal adenocarcinoma is the most common and aggressive type of exocrine pancreatic cancer.

● It has a five-year survival rate under 13.3% owing to late diagnosis, rapid progression, and therapeutic resistance.

The treatment

Using advanced computational modeling, machine learning, and predictive analytics, a selective and specific small molecule inhibitor of GIPCI was identified, targeting its PDZ domain. This molecule inhibitor is called GIPCI.

Sravathi's founder Gurram Kishan told *The Indian Express*: "We started with around 40,000 molecules and progressively narrowed them down to five candidates, of which two were synthesised and tested. Generative AI helped us design the initial molecules, while predictive AI was used to assess properties such as toxicity and absorption." "We then used molecular modelling and quantum chemistry to identify the molecules most likely to bind GIPCI, ultimately leading us to the final candidate," Kishan added.

Timeline for human use

Sravathi AI began work on discovering the molecule in 2023, completing their research in about five months. The Mayo Clinic then continued its research, which included animal trials. According to Kishan, if the treatment turns out to be suitable for human use, it could be in use after about three years.

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• LEGAL

OBC creamy layer: Why govt wants clarity from top court on 'rules of the game'

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 26

THE SUPREME COURT Tuesday agreed to constitute a Special Bench to hear the Centre's plea seeking clarification on whether its March 2026 verdict on OBC creamy layer criteria applies to the Civil Services Examination (CSE) 2025, whose results were announced five days before the judgment. The dispute focuses on what happens when a court changes the legal position after an examination process has largely concluded.

The case

The case originated from a Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) letter of October 14, 2004, clarifying an Official Memorandum (OM) of September 1993 on the creamy layer criterion for OBCs. The creamy layer refers to the economically, socially, and educationally advanced members of the OBC category who are excluded from gov-

ernment reservation benefits.

The 1993 OM had excluded income from salary and agricultural sources from the income/wealth test used to determine creamy layer status. The 2004 clarification, however, said the salary income of employees in PSUs and the private sector would be a criterion. This, however, began to be applied rigorously only from CSE-2015.

Since then, around 100 candidates who possessed caste certificates issued by competent authorities and cleared the CSE have found their OBC claims rejected by the DoPT on the creamy layer ground. Most of them are parties in different petitions before the SC and various High Courts. The petitioners argue that this was "hostile discrimination" between the wards of government servants and those of PSUs or private sector employees.

In its judgment on March 11, 2026, the SC ruled that income cannot be the sole criterion for determining the creamy layer among OBCs. The top court had set a six-

month timeline (until September 11) for implementation of its verdict, which the Centre had appeared set to enforce until its plea on Tuesday.

If the judgment is implemented in full, its benefits would extend not only to candidates appearing in future examinations but also to those affected in earlier cycles. It could hence lead to revised ranks for some.

'Rules of the game'

One of the settled principles in service law is that the criteria governing a selection process cannot be changed midway through the process. The Supreme Court has described this as the "rules of the game" doctrine.

A Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in *Tej Prakash Pathak v. Rajasthan High Court* (2024) held that "the rules of the game, meaning thereby, that the criteria for selection cannot be altered by the authorities concerned in the middle or after the process of selection has commenced".

The principle exists to protect candidates who enter a recruitment or admission process based on a particular set of rules. Once the process begins, courts have generally been reluctant to let authorities introduce new criteria or change existing ones midway.

Recent NEET matter

In January 2026, the Supreme Court applied the same principle to an admissions dispute in *Dijoy Sekhon v. State of Punjab*. The case concerned admissions to MBBS and BDS courses under Punjab's sports quota. After the prospectus had been issued and candidates had applied, the state widened the eligibility criteria for the quota.

The court held that "it is well-settled that the rules of the game cannot be altered once the game has begun", adding that the principle was "just as applicable to admission processes to educational courses as it would be to recruitment processes".

Having found the revised criteria un-

lawful, the court then turned to the question of relief. Ordinarily, it noted, it could have directed the entire merit list to be redrawn. However, it declined to do so, observing that such an exercise would affect candidates who were not before it and would "unsettle settled matters".

The Centre's plea

In its application before the SC, the government has argued that the March 11 judgment "altering settled position" on creamy layer criteria was delivered five days after the final result of CSE-2025 had already been declared. It has said that CSE-2025 "stood substantially concluded prior to the pronouncement of the judgment" and is presently at the "terminal stage of service allocation".

The Centre further argued that a "mechanical or unqualified application of the ratio of the said judgment, with retrospective effect, to the already-concluded selection process of CSE-2025" would create "a peculiar and acute anomaly amounting to discrimi-

nation inter se candidates of the very examination cycle sought to be benefited".

According to the government, reopening category-wise merit lists at this stage would have a cascading effect on training schedules, batch strength, cadre allocation, seniority, and pay fixation.

Those concerns also resemble the considerations that pushed the court in *Dijoy Sekhon* not to redraw an entire admission list after finding the governing rule unlawful. But in that case, the court moulded the relief in a manner that avoided disrupting students who had already secured admissions and were not before the court.

The Centre's plea has asked the court to clarify that the March 11 judgment should not be applied "with retrospective effect" to the "already-concluded selection process of CSE-2025" so as to "unsettle completed admissions in higher educational institutions, completed academic sessions, degrees already conferred, or settled rights of students".

• GEOPOLITICS

Strikes to sanctions: The limits of US moves on Iran



EXPERT EXPLAINS

BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH, DELHI

ON MONDAY, the US threatened to impose severe sanctions on any country or entity that maintains economic ties with Iran.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, who announced Operation Economic Outcast, termed it "Economic D-Day", a reference to the June 1944 Allied offensive against Nazi-occupied France.

The US has issued fresh sanctions against Iran's digital assets, technology, gold, aviation and shipping sectors, with the Office of Foreign Assets Control sanctioning "nearly 60 entities, individuals, and vessels in multiple jurisdictions that enable the Iranian regime's recklessness". These include sanctions against firms across countries such as China, UK, France, Singapore, UAE and Ukraine.

In the hours following the announcement, Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces, Asim Munir, made his second trip to Tehran since the March war. Islamabad described the visit as part of its efforts to "promote regional peace and stability". Al Arabiya also reported that Munir spoke to US President Donald Trump in the lead-up to the visit.

These interlinked developments come at a time when the US appears to be shifting away from its military strategy that has failed to dislodge the Iranian regime. Both countries are entering a *de facto* ceasefire following the expiry of the interim peace framework's 60-day implementation period. What do these developments mean for any future US-Iran negotiations?

D-Day sanctions

The US's new "Economic D-Day" sanctions are only the latest in a series of sanctions regimes that Washington has had in place against Iran since 1979, the year of the revolution. President Trump intensified these sanctions through his "maximum pressure" campaign in his first term (2017-2021). While the Joe Biden administration diluted this campaign's measures, the second Trump administration renewed them

• IRANIAN CURRENCY IN FREEFALL

One US dollar now costs 2 million rials in Iran.



in February 2025.

This meant that by the time the US attacked Iran a year later, the Iranian economy was reeling from inflation crossing 50% (near hyperinflation), national per capita income dropping to about \$5,000, rising youth unemployment and the rial in near free-fall. The currency has now fallen to around 2 million rial per US dollar.

Hence, despite the US's aggressive framing of these sanctions, they only represent the intensification of its historic economic outlook towards Iran.

On August 25, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio reportedly said Washington was pivoting from strikes to sanctions, indicating an apparent US disinclination for resuming military action. This comes even as Iran continues to strike tankers passing through the US-backed southern channel near Oman in the Strait of Hormuz.

Limited effects of sanctions

Historically, US sanctions on Iran have proven to have limited deterrence effect. Despite their adverse economic effect, the principal affected party is the citizenry of Iran with government actors consolidating power further as the sole arbiters of resources. It was the George Bush administration that shifted from blanket sanctions to targeted financial and sectoral ones in 2005 and 2006. President Barack Obama expanded and intensified this targeted approach through the Comprehensive Iran Sanctions, Accountability, and Divestment Act in 2010.

Trump, however, triggered a reversal

through the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act sanctions regime in his first term.

Now, the imposition of the D-Day sanctions reflects the limits of military means as an effective coercion instrument against the Islamic republic. But they also represent a large-scale unleashing of Washington's lessons from its history of economic coercion against Tehran. Iran has near-continually been the most heavily sanctioned country in this century. Its sustained ability to both prevent regime collapse as well as to militarily respond to American attacks successfully in 2026 have already proved the ineffectiveness of Washington's historic economic measures.

Tehran's popularisation of a "resistance economy" has meant that the current Iranian generation has been forced to largely normalise living conditions under external economic duress (supplemented by internal corruption).

While this has indeed meant frequent popular pressure on the regime through demonstrations, the current war-time conditions and mood of national solidarity mean that the Trump administration's nationwide economic targeting will only harden Tehran's resolve. Arguably, such conditions can also help the Iranian government find greater public acceptance for increased austerity measures to absorb the impact of the new sanctions.

It is worth remembering that the new American sanctions are not occurring in a pre-February 2026 reality — when the regime did have any organic trigger for na-

War and peace

The US has issued fresh sanctions against Iran's digital assets, technology, gold, aviation and shipping.

Meanwhile, Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces, Asim Munir, made his second trip to Tehran since the March war as part of efforts to 'promote regional peace'.



A market in Tehran's Grand Bazaar. AP

Amid signs of Pakistani mediation, the US seems to be adopting an economic strategy against Iran. But this may do little to improve its bargaining position

tional solidarity, was reeling from the effects of the December-January anti-government demonstrations and was negotiating with the US for nuclear concessions in exchange for relief from existing sanctions.

Rather, Iran's solidified control over the Strait of Hormuz following the US-Israeli war has left it with economic leverage to meet economic coercion. It is arguably the adverse impact on energy shipping through the narrow waterway that was among the prominent triggers for the pivot Rubio referred to.

Renewal of mediation?

For Iran, the D-Day sanctions do not represent any new US posture, apart from Washington's reduced appetite for military exchanges. Rather, it hardens Iran's leaning that escalation is the only way to deal with Washington's attempts to undermine its bargaining power.

Indeed, Tehran's escalatory actions since the war began — from strikes on Gulf countries to attacks on shipping, especially vessels following the US-approved route — have improved Iran's bargaining position in negotiations for a final deal.

For Washington, the new economic measures (despite their effects being old) allow the Trump administration to project strength and cushion its potential return to negotiations with Tehran after military failure. Iran itself specifically requires the US to return to the framework and uphold Article 5 — which provides for joint Omani-Iranian administration of Hormuz. This was among Iran's demands from the US, conveyed through Munir, as reported by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps-affiliated *Tasnim News*.

In any case, Iran and Oman are continuing to discuss Article 5's implementation. On Tuesday, the Omani Foreign Minister asserted that both sides expected to announce a joint temporary transit corridor through the Strait of Hormuz and joint mine clearing operations soon. US President claimed on the same day that the strait had been cleared of all mines. On Wednesday, Iran and Oman reached agreements on their share of Hormuz and revenues.

Iran will feel the need to continue proving its readiness for continued fighting (at least until the US mid-term elections in November), alongside indirect negotiations with the US through Pakistan, Turkey, while D-Day sanctions or fresh US strikes on Iran might trigger a resumption of war, both sides remain focused on bettering their bargaining positions.

• GLOBAL

\$100,000 fee for H-1B: The new legal route Trump is pursuing

Soumyendra Barik
New Delhi, August 26

BARELY TWO months after a US court struck down a \$100,000 charge on new H-1B visa petitions, the Donald Trump-led US administration is trying to impose it again. This time, through a formal rulemaking process and under a different provision of immigration law.

The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) has proposed an additional \$103,265 fee on every H-1B petition subject to the annual visa cap. The amount would be paid by the sponsoring employer at the time of filing, on top of existing H-1B fees. The proposal is not yet in force — after seeking public comments for 30 days, the DHS would have to issue a final rule. US Vice President JD Vance has backed the move.

Indians, who are the biggest beneficiaries of the visa programme, stand to lose the most if the proposal goes through.

The proposal

The H-1B programme allows US employers to hire foreign workers in "specialty occupations", typically jobs requiring at least

a bachelor's degree. The US Congress caps new H-1Bs at 65,000 a year, with another 20,000 available to people with a master's or higher degree from a US university.

The new \$103,265 charge would apply to these cap-subject petitions, including the advanced-degree category. It would not apply to cap-exempt H-1B petitions, including many filed by universities, non-profit research institutions, and government research organisations.

DHS estimates the fee would raise about \$8.8 billion annually, assuming 85,000 fee-paying petitions. Unlike a normal visa processing charge, the money is meant to support costs across the wider immigration system.

The proposal also makes clear that the policy has a labour-market objective. DHS says a six-figure charge would make employers less likely to choose an H-1B worker over a qualified American unless they genuinely need the foreign worker's specialised skills.

Why earlier fee was scrapped

Trump had imposed the earlier charge through a September 2025 presidential di-

Under lens

● Critics question whether the H-1B programme is being used for its original purpose — allowing companies to fill specialised jobs for which sufficiently skilled American workers are unavailable — or as a route to access cheaper foreign labour.

● The Trump administration argues that some companies, particularly in tech, have continued to hire H-1B workers even while laying off American staffers.

rective, relying on provisions of the Immigration and Nationality Act that allow the president to restrict the entry of foreigners deemed detrimental to US interests.

This June, a US federal court ruled that the \$100,000 payment functioned as a tax, not merely an entry restriction. Since the Constitution gives Congress the power to levy taxes, the court held that the immigration provisions cited by Trump did not clearly authorise the President to impose such a charge. Upon appeal, the First Circuit Court of Appeals in July refused to pause the lower court's order.

The biggest difference in the new approach is the legal route. Instead of relying primarily on presidential authority to restrict entry, DHS is invoking its statutory power under Section 286 of the Immigration and Nationality Act to set fees that recover the costs of immigration adjudication and naturalisation services. It is also going through notice-and-comment rulemaking rather than imposing the fee directly by proclamation.

That does not necessarily insulate the policy from another lawsuit, however. DHS itself acknowledges that it has not histori-

cally charged one narrow class of immigration applicants to fund such broad costs across multiple agencies, including programmes with which H-1B employers may have no direct connection.

Impact on Indian workers

US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) data show that people born in India accounted for 7% of all approved H-1B petitions in FY2024. People born in China came a distant second, hovering at the 12-13% mark since 2018.

Between October 2022 and September 2023, 72% of the nearly 41akh H-1B visas issued went to Indian nationals. During the same period, top four Indian IT majors with a presence in the US — Infosys, TCS, HCL, and Wipro — got approval for around 20,000 employees to work on the H-1B visa, as per USCIS data.

Industry body Nasscom has urged Washington to weigh the programme's role in filling short-term skills gaps, while pointing out that Indian technology companies have expanded local hiring in the US and reduced their dependence on H-1B workers.

Himalayan tsunami shatters Nepal

'Saved by mango tree': Survivors recount chaos as torrent sweeps away homes

Reuters
Kathmandu, August 26

NEPALI LABOURER Bibek Kumal was digging a toilet pit outside a newly built house on Wednesday when a wall of water, mud and rock came roaring down, sweeping him and everything near him away.

Kumal, 24, was working in Bidur, downstream from the worst-hit Rasuwa district, near Nepal's Himalayan border with China's Tibet, when he heard a hissing sound. His four co-workers, standing above the five-foot deep pit, shouted at him to get out and run. By the time he scrambled out of the pit, his co-workers had already fled.

"I started running. Then a wall of water came thundering down as if it was an earthquake," Kumal said from his bed at Kathmandu's National Trauma Centre, his brother Dinesh sitting beside him.

The torrent swept him downstream amid mud and debris, but "luckily I was stuck up in a mango tree," he said. "Had there been no mango tree, I'd have been washed away to death."

Three others also injured in the flood were being treated alongside Kumal, as more people were transported to the capital Kathmandu. Authorities said they rescued over 114 people who were being treated at hospitals in Kathmandu and Rasuwa.

Outside the hospital, well-wishers, friends and onlookers crowded the small compound of the trauma centre.

The flood, triggered after what appeared to be the collapse of a mass of mud and rock into a



Damaged houses stand near the swollen, debris-choked banks of the Trishuli River after flash floods in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Wednesday. **AP**

river on the frontier between Nepal and Tibet, devastated settlements and infrastructure downstream. The exact cause of the mudslide was not clear, but the German Research Centre for Geosciences said there was a 4.4-magnitude quake about seven minutes before the time shown on the security footage time-stamp.

Survivor Kumal said as he clung to the mango tree, he watched the house where he had been working disappear.

In the hospital bed opposite him, 11-year-old Rihana Lamichhane narrowly escaped. "I was at school. They closed school because of this and asked us to go home," she said. "As I was crossing the river, suddenly flood water came gushing down."

She suffered injuries to her chest and leg but said: "I am happy to be safe. I have no idea what happened to my friends."



• WHAT TRIGGERED THE DELUGE?

WHAT HAPPENED?
Torrential floods swallowed roads, bridges, houses, and power projects in the border areas of Nepal, and triggered a mudslide that hit Ghyrong Port, a major land crossing with neighbouring Tibet.

WHAT CAUSED CALAMITY?
It is suspected that an earthquake struck the region and triggered an ice-rock avalanche on the Hende Khola river in Nepal. The river runs through both Nepal and Tibet.



ARE ANY FOREIGNERS MISSING?
Apart from many Indians, three US citizens, 12 British citizens, 8 South Koreans have been reported missing. The other missing included 17 Malaysian nationals, 4 South Africans, and one each from Australia and the Netherlands.

HAS THE DANGER PASSED?
Authorities have warned a second flood may occur since a blockage lodged upstream on the Hende Khola river.

THE SITUATION NOW
Police and military personnel were engaged in rescue efforts, although officials have said rescue helicopters would not be able to land in the affected areas until the waters recede.

A boy looks at the devastation caused by flash floods along the Trishuli River in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Wednesday. **AP**

U.S. MUST ACCEPT OUR TERMS: TEHRAN

Iran & Oman still working on Strait accord; waterway remains blocked

IRGC claims two countries agreed on how to share passage, revenues

Reuters
Cairo, Dubai, August 26

IRAN AND Oman are still working on the details of an agreement on the Strait of Hormuz, a senior Iranian source said Wednesday, after Iran's Revolutionary Guards said the two countries had agreed how to share the waterway and its revenues.

The elite force's spokesperson, echoing Tehran's official stance, also said the Strait would not open unless the US met Tehran's conditions under an interim ceasefire agreement that was struck in June before unravelling. Those conditions include an end to the US blockade on Iranian ports, compensation and removal of sanctions.

Most shipping has since been shut down, driving global energy prices higher, as Tehran and Washington have tried to assert control over the channel, imposing separate blockades.

"An agreement with Oman over the Strait of Hormuz has not been finalised," the senior Iranian source told Reuters, adding that the talks were continuing on the details of an accord.

A spokesperson for Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said Iran and Oman had reached an agreement on their shares of the territory and revenues.

"The Strait of Hormuz be-

India and China can help resolve conflict: Hillary

New York: India and China could be among key players who could contribute to resolving the West Asia conflict if US President Donald Trump wants to use "diplomacy instead of bluster", said former Secretary of State Hillary Clinton.

Talking about the conflict, Clinton, in an interview with C-SPAN, said: "The misconceptions on a strategic level have led us to where we are."

"If you want to figure out how Trump could get out of this, I think the key to it is probably China and India, because if you look at who buys the most oil and gas from Iran, it's China and India," said Clinton. **PTI**

longs to Iran and the country of Oman... We have been in negotiations with Oman for about a month, and we have reached results that are acceptable to both sides," Hossain Mohiuddin said.

"In these negotiations, agreements have been reached regarding the share of each country in the waters of the Strait and the share of Iran and Oman's revenues," he added.

Following talks on Tuesday between Iran and Oman, Omani Foreign Minister Badr Albusaidi said he was "hopeful that we will soon announce a temporary corridor for the Strait of Hormuz and practical arrangements to restore safe navigation".

• BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

Tim Curry, actor famed for Rocky Horror Picture Show, dies at 80



Tim Curry at the 59th Annual Tony Awards in New York, June 5, 2005.

TIM CURRY, the baritone-voiced British actor who pranced to movie fame as a singing, lingerie-clad "sweet transvestite" in the 1975 cult classic *The Rocky Horror Picture Show*, has died at the age of 80, *Variety* and other outlets reported. A cause of death was not given, but Curry had been in ill for some time. Curry appeared in several movies, often as a hammy villain, was nominated thrice for a Tony Award for Broadway roles, and performed voice work in animated films. **REUTERS**

SLOVAKIA

Govt proposes banning social media for kids

SLOVAKIA'S GOVERNMENT approved a bill on Wednesday proposing a ban on use of social networks by children under 16, saying it would help prevent addictive behaviour, social pressure and radicalisation. The law, if approved by parliament, will ban setting up social network accounts for younger children and require proving the user's age. **REUTERS**

HAITI

Over 50 killed, 47 kidnapped in gang attack

AT LEAST 47 people were killed and more than 50 others kidnapped when armed men attacked a once-peaceful community near Haiti's capital earlier this week, the UN said Tuesday. "This is a major political test, for the government..." said Romain Le Cour, head of the Haiti Observatory at Global Initiative Against Transnational Organized Crime. **AP**

Xi orders rescue efforts, US expresses sorrow; 8 workers missing; Seoul

Agencies

Kathmandu, Beijing, Seoul, August 26

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping has ordered all-out efforts to search for and rescue people missing, while the US Embassy in Nepal has expressed profound sorrow over the tragic loss of life and widespread devastation caused by the flash flood.

A total of 145 officers and sol-

diers from the Xigaze detachment of the People's Armed Police have been sent to the mudslide-hit border port to assist with emergency response operations. China's Tibet Autonomous Region shares a roughly 1,400-km border with Nepal.

The mudslide struck near Ghyrong Port on Wednesday. Drone footage showed some buildings at the port buried by debris, Chinese official media re-

ported. State-run *Global Times* reported that the local government was dispatching personnel to the disaster-hit area, where communications had been cut off. The Chinese Embassy in Nepal activated its emergency response mechanism after a flash flood struck the Ghyrong-Rasuwa area in northern Nepal Wednesday, the report said.

The embassy assessed the situation of Chinese citizens

and enterprises in the affected area and urged the Nepalese government and agencies to carry out rescue efforts.

The US Embassy, extending heartfelt sympathies to those impacted, said: "We are deeply saddened by the tragic loss of life and devastation caused by the Bhoté Koshi flood that struck Rasuwa district and communities downstream."

The diplomatic mission

confirmed it is closely tracking developments and maintaining continuous communication with Nepali authorities as rescue, relief, and recovery operations unfold across regions.

South Korea's Foreign Ministry said Wednesday eight South Koreans working on a hydro-power plant were missing, and 10 others were stranded.

The workers were employed by Korea Energy and Doosan

Enerbility Co, the ministry said, adding that Nepal has deployed a rescue team to search the affected area. Another 10 South Korean workers affiliated with Doosan Enerbility were stranded in the area and awaiting a helicopter sent by Nepalese authorities to evacuate them.

14 newborns killed in blaze at a hospital nursery in Islamabad

Press Trust of India
Islamabad, August 26

AT LEAST 14 infants were killed on Wednesday after a massive fire broke out in a gynaecology ward of a major hospital in Pakistan's capital Islamabad, authorities said. The fire occurred around 7 am at the state-run Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences (PIMS), the largest public hospital in the capital.

In a statement, the Islamabad administration said 14 newborns were killed when the fire broke out on the third floor of the hospital's mother and child ward. PIMS Spokesperson Dr Aneezah Jilil told the Dawn newspaper that 15 babies were in

the ward. "At least one baby was saved by a doctor," she said.

The administration statement said rescue teams were rushed to the scene, with six fire brigade vehicles and four ambulances taking part in operation.

"The fire was immediately brought under control," it said, adding an inquiry committee headed by additional deputy commissioner general had been formed to probe the incident.

PIMS spokesperson Jilil said the fire appeared to have been caused by a short circuit and added that the flames had been extinguished, but the cooling process would take some time.

Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif summoned a high-level meet-

ing of the Islamabad administration to discuss the incident. The PMO said in a statement that the prime minister had suspended the federal Health Secretary Muhammad Aslam Ghauri.

Expressing grief over the incident, PM Sharif directed an immediate probe. "I am heartbroken at this tragic incident and share parents' grief," he said.

He also ordered a high-level inquiry committee, headed by former interior secretary Shahid Khan, to probe the incident.

President Asif Ali Zardari also expressed deep grief and sorrow over the incident, calling the deaths of the newborn babies "extremely heartbreaking and an irreparable loss".

Trump pauses immigrant visa process for applicants worldwide

US may also revoke business & tourism visas of almost 2,00,000 foreigners

Reuters
Washington, August 26

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump's administration has issued a pause on immigrant visa appointments for applicants globally during an ongoing immigration crackdown by the US government in Trump's second term in the White House.

A US State Department spokesperson said Tuesday it

launched a global training initiative at all US embassies and consulates worldwide and appointments for visa services will be adjusted to accommodate the training.

The crackdown has faced some legal setbacks. A US judge Friday struck down a Trump administration policy suspending the issuance of immigrant visas to applicants from 75 countries, saying that the policy exceeded Secretary of State Marco Rubio's statutory authority.

The State Department did not specify details on the training and its timeline, beyond saying the training aimed to help consular officers screen out applicants deemed likely to be-

come dependent on US public benefits and to ensure evaluation of visa applicants "comprehensively and consistently".

The administration is also preparing to revoke business and tourism visas of up to 200,000 foreigners who have applied for or are currently seeking asylum status in the US, making it the single largest mass revocation of visas in US history and likely to face legal challenges.

Unless challenged or revised, the State Department is expected to announce in the coming weeks the revocation of so-called B1 and B2 visas issued between 2016 and 2026 whose holders have sought asylum or are now seeking asylum.



Instagram CEO Adam Mosseri arrives to testify in the landmark case over social media harm to children, in Los Angeles. **FILE**

nied wrongdoing in agreeing to settle. The total payout represents about three to four months of profit for the Menlo Park, California-based company.

"Ensuring teens have a safe and productive experience on our platforms is an absolute im-

perative for Meta," the company said in a blog post. "We want to get this right for parents and teens." The settlements include maximum payments of about \$177 billion to 48 US states, Washington, Puerto Rico, American Samoa and the Northern Mariana Islands.

California could receive a \$2.2 billion payout, while New York and Texas could each receive more than \$1 billion.

Some states will deposit funds they receive in general accounts while others will earmark portions to address children's mental health. Meta guaranteed payments of about \$12.7 billion, with another \$5 billion contingent on whether Snap Inc's

Shapchat, ByteDance's TikTok and Alphabet's YouTube impose similar protections for children. Those companies were not available for comment.

"This is a big deal," said James Speta, a Northwestern University law professor who specializes in telecommunications and internet policy.

"Meta and other companies were facing pressure to change business practices whether or not they lost the lawsuits. From the public and from Congress and state legislatures," he continued. "These restrictions will change experience on Instagram and Facebook, and are designed to reduce engagement." Wednesday's settlements

also call for Meta to pay \$459 million to resolve states' privacy claims related to the Cambridge Analytica scandal, while British consulting firm collected personal data of Facebook users without authorisation.

Instagram head Adam Mosseri had begun testifying, and Meta Chief Executive Mark Zuckerberg had been expected to testify. At a Wednesday hearing, Gonzalez Rogers called the settlements "a step forward" and said she expected to grant approval. "I don't want to suggest there's anything with this agreement that I am particularly concerned with," the judge said. "I am quite happy to not have to finish up this trial." **REUTERS**

• WHILE META WILL NOT UNDERGO A FUNDAMENTAL OVERHAUL, THE ACCORDS COULD PROVIDE A TEMPLATE FOR RESOLVING THOUSANDS OF OTHER LAWSUITS AGAINST SOCIAL MEDIA COMPANIES

Meta agrees to pay \$18 bn to settle lawsuits over children's social media addiction

Diana Novak Jones & Jonathan Stempel
Oakland, August 26

META PLATFORMS will pay up to \$18 billion and strictly limit how teenagers use Facebook and Instagram under a sweeping agreement with nearly all US states to resolve claims it designed those social media platforms to addict children.

The settlements announced on Wednesday end federal over allegations Meta's products harmed children and the company misled the public about their safety. Four of the states — California, Colorado, Kentucky and New Jersey — were expected to seek close to \$200 bil-

lion in civil penalties. While Meta will not undergo a fundamental overhaul, the accords represent a sweeping effort to define how it serves young users.

It could provide a template for resolving thousands of other lawsuits against social media companies. Governments around the world are trying to curb children's access to harmful online content, including a ban in Australia on social media for children under 16.

"The focus of this case was to protect our kids," Colorado Attorney General Phil Weiser said in a statement. "The relief we are getting in this settlement is very meaningful and well beyond what any court has ordered or is

likely to order."

Meta agreed over the next decade to restrict teenagers' use of Facebook and Instagram to two hours a day and block all usage from midnight to 6 am, absent parental consent.

These limits could be tightened if the social media platforms Snapchat, TikTok and YouTube add similar terms. Meta will also disable most push notifications to teenage users during school hours of 8 am to 3 pm and enhance measures to prevent children from accessing age-restricted content.

The settlement does not require Meta to abandon personalized recommendations or targeted advertising. Meta de-

US' HANDLING OF ITS RISING BORROWING COST HAS PUT MARKETS ON EDGE

As US debt hits \$40 trillion, all eyes on Fed's Warsh at Jackson Hole

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 26

THIS WEEK, some of the most important policymakers and economists in the world will gather in Wyoming for the annual Jackson Hole Economic Policy Symposium, hosted by the Federal Reserve Bank of Kansas City.

And while the three-day event starting Thursday is always keenly eyed, this year's edition has assumed even more importance given the events that have occurred in the last couple of months.

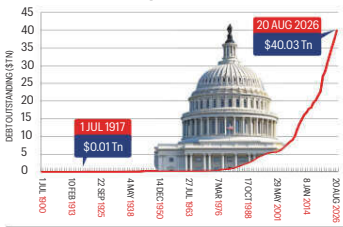
In what will be his first speech as the Chairman of the US Federal Reserve, Kevin Warsh on Friday will deliver the keynote remarks. While pressure is on Warsh to communicate better, expectations are not high. "Given Warsh's approach to communication so far, he may provide even fewer clues on near-term monetary policy than markets currently expect," Terpe Inno, Tokyo Head of Global Markets Research at MUFG Bank, said on Monday.

Bond buyback

Tensions have been high in global financial markets over the last couple of months, with matters coming to a head last week when the US' total debt crossed \$40 trillion, or about 120% of its GDP.

It has taken less than five years for the US debt to reach this point after breaching \$30 trillion in January 2022. Revenues have taken a hit from President Donald Trump's 2017 tax cuts, while spending surged

How US' debt has spiralled



SOURCE: US DEPARTMENT OF TREASURY

during Covid. The One Big Beautiful Bill Act is seen raising US debt by \$4.7 trillion. The result has been an increase in US government bond yields.

In an attempt to cool long-term yields, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessant last week said the government would buy back at least double the bonds it had already said it would.

These bond buybacks — done to improve trading by removing bonds that aren't bought or sold regularly — are supposed to take place in the eight weeks starting September 9, a period that coincides with the US midterm elections.

Yield problem

Buying back bonds increases demand for them, which raises their price. Since bond prices and yields move in opposite directions, a rise in prices reduces yields.

Bond yields — which is the cost at which the government

borrowed to bridge the difference between its income and expenditure — have been a major issue for the US government. High bond yields mean interest rates in the economy stay elevated, which weighs on economic activity.

On February 27, the day before the US and Israel attacked Iran, the 10-year bond yield was 3.97%, while the 30-year bond was trading at 4.64%.

On August 17, the day before US debt hit \$40 trillion, the 10-year yield was 4.72% and the 30-year at 5.31% — the highest in almost 20 years.

To help Japan — and indirectly, itself — the US assisted in the defence of the yen.

From New York to Tokyo

This is not the first step the Trump administration has taken to contain US bond yields. Late July, the US sold euros and bought the yen to prop up the Japanese currency, which had slumped to a 40-year low of 164-per-dollar. But why is the yen the US' headache? For Japan to stabilise its currency, it would have to sell dollars and buy the yen. And it can only get hold of dollars by selling some of the US government bonds in its possession — which would push down prices of these bonds and raise US yields. Japan, as it turns out, owns the most US government bonds: \$1.12 trillion of it as of June, having sold \$123 billion of them since February.

To help Japan — and indirectly, itself — the US assisted in the defence of the yen.

Fiscal credibility

The problem with Bessant's plan to lower US yields is markets' lack of confidence in it. According to economists, the long-term solution to high bond yields is a credible blueprint to

improve government finances, with interest payments now making up 15% of all spending at the federal level.

"...ultimately, policymakers will eventually need to address the deficit by raising taxes or cutting expenditure," ANZ economists said Monday.

But room to cut spending is limited, with ANZ estimating around 60% of federal spending is mandated by existing legislation. Another 12-13% or so is defence spending, which is set to rise.

Dollar debasement

Given all of the above, markets think a weaker dollar lies ahead. According to Chen Zhao, Chief Global Strategist at Oxford Economics' Alpine Macro, while controlling bond yields is not unusual, it can have its costs, with the direct impact being a fall in the dollar's value.

"Importantly, the (yield) curve management, together with the joint currency intervention with Japan to prop up the yen last month, suggests that the US government does not mind having a weaker dollar," Zhao said on Monday.

A weaker dollar also encourages the dollar debasement trade that became popular in 2025 and led to the historic rise in the price of gold. A weaker dollar makes commodities that are priced in the US currency cheaper. But if the dollar weakens, what happens to US inflation? This question brings us back to Warsh and his speech at Jackson Hole on Friday.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

COMMERCE MINISTER PIYUSH GOYAL'S JAPAN TOUR

'Uniqlo, other Japanese textile cos to step up India sourcing'

Sandeep Singh & Ravi Dutta Mishra
Tokyo/New Delhi, August 26

COMMERCE MINISTER Piyush Goyal on Wednesday said that Japanese textile companies, including one of the largest in the world, Uniqlo, would step up sourcing input material from India and would also increase investment in India to export textile goods across the globe from India.

This comes after India is expected to get major concessions from FTA partners including the US, EU, UK and Canada.

"My meetings with some of the largest importers and marketing companies of textiles give me the confidence that we will see a larger presence in India, both as investment to expand their business in India and to source from India for Japan and for the roughly 4,000 stores which one company has in India with 4 trillion yen turnover — Uniqlo. Incidentally, non-tariffs are barriers. I would consider them as barriers; I would consider them as very high quality regulations, particularly in food items," Goyal said while responding to a question on whether Japan will lower non-tariff barriers on Indian textile exports. Goyal said that businesses in Japan and India are both very much committed to working together and there is a lot of interest on both sides for technology transfer, for making India a manufacturing base for the world, along with a large Indian domestic market.

The minister said that both sides are committed to new technologies, adding that India and Japan have discussed semi-

In 10 mths, Japan invested Rs 1 lakh cr out of 10-year target of Rs 7 lakh cr: Goyal

Tokyo/New Delhi: Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal on Wednesday said that Japan is one of India's most strategic partners and India is working to expand the scope, scale and extent of the engagement.

The statement came at a time when India and Japan are expected to review their 2011 trade deals. New Delhi is concerned over a widening trade deficit with Tokyo.

Japan has announced to invest a trillion yen (about Rs 7 lakh crore) in India over one decade. He said that India has received about Rs one lakh crore in investments from that target in about 10 months.

"We haven't got down to work on terms of reference, but I think once the teams have discussed, we will be open to expanding the scope, scale and extent of the engagement

because Japan today is one of our most strategic partners," he added. The commerce ministry is also supporting industry and exporters in registering their products to meet regulatory requirements, the minister said.

He added that under the export promotion mission scheme, the ministry will facilitate and support micro and small businesses in undertaking expensive registrations such as the European Union's registering chemicals in the EU (REACH) regulations for chemicals.

"For the pharma industry, I have also requested to start registrations all across the world...they should all look at registering across the world, including Japan," he said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

conductors and the entire ecosystem, especially chemicals, gases, equipment, raw materials, design, manufacturing, packaging, shipbuilding, ship breaking, and ship repair.

"We have also had discussions on the textile sector also. We earlier had an experience that the textile industry was not able to crack the Japanese requirements. Sizes are different, they are so used to the US and Europe. Japanese materials, sizes and styles are differ-

ent. I suspect that the Indian industry did not take as much interest as they should have. Two delegations of the apparel export promotion council, now they are showing interest in understanding the Japanese requirements," Goyal said.

Japan is the fourth largest garment importer in the world after the US, Germany and France.

Singh is in Tokyo at the invitation of FICCI. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

PSU banks more efficient than private peers: EAC-PM

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 26

IN A surprising find, an analysis by the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) has found that government-run banks are more efficient than private banks, with the last three years in particular seeing public sector lenders improving their position.

In a paper titled 'Reforms, Efficiency, and Productivity of Indian Banking Sector in the Last Decade: A DEA Approach', authors Soumya Kanti Ghosh and Tapas Kumar Parida found that "contrary to popular perceptions", the efficiency of public sector banks (PSBs) stood at 93.12% in 2025-26.

In comparison, private banks were operating at 86.02%. Foreign banks were at 85.88%. An efficiency score of under 100% means the bank can produce the same output by reducing its inputs.

For instance, if the efficiency score of a bank is 85%, then it can reduce its inputs by 15% (100% minus 85%) and still have the same output.

with a score of 88.53% as against 85.62%. Foreign banks scored the highest, with 88.98%. However, their efficiency score has declined sharply from 95.86% in 2014-15.

DEA refers to data envelopment analysis, a method used to understand performance. It measures the relative efficiency of decision-making units that produce the same goods or services.

Apart from being a part-time member of the EAC-PM, Ghosh is the State Bank of India's Group Chief Economic Advisor. Parida is an economist in SBI's Economic Research Department.

The unexpected finding comes days after Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman told officials of state-run banks that they had to raise their 'cool' quotient in the eyes of the country's youth without sacrificing the prudence the business requires.

The Finance Minister had also said that PSBs "still give the impression of a government bank".

HSBC, JPMorgan, SBI, HDFC on top

While several banks clocked the maximum efficiency score of 100% in 2025-26, only two

maintained that score across the 12 years covered by the paper: HSBC and JPMorgan Chase. As per Ghosh and Parida, the efficiency of foreign banks is better than domestic ones "mostly due to their previous business models".

Among private lenders, HDFC Bank was the most efficient from 2014-15 to 2025-26, with a score of 97.54%. SBI, at 97.49%, was only marginally behind, the leader among PSBs. Interestingly, IDBI Bank — which the government has been trying to sell for years — has been the seventh-most efficient bank over the last 12 years, with SBI being the only PSB to rank ahead of it.

A variety of factors can affect the efficiency scores of any bank. For instance, the lowest score of any of the 47 banks examined by Ghosh and Parida was for DBS Bank India's 40.12% in 2021-22. This, the paper said, may be due the merger of Laxmi Villages Bank with DBS Bank India in 2020.

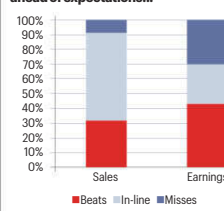
"PSBs are relatively more efficient than private banks except FY19-FY22, which may be due to merger and rationalisation of business branches, and employees," the paper added.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

INDIA INC'S Q1 RESULTS RESILIENT DESPITE OIL SHOCK

Despite the oil shock from the West Asia conflict, earnings of about 70% of Indian companies in the April-June quarter were either in line with or better than expectations, according to HSBC.

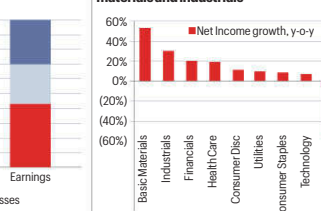
70% of companies reported in line or ahead of expectations...



● Small- and mid-caps posted growth of 30-35%, with consumption staying resilient after last year's GST and interest rate cuts.

● Firms also rolled out calibrated price increases and, along with inventory gains, these partially offset higher raw

Earnings growth was the strongest for materials and industrials



material costs," HSBC analysts said in a note on Monday.

● At 70%, the in-line-or-above expectations earnings was lower than the January-March figure of more than 75% but above the trend of just over 60%.

● Earnings growth was the

strongest for materials and industrials, while many sectors saw margin compression.

● Looking ahead, there's a risk of downgrades as commodity prices stay elevated, while lift from GST cuts, inventory gains fade. Further price hikes could also weigh on demand.

SOURCE: BLOOMBERG, HSBC; NOTE: EXCLUDES OUTLIERS SUCH AS INTERLOG AVIATION, ITC, TATA MOTORS PASSENGER VEHICLES AND DR REDDYS

JSW MG unveils plug-in hybrid EV with 1100 kms range

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, August 26

JSW MG Motor India on Wednesday unveiled the Hector Tomahawk, the first vehicle built on its newly-developed Advanced Drive Architecture Platform Technology (ADAPT), which the company describes as India's first multi-energy-vehicle platform.

The SUV will be available in both electric vehicle (EV) and plug-in hybrid electric vehicle (PHEV) versions with a range of over 1100 kms.

The Hector Tomahawk EV will be priced at an introductory Rs 13.99 lakh under the battery-as-a-service (Baas) model, along with a battery rental of Rs 4.90 per km. The full-ownership price starts at Rs 14.99 lakh.

The PHEV starts at Rs 21.79 lakh under Baas, with a battery rental of Rs 3.20 per km, while its introductory ex-showroom price starts at Rs 25.69 lakh.

MAHARASHTRA STATE SEEDS CORPORATION LIMITED,
Regd. Office: "Mahaseed Bhawan", Kishi Nagar, Akola 444 104 (Maharashtra)
Phone: 020-22222277, CIN: U01201MH1955GSC010999
E-Mail: info@mahaseed.com, Visit us at: www.mahaseed.com

Ref. No.: MSSCP/MW/2026-2027/01

e-TENDER - NOTICE

The online e-Tenders (in Two Bid System) are invited for the supply of following Packing Material required for Processing Year Kharif 2026-27.

S. N.	Name of the Item	Approx. Quantity
1	Printed & Stitched Non-woven Cloth Bags (With Handle) (3 Sizes)	4.70 Lakh
2	Printed & Stitched Cotton Cloth Bags (Without Handle) (1 Size)	0.55 Lakh
3	Printed Polyester Poly Pouches (Cylinders not available) With D-Punch (6 Sizes)	24.95 Lakh
4	Printed DWT Canvas Bags	0.50 Lakh
5	Printed Antiskid HDPE Bags (25 Sizes)	1.05 Lakh
6	Printed HDPE Bags (Unlaminated) (3 Sizes)	1.20 Lakh
7	Printed Both Side BOPP Lami. Bags (Gusseted) (2 Sizes)	10.05 Lakh
8	One Side BOPP Laminated HDPE Bags	2.30 Lakh
9	One side Poly. Lamin. HDPE Bag (2 Sizes)	0.35 Lakh
Other Processing Material		
10	Thiram 75% WSP/DP (ISI Mark)	100 M. Ton
11	Germination Towel Paper	3500 kg
12	Printed Handmade Paper Truthful Labels	23 Lakh
13	Lead Seals	3500 kg
14	Leaflets (Various sizes)	51 Lakh
15	Printed Polythene Bags	4400 kg
16	Thread Cones	12000 Nos.

Note: e-Tender documents containing the terms and conditions of supply and detailed specifications can be downloaded from the e-Tendering portal of Govt. of Maharashtra at <https://mahatenders.gov.in>. Help desk No. 758690407/758690968. The last date of online submission of e-Tender is 15.08.2026 (Tuesday) upto 15.00 Hrs.

FOR M.S.S.C. LIMITED, GENERAL MANAGER (P&E / PMW)

Invest in India's growth: FM in Canada

Washington: India is the fastest-growing major economy and offers a combination of scale, sustained growth, a young population, expanding consumption, and rapidly deepening capital markets, Finance Minister Nir-

mala Sitharaman said while seeking investment from Canadian investors. India's transformation is structural, driven by rapid urbanisation, a growing middle class and world-class digital infrastructure, she said in Canada, PTI

MARKETS

	Gold	US Dollar
Sensex	77,42,94	\$1,61,337
NIFTY	24,20,775	\$95.41
	-183.15	
	-0.24%	
	\$2,42,959	
		\$93.93

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 100, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 24, 2026. FOREX MARKET WAS CLOSED ON AUGUST 26, 2026

State Bank of India Employees' (M. S. Patel) Co-operative Credit Society Ltd., Mumbai.
State Bank of India, Mumbai Main Branch Building, 3rd Floor, Mumbai Samachar Marg, Fort, Mumbai - 400 001.

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that, the 97th Annual General Body Meeting of the State Bank of India Employees' (M. S. Patel) Co-op. Credit Society Ltd., Mumbai, will be held on Saturday, 12th September, 2026 at 02.30 p.m. at Sir Sitaram & Lady Shantabai Patkar Convocation Hall of S.N.D.T. Women's University, 1, Nathibai Thackersey Road, Queen's Road, Churchgate, Mumbai-400 020. All members are requested to attend the meeting. The Annual Report & Audited Statement of Accounts have been despatched to all members at their Branch/office. Notice is available on Society's Website www.sbmipatel.com & displayed at the registered office, for information. Bank's Identity Card is compulsory to attend the meeting.

By order of the Board,
MUMBAI
Date : 02.08.2026
MAHENDRA VAIDYA
HON. SECRETARY

STATE BOARD OF TECHNICAL EDUCATION AND TRAINING TELANGANA: HYDERABAD

Tender Notification
The State Board of Technical Education and Training (SBET), Telangana, Hyderabad, intends to engage a Confidential Printer to compose the Question Papers and compose, print & supply the Question Paper Booklets of Entrance Examinations conducted by SBET, Telangana, Hyderabad.

S.No.	Particulars	Date	Time
1.	Date of Commencement of Tender Application Submission	25-08-2026	10.30 AM
2.	Last Date for Submission of Tender Application	17-09-2026	03.00 PM

Interested firms can download the detailed Tender Document from sbet.telanganagov.in → More → Tenders.

DIPR NO. 481-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt: 25-08-2026 Sd: SECRETARY

Rajasthan State Road Development And Construction Corporation Ltd., JAIPUR.
जिफरा रोड-27

Invitation is hereby given to all eligible bidders to submit sealed bids for the supply of the following materials for the construction of the road.

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quantity	Unit	Rate
1.	Gravel	1000	Cum	1500/-
2.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
3.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
4.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
5.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
6.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
7.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
8.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
9.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
10.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
11.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
12.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
13.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
14.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
15.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
16.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
17.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
18.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
19.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-
20.	Crushed Stone	1000	Cum	1500/-

For M.S.S.C. LIMITED, GENERAL MANAGER (P&E / PMW)

सर्वोच्च न्यायालय
सं. १०८७८-४
(सामान्य न्यायालय प्रविष्टि)

सरकारी गज़ट, उत्तर प्रदेश

उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार द्वारा प्रकाशित

प्रयागराज, शनिवार, 15 अगस्त, 2026 ई० (श्रावण 24, 1948 शक संवत्)

भाग 1-क
नियम, कार्य विधियाँ, आज्ञाएँ, विज्ञापित इत्यादि, जिनको उत्तर प्रदेश के राज्यपाल महोदय, विभिन्न विभागों के अध्यक्ष तथा राजस्व परिषद् ने जारी किया।

OFFICE OF THE DISTRICT MAGISTRATE BULANDSHAHR
Revenue Department
Form-18
(Sub-rule (2) of Rule 20)
Preliminary Notification by the Appropriate Government / Collector
(Under Sub-section (1) of Section 11 of the Act)
Notification
JUNE 28, 2026

No.:182/III-S.L.A.O. (J.O.) Bulandshahr-1- Under sub-section (1) of Section 11 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, the Uttar Pradesh / Collector (for the purposes of the appropriate Government) is of the opinion that a total of 1,82,592 hectares of land is required in village Jahangirabad, Pargana and Tehsil Anupshahr, District Bulandshahr, to fill the gap of Alipka Jahangirabad under Lakhavati branch proposed by Madhya Ganga Canal Construction Block-10, Bulandshahr.

2. There is no possibility of displacement of any family due to land acquisition.

3. The State Government/Collector hereby accords its consent to notify for general information the land mentioned in the following schedule for public purpose.

S. No.	District	Tehsil	Pargana	Village	Plot Number	Area to be Acquired (in Hectares)
1	Bulandshahr	Anupshahr	Jahangirabad	887	0.040	
2	"	"	"	"	0.150	
3	"	"	"	"	0.040	
4	"	"	"	"	0.040	
5	"	"	"	"	0.040	
6	"	"	"	"	0.040	
7	"	"	"	"	0.040	
8	"	"	"	"	0.040	
9	"	"	"	"	0.040	
10	"	"	"	"	0.040	
11	"	"	"	"	0.040	
12	"	"	"	"	0.040	
13	"	"	"	"	0.040	
14	"	"	"	"	0.040	
15	"	"	"	"	0.040	
16	"	"	"	"	0.040	
17	"	"	"	"	0.040	

4. Directives are issued to authorize the State Government/Collector to undertake all necessary actions for the proper implementation of the Act and its associated functions.

5. Under Section 15 of the Act, any person having an interest in the land may submit a written objection to the Collector against the land acquisition within their area, within 60 days from the date of publication of the notification.

6. Under Section 11(4) of the Act, no person shall from the date of publication of the notification until the completion of the land acquisition proceedings enter into any transaction regarding, or effect the sale/purchase of, the land specified in the preliminary notification, nor create any encumbrance upon such land, without the prior approval of the Collector.

Note: A site map of the aforesaid land may be inspected at the office of the Collector.

UPID-255085 Dt. 25/08/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

(Sd.) Illegible
District Magistrate
Bulandshahr

Superintending Engineer
Bulandshahr Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr
No. 8295 /96M(3) /E-TENDER/BSS/CI/2026-27
Dated 17.08.2026

E-Procurement Inviting Tender Notice

On behalf of Governor of Uttar Pradesh, Superintending Engineer Bulandshahr Circle, U.P.W.D., Bulandshahr invites following percentage rate bid online through <http://tenderup.nic.in> from the eligible and approved Contractors registered with P.W.D. class as per column no. 8 below Road work Category as applied from Date **09.09.2026 to 16.09.2026 upto 12:00 Noon** as per the prescribed T-2 of Govt. of U.P. The technical bids will be opened online on dated **16.09.2026 at 12:30 P.M.** If the office happens to be closed on the date of opening of the bids as specified, the bids will be opened online on the next working day, at the same time any validity of bid will be considered from the original date. The date and time of opening of the financial bid shall be notified on the website.

Sl. No	Name of Work	Construction cost of work (Rs.in Lac)	Maintenance cost (Rs. in Lac)	Bid Security (Rs.in Lac)	Work Completion	Tender document fee including GST	Contractors Category
1	New Construction of Bagsara Pul to Randhora Rajwaha Patti	277.00	18.38	16.77	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	A (Road Work)
2	New Construction of Govindpur Atrauli Railway Station road to Sultanpur Biloni Link road	109.00	2.74	7.59	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
3	New Construction of Pibai Edlghat to Ichhawari Via Bhatta.	108.00	2.70	7.54	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
4	New Construction of Village Nagar to Village Saurapur Kalan Link road	71.00	1.77	5.64	6 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
5	New Construction of Saunda Habibpur to Village Rampur Link road	103.00	2.59	7.28	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
6	New Construction of Kehrola Amia Link road to Village Kehrola and Bhogpur Underpass	135.00	9.64	9.23	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
7	New Construction of Naar Mohammadpur to Usmanpur main road via chingrawali	191.00	10.99	12.10	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	A (Road Work)
8	New Construction of Hissara to Hissaiti Link road	74.00	1.86	5.79	6 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
9	New Construction of Bhadwani to Saunda Habibpur road	120.00	8.30	8.42	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
10	New Construction of Village Khutena to paldiphal Bijli Ghar road via Village Gangawali	127.00	8.00	8.75	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
11	New Construction of Jaanpur Kalan road to Soojapur Link road	105.00	2.64	7.38	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
12	New Construction of Milak Bhatnara road to Rangpur Link road	152.00	3.80	9.79	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
13	New Construction of Village Rasoolgarh Model School to Tyoti Link road	204.00	5.10	12.46	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	A (Road Work)
14	New Construction of Rasoolgarh to Pataleshwar Mahadev (Patali Baba) Mandir Link road	81.80	2.04	6.19	6 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
15	New Construction of Fuzalpur to Nagla Ranjeet Link road	75.00	1.88	5.84	6 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
16	New Construction of Ghunghrawali to Yakubpur road	118.00	2.95	8.05	9 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
17	New Construction of Salempur - Shiwal road to Shaheed Chaudhary Jagpal Singh's Statue in Village Bhainawali	76.00	1.91	5.90	6 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
18	New Construction of Village Poothari Khurd road to Khairpur Link road	89.00	2.22	6.56	6 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)
19	New Construction of Sarjawali road to Milak Link road	78.00	1.95	6.00	6 Month	Tender Cost- Rs. 2300.00+ G.S.T. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	AB (Road Work)

1. Maintenance Period of above works will be 5 Years

2. Time allowed for completion of Whole work is mention in col. No.5 including rainy season.

3. The Tender Document fee & Bid Security must be deposited through Internet Banking only.

4. All registered contractors have to upload Turnover last 5 years of certified by C.A. and details of maximum cost of work successfully completed in last 5 years on Chanakya Software before submission of tender.

5. Details of e-tender uploaded on <http://tenderup.nic.in> shall also be uploaded on UP PWD Chanakya software, before last date & time of submission of bid.

6. Terms & other conditions related to bid are available on <http://tenderup.nic.in>

7. Bidder has to upload required documents as per Government order No. 879(1) / 23-7-2020 P.W. Anubhag-7 Lucknow Dt. 25.08.2020 for "Pranah Application" in Chanakya Software by accessing hyperlink available on <http://roc.up.gov.in> for Tendering Process

8. According to Government Order No. 86/2026/649/2026/23, 7099/106/2025 Lo. Ni. Anu-7 Date 23.05.2026 additional Performance Security will have to be deposited & The Contractor is required to deposit performance Security valid for 45 days from the date of expiry of defect liability period For unbalanced bids, it will be mandatory to deposit additional performance security amount by the date of completion of work as per the Contract Bond.

(Hemant Singh)
Executive Engineer
CD PWD Khurja

UPID-255113 Dt. 25.08.2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

(Maneesh Verma)
Superintending Engineer
Bulandshahr Circle, PWD
Bulandshahr

BEFORE THE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL
AHMEDABAD BENCH, AHMEDABAD
C.A. (CAA)/ 29 (AHM) 2026
In the matter of Sections 230 to 232 read with other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013
and
In the matter of Scheme of Amalgamation of
Orient Cement Limited ("Transferor Company")
with
Ambuja Cements Limited ("Transferee Company")

APPLICANT NO. 1 /
TRANSFEROR COMPANY

NOTICE AND ADVERTISEMENT OF NOTICE OF THE MEETING OF THE EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS
(WHICH CONSIST OF PUBLIC SHAREHOLDERS)

Notice is hereby given that by an order dated July 20, 2026 ("Order"), the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Ahmedabad Bench ("Hon'ble Tribunal") has directed convening of the meeting of the equity shareholders of Orient Cement Limited (hereinafter referred to as the "Transferor Company"), for the purpose of considering, and if thought fit, approving the arrangement embodied in the Scheme of Amalgamation of the Transferor Company with Ambuja Cements Limited (hereinafter referred to as the "Scheme") pursuant to the provisions of Sections 230-232 of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and other applicable provisions thereof and applicable rules thereunder.

In pursuance of the Order passed by the Hon'ble Tribunal and as directed therein, further Notice is hereby given that a meeting of the equity shareholders of the Transferor Company will be held on Monday, September 28, 2026 at 10:30 a.m. (10:30 hours) IST through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") (hereinafter referred to as the "Meeting") in compliance with the applicable laws including circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars") from time to time and the Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/CFO-PoD-2/PIR/2024/133 dated October 3, 2024, issued by the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("Circular issued by SEBI") and the said equity shareholders are requested to attend the Meeting.

The Transferor Company has completed the electronic dispatch of the Notice of the Meeting dated August 20, 2026, 2026; the explanatory statement as required under Sections 230(3), 232 (1) and (2) and 102 of the Act read with Rule 5 of Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamations) Rules, 2016; and the annexures to the explanatory statement which includes the Scheme (collectively referred to as "Particulars") on August 26, 2026, through e-mail. The Particulars were sent through electronic mode to those equity shareholders whose e-mail addresses are registered with Kfint Technologies Limited, the Transferor Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent, hereinafter referred to as "Kfint/Depositories/Transferor Company" and whose names appear in the register of members/beneficial owners as on Friday, August 14, 2026. The Particulars are placed on the website of the Transferor Company and can be accessed at www.orientcement.com and are also available on the website of National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com; Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") at www.evotingindia.com if so desired, copy of the Particulars can be obtained free of charge, between 10:30 a.m. to 12:30 p.m. on all working days of the day up to one day prior to the date of the Meeting at the registered office of the Transferor Company or from the office of its advocates, M/s. Singh & Co. Singh House, 1, Magnet Corporate Park, Off. Salu Bridge, S. G. Highway, Ahmedabad - 380 059, Gujarat, India or by sending a request along with the details of shareholding to the Transferor Company by email at investor@orientcement.com.

Since, the Meeting is being held pursuant to the Order passed by the Hon'ble Tribunal and in compliance of MCA Circulars and Circular issued by SEBI through VCOAVM, physical attendance of the equity shareholders has been dispensed with. Accordingly, the facility for appointment of proxy by the equity shareholders of the Transferor Company is not available at this Meeting.

The Hon'ble Tribunal has appointed Dr. Madan Bhalachandra Gosavi, former member of the National Company Law Tribunal, to be the Chairman of the Meeting.

M/s. Khan & Khan (Law Firm), or in its absence, CS Raimeen Maradiya, Partner, Chirag Shah and Associates, Practicing Company Secretary (Membership No. 11283 & P.P. No. 17554), has been appointed to coordinate the remote e-voting process and the e-voting during the Meeting.

The Scheme of the Meeting, if approved by the equity shareholders will be subject to subsequent approval of the Hon'ble Tribunal and such other regulatory approvals as may be necessary.

NOTICE is further given that:

- The Transferor Company has provided remote e-voting facility to its equity shareholders to enable them to cast their votes electronically and has available the services of CDSL for providing VCOAVM facility, remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting. Some of the important details regarding remote e-voting are provided below:

EVSN	260825048
Commencement of remote e-voting period	Wednesday, September 23, 2026, at 9:00 a.m. (09:00 hours) IST
End of remote e-voting period	Sunday, September 27, 2026, at 5:00 p.m. (17:00 hours) IST

The remote e-voting module will be disabled by CDSL, thereafter.

- The e-voting facility will also be made available during the Meeting to enable the equity shareholders who have not cast their vote through remote e-voting, to exercise their voting rights. Equity shareholders who have cast their vote through remote e-voting prior to the Meeting may attend the Meeting but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.
- An equity shareholder, whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the list of beneficial owners maintained by Kfint/Depositories/Transferor Company as on the cut-off date, i.e., Monday, September 21, 2026, only shall be entitled to exercise his/her voting rights on the resolution proposed in the Notice and attend the Meeting of the equity shareholders. The voting rights of the equity shareholders of the Transferor Company shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Transferor Company as on cut-off date i.e. Monday, September 21, 2026.
- The Scheme shall be acted upon if a majority of persons representing three-fourth in value of the equity shareholders of the Transferor Company voting through remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting approve the Scheme, in terms of the provisions of Sections 230-232 of the Act.
- Further, in accordance with Master Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/CFO-PoD-2/PIR/2024/133 dated June 20, 2023 issued by Securities and Exchange Board of India, the Scheme shall be acted upon only if the number of votes cast by the public shareholders (through remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting) in favour of the Scheme is more than the number of votes cast by the public shareholders against it.
- The results, together with the scrutineer's report, will be displayed at the registered office and on the website of the Transferor Company and on the website of CDSL at www.evotingindia.com and shall be communicated to National Stock Exchange of India Limited and to BSE Limited on or before Wednesday, September 30, 2026.
- Information and instructions for attending the Meeting including manner of voting (both remote e-voting and e-voting at the Meeting) by the equity shareholders holding shares in dematerialised mode, physical mode and for equity shareholders who have not registered their e-mail address has been provided in the Notice of the Meeting. The manner in which (a) person who becomes an equity shareholder of the Transferor Company after dispatch of the Notice and holding equity shares as on cut-off date (mentioned herein above); (b) equity shareholders who have forgotten the User ID and Password, can obtain/generate the User ID and password, has also been provided in the Notice of the Meeting.
- Equity shareholders holding equity shares in physical mode, who have not registered/updated their e-mail address with the Transferor Company, are requested to register/update their e-mail address by submitting Form ISRT-1 (available on the website of the Transferor Company at <https://orientcement.com/general-information/only>) filed & signed along with requisite supporting documents to Kfint at enward@rudrafinetech.com.
- Equity shareholders holding equity shares in dematerialised mode, who have not registered/updated their e-mail address with their depository participant(s), are requested to register/update their e-mail address with the depository participant(s) where they maintain their demat accounts.
- Equity shareholders seeking any information with regard to the Scheme or the matter proposed to be considered at the aforesaid Meeting, are requested to write to the Transferor Company at least 3 (three) days before the date of the Meeting through e-mail on investors@orientcement.com.
- In case of any difficulty or queries in connection with attending the Meeting through VCOAVM or casting vote through remote e-voting facility, equity shareholders may contact:

For	Name & Designation	E-mail	Address	Contact No.
E-voting	Mr. Rakesh Dahiya, Sr. Manager (CDSL)	helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com	Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futurex, Marfatil Mill Compounds, N.M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai - 400 013	1800 21 09911
VCOAVM				

Sd/-
Dr. Madan Bhalachandra Gosavi,
former member of the National Company Law Tribunal,
Chairman appointed for the Meeting

Dated: August 26, 2026

सर्वोच्च न्यायालय
सं. १०८७८-४
(सामान्य न्यायालय प्रविष्टि)

सरकारी गज़ट, उत्तर प्रदेश

उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार द्वारा प्रकाशित

प्रयागराज, शनिवार, 15 अगस्त, 2026 ई० (श्रावण 24, 1948 शक संवत्)

भाग 1-क
नियम, कार्य विधियाँ, आज्ञाएँ, विज्ञापित इत्यादि, जिनको उत्तर प्रदेश के राज्यपाल महोदय, विभिन्न विभागों के अध्यक्ष तथा राजस्व परिषद् ने जारी किया।

OFFICE OF THE DISTRICT MAGISTRATE BULANDSHAHR
Revenue Department
Form-18
(Sub-rule (2) of Rule 20)
Preliminary Notification by the Appropriate Government / Collector
(Under Sub-section (1) of Section 11 of the Act)
Notification
JUNE 17, 2026

No.:190/III-S.L.A.O. (J.O.) Bulandshahr-1- Under sub-section (1) of Section 11 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, the Uttar Pradesh / Collector (for the purposes of the appropriate Government) is of the opinion that a total of 1,666.7 hectares of land is required in the district and tehsil Bulandshahr village Dhakuli to fill the gap of Alipka Dhakuli under the Lakhavati branch proposed by Madhya Ganga Canal Construction Block-10, Bulandshahr.

2. There is no possibility of displacement of any family due to land acquisition.

3. The State Government/Collector hereby accords its consent to notify for general information the land mentioned in the following schedule for public purpose.

S. No.	District	Tehsil	Pargana	Village	Plot Number	Area to be Acquired (in Hectares)
1	Bulandshahr	Bulandshahr	Narain	Dhakuli	88	0.015
2	"	"	"	"	488/1	0.041
3	"	"	"	"	488/2	0.0015
4	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
5	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
6	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
7	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
8	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
9	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
10	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
11	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
12	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
13	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
14	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
15	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
16	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
17	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
18	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
19	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
20	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
21	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
22	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
23	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
24	"	"	"	"	80	0.000
25	"	"	"	"	80	0.000

4. Directives are issued to authorize the State Government/Collector to undertake all necessary actions for the proper implementation of the Act and its associated functions.

5. Under Section 15 of the Act, any person having an interest in the land may submit a written objection to the Collector against the land acquisition within their area, within 60 days from the date of publication of the notification.

6. Under Section 11(4) of the Act, no person shall from the date of publication of the notification until the completion of the land acquisition proceedings enter into any transaction regarding, or effect the sale/purchase of, the land specified in the preliminary notification, nor create any encumbrance upon such land, without the prior approval of the Collector.

Note: A site map of the aforesaid land may be inspected at the office of the Collector.

UPID-255087 Dt. 25/08/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

(Sd.) Illegible
District Magistrate
Bulandshahr

Saransh Jain 'unique bowler', brings 'variety', says Bahutule

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 26

DEBUTANT SARANSH Jain took the last two wickets in Sri Lanka's first innings – including that of centurion Sonal Dinusha, which allowed India to enforce the follow-on – and though he hasn't got a bagful of scalps, his performance hasn't gone unnoticed by the team management.

Spin bowler coach Saiiraj Bahutule was pleased with Jain's performance, with the off-spinner claiming three wickets across the two innings so far – 2/69 in 20.4 overs in the first innings and 1/55 in 17.4 overs in the second till the end of Day 4.

Playing one's maiden Test for India at 33 is a rare occurrence, but the rich domestic experience doesn't prevent nerves coming into play, the former leg-spinner said after stumps in Colombo.

"Saransh has toiled a lot in domestic cricket over the years, and he's got his fair due. The opportunity to make a debut for India is special. There are nerves. You're not going to be as sort of at ease when you're playing your first Test match compared to when you're playing a domestic game," Bahutule said.

"But he showed a lot of character, in spite of certain decisions not going his way and him not getting those wickets early in the first innings. But he was very consistent in his line and length."

Bahutule felt Jain has his own attributes and can work well as part of the Indian bowling attack.

"He's a peculiar bowler, a unique bowler, in the sense that he doesn't have that overspin, which is again a work in progress behind the scenes. He possesses side-spin, which is good; it gives him drift. His flat trajectory is very good, and he is also in a speed range between 80 and 85kph. When we have two more spinners in (Ravindra) Jadeja and Manav (Suthar), he brings that variety," he added.

India's spinners have been a big reason they are on the cusp of a 2-0 clean sweep in Sri Lanka, but the old problem of no-balls – even by spinners – has been a cause of frustration. Jain was the main offender with four while Jadeja overstepped once.

Bahutule acknowledged the team was aware of the issue and was working on it, and even offered a solution. "We are working on the no-balls. It is a concern, at times," he said on Wednesday.

"When the bowler is putting in that effort in situations where wickets are not coming, he has the tendency to push himself. I guess, if the free hit comes in, it will reduce the (no ball) percentage."

India's decision to enforce the follow-on was prompted by the weather forecast, Bahutule said.

"The decision had to be taken. We were looking at the clouds every now and then because, from Galle to Colombo, the rains are around any moment. There was no debate but to give that follow-on and make sure that we get the opposition out."

BCCI, other boards flag several concerns over Asian Games venue

Devendra Pandey & Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 26

AN UNTESTED hybrid surface, laid only recently. A lack of proper dressing rooms. And hotel rooms so tiny that there "might not be any space to keep a kitbag."

In about three weeks, Nishin, a small city east of the Japanese port hub Nagoya, will welcome some of the continent's best cricketers, including a star-studded Indian side featuring Jasprit Bumrah and Vaidhury Suryavanshi, led by Shreyas Iyer, for the Asian Games. The opening ceremony is on September 19, and the cricket tournament begins on September 17.

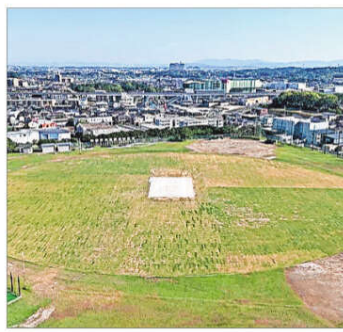
The continent's top teams, though, have expressed concerns over the makeshift facility, which was a baseball ground until a few months ago. The Indian Express has learnt that the Pakistan Cricket

Board first flagged these concerns during an Asian Cricket Council meeting a little more than a fortnight ago.

Following deliberations between members, including India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Afghanistan, among others, it has been decided that the ACC will send representatives for a recce of the venue and the players' accommodation.

"It is a very rudimentary ground, and there remains a question mark over the quality of the pitch. It has been laid very recently and, apart from one tournament, that too in May, hasn't been tested much. There are no proper dressing rooms as well," a source told The Indian Express.

Following the feedback at the meeting, it is learnt that the BCCI approached the Indian Olympic Association and the Organising Committee of the Asian Games. An IOA official said: "Since we do not have



Korogi Sports Park (archive pic) has a hybrid surface. ACHINAGAYA

any role in the technical aspects of a sport, we have advised the BCCI to consult the Organising Committee." The

Asian Games organisers did not respond to questions sent by email.

Cricket at the Asian Games

will be played at Korogi Sports Park, a remodelled baseball facility that still retains a pitcher's mound. The venue was made cricket-ready only in March this year.

The ground, with temporary stands that can hold around 2,000 people, has a hybrid pitch square, mostly natural grass with a small portion of polyethylene fibres inserted into the surface.

The park hosted the ICC Men's T20 World Cup East Asia-Pacific Qualifier in May. Adam Birss, Korogi Sports Park's Asian Games operations manager, told AFP at the time that the pitch was likely to be "bouncy, despite typhoon season usually arriving in Japan in September."

No athletes' village

The cricket boards have also raised concerns over players' accommodation, in Nagoya, roughly 20km from the venue.

Cricket at the Asian Games will be played at Korogi Sports Park, a remodelled baseball facility that still retains a pitcher's mound. The venue was made cricket-ready only in March this year.

Unlike previous Games, the Aichi-Nagoya edition will not have a conventional Athletes' Village. Instead, the roughly 15,000 participants will be split across three types of accommodation, a luxury cruise liner, Games Villas, and hotels.

Shuttlers, cricketers, footballers and softball players will be lodged at the Nagoya, according to the Olympic Council of Asia.

An official said the room sizes are believed to be "too small for two people to share, along with their individual kitbags and luggage." "It is a genuine problem, since the rooms are very tiny. If one player opens a kitbag, there won't be much space left to stand. We are trying to figure out a solution to this problem," the official said.

It is learnt that the Indian cricket teams will fly to Nagoya around September 14 or 15. The women's competition begins on September 17, with Harmanpreet Kaur-led India opening their campaign against hosts Japan. The men's team is likely to play practice matches against two club sides, and another against Japan, to acclimatise before their own competition begins on September 28. India have received a bye to the quarterfinal stage, where they will face the runners-up of the group featuring Afghanistan, Nepal and Japan.

SRI LANKA VS INDIA, SECOND TEST

India on the cusp of clean sweep as spinners take 3 late wickets

Stumping of Sooriyabandara on 92 turned the Lankans' fightback into a genuine collapse

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 26

WITH 213 runs in the bank, most teams would be tempted to enforce the follow-on. Yet, as India wrapped up Sri Lanka's first innings early on Day 4 in Colombo, Shubman Gill may have had second thoughts, bowling the hosts out for 290 with the pitch still looking good to bat on.

He opted to send them back in, perhaps mindful of the weather. But at 178 for 2, with Pasindu Sooriyabandara and Kamindu Mendis in the middle, the decision looked to have backfired.

The bowlers found a way back into the match in the third session, though, to leave Sri Lanka precariously placed at 229 for 6, with a lead of just 16.

For much of the day, India's attack struggled to sustain any real pressure on a surface offering little assistance.

It began promisingly. Mohammed Siraj removed Lahiru Udara for 32 and bowled a disciplined opening spell, hitting good areas and giving Sri Lanka little room. Prasidh Krishna supported him with tight lines, though without the same threat.

Siraj gets injured

Siraj's injury changed the equation. Attempting a catch in the deep to dismiss Sooriyabandara, he landed awkwardly and hurt his rib, forcing him into the medical tent. India were without their most experienced fast



Three of the eight Lankan wickets that fell on Wednesday were taken by debutant off-spinner Saransh Jain. ANI

bowler, while the spinners were finding little consistent turn or bounce.

Sri Lanka showed very the surface called for patience over attacking fields. Kamil Mishara and Sooriyabandara put together 58 for the second wicket, using sweeps and calculated footwork to disrupt the spinners. Jadeja eventually had Mishara lbw for 32, but India couldn't build on the breakthrough.

Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain were accurate, but accuracy alone wasn't enough. Sri Lanka rotated the strike whenever the bowlers missed their lengths, taking on Suthar in particular and forcing him into containment, bowling defensive lines without close-in

fielders.

Jadeja remained India's most threatening spinner, varying his pace and attacking the stumps, but the batsmen used sweeps, slog-sweeps and the odd charge down the pitch to disturb his rhythm.

The problem wasn't that India bowled badly throughout. It was that they couldn't sustain pressure for long enough. Each time the bowlers strung together quiet overs, Sri Lanka would rotate the strike or release the pressure with a boundary.

Jain had a similar problem. He was accurate, and occasionally found turn, but lacked the penetration to consistently trouble the set batsmen. No-balls disrupted his rhythm too,

two in the middle session, another later.

India's breakthrough came through Prasidh. Kamindu Mendis had grown increasingly comfortable against both pace and spin, but in the 44th over, a rising delivery struck him high on the bat as he pulled. Gill ran back and completed an excellent diving catch.

The third session showed what India could have produced earlier. The attack became more disciplined and aggressive, particularly against the lower order. India used close catchers; Prasidh bowled short, while the spinners attacked the stumps.

The pressure finally produced a cluster of wickets. Suthar removed Dhananjaya de Silva for 23, not through a brilliant delivery so much as sustained pressure forcing a mistake. Dhananjaya tried to clip a flatter ball into the leg-side, but the inside edge popped up off the thigh pad, and Devdutt Padikkal took the catch.

Biggest breakthrough

Then came the biggest wicket of the innings. Sooriyabandara, who had scored 80 in the first innings, was within sight of a hundred on 92. Suthar anticipated his charge, slowed the delivery down and pushed it wider outside off. Sooriyabandara couldn't reach it, and Rishabh Pant completed a straightforward stumping. It was sharp bowling awareness from Suthar, and sharper glove work from Pant.

That dismissal opened the door, and India went after the next batsman. Niroshan Dickwella edged Sri Lanka for four and swept him for a single before Jain trapped him lbw for 6.

From there, India's bowling tightened further. Prasidh used the short ball against Sonal Dinusha, with leg spin and leg

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA
COLOMBO
TOSS: India won, chose to bat

INDIA (503/9 DECLARED)
SRI LANKA (0/N 265/8)

Sonal Dinusha c Rahul b Jain 103 (162b, 8x4, 3x6)
Lahiru Kumara c June b Jain 12 (58b, 2x4)

Aisith Fernando not out 1 (4b)

EXTRAS 14 (b 0, lb 6, w 2, nb 6, p 0)

TOTAL (584 Overs) 290 all out

FOW: 9-288 Lahiru Kumara, 86-5 (w), 10-290 (Sonal Dinusha, 89-4 (w))

BOWLING: Mohammed Siraj 11-0-33-2; Prasidh Krishna 16-2-53-2; Manav Suthar 21-85-3; Saransh Jain 20-4-5-6

SRI LANKA (FOLLOWING ON)

Lahiru Udara c Jain b Siraj 3 (51b)

Kamil Mishara lbw b Jadeja 32 (39b, 3x4, 1x6)

P Sooriyabandara c Pant b Suthar 92 (172b, 2x4, 1x6)

Kamindu Mendis c Gill b Krishna 55 (92b, 2x4, 3x6)

Dhananjaya de Silva c Padikkal b Suthar 23 (44b, 1x4, 1x6)

Sonal Dinusha c June b Jain 103 (162b, 8x4, 3x6)

Niroshan Dickwella lbw b Jain 6 (12b, 1x4)

Keshara Nuwantha batting 3 (29b)

EXTRAS 8 (b 3, lb 0, w 0, nb 5, p 0)

TOTAL (724 Overs) 229/6

FOW: 1-5 (Lahiru Udara, 3-3 (w), 2-63 (Kamil Mishara, 14-5 (w), 3-178 (Kamindu Mendis, 43-1 (w), 4-209 (Dhananjaya de Silva, 58-5 (w), 5-222 (Pasindu Sooriyabandara, 60-3 (w), 6-218 (Niroshan Dickwella, 64-2 (w))

BOWLING: Prasidh Krishna 10-1-31-1; Mohammed Siraj 9-4-11-1; Manav Suthar 18-2-44-3; Saransh Jain 17-4-3-55-1; Ravindra Jadeja 18-2-48-1

gully in place. The left-hander was forced to duck, sway and defend. At one stage, Sri Lanka went 36 balls without scoring. The passage showed India had finally found the right method: making the lower order defend for long periods, and building pressure through dot balls.

At 229 for 6, India had reduced the scoring and begun to turn the match around. That was when the weather intervened.

Suthar's Colombo spell may matter more than his 10 wickets in Galle



Manav Suthar led the Indian fightback with wickets of Dhananjaya de Silva and Pasindu Sooriyabandara in quick succession. CREMAS

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 26

AT GALLE, Manav Suthar looked like a left-arm spinner bowling on instinct. He got plenty of help from the surface, beat the edges, troubled the batsmen, and eventually finished with 10 wickets in the match, helping India win by a big margin.

Colombo has offered no such luxury. His second innings spell on Wednesday became less about help from the pitch and more about learning how to create pressure with little assistance.

That difference made the performance an important step in Suthar's short Test career. In Galle, he could land the ball in the right areas, let his drift and turn create uncertainty, and let the pitch do the rest. Colombo demanded something different.

Sri Lanka's batsmen quickly recognised that the SSC surface was considerably slower, offering nothing like Galle's assistance, and hadn't deteriorated much despite three days of bowling on it. The lack of wear gave them room to attack Suthar.

He was attacked almost immediately, Kamil Mishara and Sooriyabandara using the sweep and the charge to keep him from settling. Sooriyabandara punished a full delivery for four early in the innings. His first three overs cost 12 runs, and his fourth went for 10. Sri Lanka taking him on almost from the start.

That approach was Suthar's first real test at this level, and it forced him to change his role. He had to gradually balance attack with containment, at times shifting to over the wicket against the right-hander with a spread field.

He bowled flatter and quicker at times, and slowed the ball down when he expected the batsmen to charge. Sooriyabandara, and later Dhananjaya de Silva, were happy to take singles into the gaps, making it hard for him to build pressure. There were moments, though, when the ball still turned sharply, including one delivery that beat Sooriyabandara's outside edge. Suthar kept bowling despite the lack of reward, waiting for the batsmen to make a mistake. For a prolonged stretch, he became more of a containing bowler. Sri Lanka finding ways to rotate the strike and attack whenever he erred in length. That pa-

tience eventually paid off.

"It is an experience for Manav. This is his third Test. He's going to get different situations. He knew they are going to charge at him. He's a learning cricketer. What we like about him is his resilience. He always gives 100%... the batters also played some good shots," spin bowling coach Saiiraj Bahutule told reporters on Wednesday.

On this pitch, Suthar had to accept there would be long stretches when wickets wouldn't come. Young spinners can get carried away claiming wickets on surfaces offering extravagant turn. The game, though, tends to reward patience and persistence.

Small adjustments

Suthar varied his pace from the low 80s to the mid-90s kph, occasionally slowing the ball to tempt batsmen into charging. His wickets didn't always come from ripping deliveries. They came from reading the batsmen, and making small adjustments.

Dhananjaya de Silva's dismissal was an example. Suthar bowled flatter, and the ball held its line, taking the inside edge before ballooning off the thigh pad.

Later, Sooriyabandara charged once again. Suthar anticipated it, slowed the delivery, bowled it wide, and left Rishabh Pant with a simple stumping. Both wickets were products of thought, not arm's length. The variation was in pace, trajectory, drift and angle.

That is why Colombo may ultimately prove more valuable to Suthar than Galle. Galle showed what he could do when conditions favoured him. Colombo tested whether he could stay effective when batsmen attacked, when he had to defend, and wickets didn't come as freely. His final figures of 2 for 81 in 18 overs after making the ball turn sharply, and producing a spectacular delivery. At Galle, Suthar could trust his natural strengths: flight, drift, turn and accuracy. At Colombo, he began to look like a Test bowler learning to think his way through a spell.

WHAT'S IN YOUR BAG?

Arshdeep still carries a red ball that he barely gets to bowl

Venkata Krishna B
Bengaluru, August 26

WHEREVER HE goes, Arshdeep Singh carries the red ball in his kit bag. He doesn't know when or where the opportunity will come, but he prefers to have it with him and practice whenever he can. It has been four years since he made his white-ball debut for India, and nearly eight since his first-class debut. Yet despite being an integral part of India's white-ball squads, thanks to his ability to move the ball both ways, the 26-year-old international white-ball commitments have left him little room to build a case for a Test spot.

"I've been saying that since day one, as a player when you start playing, the goal is always to represent India. It's not just to play a few Tests," he says.

pressed enough by his work in the nets that they considered including him in the XI, before an injury ended his tour.

If he is fit and makes North Zone's XI for the Duleep Trophy semi-final against South Zone starting Sunday, it will be his first time he plays back-to-back domestic matches since October 2024. Before North Zone's 52-run win over West Zone on Wednesday, in which Arshdeep played, his last red-ball appearance had also come in last year's Duleep Trophy. In the 2024-25 season, he played four red-ball fixtures, and international white-ball commitments have left him little room to build a case for a Test spot.

"I've been saying that since day one, as a player when you start playing, the goal is always to represent India. It's not just to play a few Tests," he says.



Arshdeep Singh took four wickets against West Zone. PTI

format. And I'm no exception. I also want to play all three formats and very rarely do I get a chance to play red ball cricket. This was a chance and I just

wanted to showcase my skill set and just see how many overs I can bowl and nice to get the win as well," Arshdeep said.

On a pitch offering maximum assistance to the spinners, Arshdeep finished with only four wickets to his name, but was hard to miss how he made the new ball talk. Even with the old ball, he worked at his angles, trying to extract something from the surface. Still, unlike in white-ball cricket, making a real impact with the red ball remains a work in progress for him.

"I mean, every player is eager to play all the formats, but when the time is right, it will come eventually. Red ball has that beauty of giving you a chance again, and if you feel you're not in the game in the first spell, there's always a chance to come back and take wickets in the second

spell, and you're always in the game. You always have a chance to prove and change the game by delivering for the team," he said.

Spinners dominated the game overall. For North, beyond Arshdeep, it was Anshul Kamboj who was the mainstay, with a steady line and length that Arshdeep himself often lacked. Since Jayden Unadkat played the two Tests in West Indies in 2023, India haven't fielded a single left-arm seamer in their XI, and their hesitation to turn to Arshdeep is itself a sign of where he stands in the race for a Test cap. "I mean the message is to perform whenever you get a chance and just keep delivering, and when the time is right, you will get your chance," he says.

It isn't as if India have written him off as a white-ball specialist. In 2023, he was sent to county cricket, where he showed a different side to his game. When Musheer Khan was frustrating North Zone's bowlers in the first innings here, Arshdeep, beyond varying his angles, kept a few flickers poised in front of the batsmen's eyeline while bowling from around the wicket. It played on Musheer's mind, and he eventually nicked one behind to the keeper.

BRIEF SCORES: North Zone 251 (Anshul Kamboj 60; Tusshar Deshpande 4/57) & 222 (Ayush Badoni 50; Tanush Kotia 18/44) beat West Zone 187 (Shams Mulani 52; Abid Mushtaq 5/39) & 234 (Musheer Khan 96; Abid Mushtaq 4/60) by 52 runs.

SEMIFINALS: North Zone vs South Zone; Central Zone vs East Zone.

Pragg's mistake hands Caruana lead in GCT final

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, August 26

FABIANO CARUANA is the defending Grand Chess Tour champion for a reason. The American GM, who won the prestigious tour in 2023 and again in 2025, took a big step towards a record third title on Wednesday, defeating India's R Praggnanandhaa in the first Classical match of the final.

In the Four Knights of the Guoco Piano, Pragnanandhaa kept things under control for the longest time. The first trade came quickly, with the light-squared bishops the first to leave the board. He lost a bit of momentum when he allowed the exchange of his dark-squared bishop for White's knight, though the engine evaluation stayed roughly equal for the next several moves.

Pragnanandhaa then traded his first knight to enter a queen-and-rook endgame, where he held a knight against Caruana's active bishop. Both players had just over 13 minutes left on the clock. In the tricky endgame that followed, Pragnanandhaa's rook move to c8 on the 28th move proved costly, the first time he had conceded a significant edge.

It let Caruana force the exchange of queens and one set of rooks, leaving him with a highly active bishop and an extra pawn against Pragnanandhaa's knight.

Knight sacrifice

There was hardly any defence that could have stopped Caruana's impending attack, his a-pawn running down the flank to kill the game. Pragnanandhaa sacrificed his knight at c5 to attempt to salvage something, but the position was too hopeless. He resigned on the 48th move.

Pragnanandhaa has emerged as one of the most consistent players on the circuit. Having become the first Indian to win the Norway Chess event, beating Magnus Carlsen twice in two Classical games, he showed his range even in shorter formats by winning the Saint Louis Rapid and Blitz. He then finished joint top of the Sinquefeld Cup, where he defeated arch-rival and new World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov.

While all these results are impressive, Pragnanandhaa has had to play non-stop chess, event after event. He has been relentless in his second year as a full tour player on the GCT, but the toll of playing so many games is beginning to show. He made an uncharacteristic mistake in both games against Vincent Keymer in the semifinals, though the German made even bigger blunders that allowed the Indian to hit back. The mistake against Caruana was yet another sign of fatigue creeping in.

GM Peter Svidler, who has previously beaten Pragnanandhaa's second, pointed to the same thing. "It feels like we're making excuses for the best players in the world. You know, poor babies, they had to play chess for three weeks straight, but it does accumulate...things like this start slipping in," he said.

DIFFERENT APPROACHES

Preparing for Gukesh's best form: Sindarov on Worlds tie

Uzbekistan GM explains why he can't stop competing before the biggest match of his career

Mayank Chaudhary & Amit Kamath
New Delhi/Mumbai, August 26

JAVOKHIR SINDAROV and D Gukesh make for a compelling yin-yang pair. Polar opposites in temperament, they represent two completely different approaches to the game, and to life. On one side is Gukesh: usually quiet, intense, utterly focused. The youngest world champion in chess history has chosen to step away from the Global Chess League (GCL) and the Grand Chess Tour (GCT) to dedicate himself entirely to his title defence. He wants no distractions.

On the other side is Sindarov: chirpy, energetic, seemingly unstoppable. The Uzbek challenger has done the exact opposite. He filled Gukesh's spot at the GCT as a full tour member, and played in the FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Team Championship, Tata Steel Masters, Nordtits Memorial, and the Uzbekistan vs USA showdown, among a dozen other events. His trip to Bengaluru for the Global Chess League will be his third visit to an Indian city in less than a year, after Goa and Mumbai.

Exposure is one thing, but is he fatiguing himself ahead of the biggest match of his career? Sindarov tries to explain why he plays so much. "I became a top chess player only this year. I was a 2700-rated player, but that doesn't really count as being a top player. But Gukesh has been a top 10 player for more than three years now, so he has a lot of experience playing against the best in the world," he tells The Indian Express.



Javokhir Sindarov (R) and D Gukesh will face off in the World Championship match in Geneva from November 25 to December 15. EXPRESS

"That's why, whenever I get the chance to play in other tournaments, I want to play. I enjoy playing against top chess players. I want to feel more comfortable in high-level tournaments before the World Championship match, and that's why I've been playing so many events," he adds.

Into deep waters

Sindarov has thrown himself deep into the waters. By his theory, if he stays afloat, he's ready. His travel schedule over the last few months reads more like a world tour: Goa, Mumbai, Doha, Wijk aan Zee, Cyprus, Warsaw, Bucharest, Hong Kong, Charlotte, Miami, Saint Louis, and Bengaluru. After that, he returns to Uzbekistan to help bring the Chess Olympiad's glory back to his own backyard, in Samarkand.

Where Gukesh retreats into silence, Sindarov thrives in chaos. Where the champion conserves energy, the challenger burns through it. But Sindarov understands Gukesh's approach too.

“For Gukesh, I understand. Last year he played a lot of tournaments and he didn't feel very good mentally. He might have felt that he needed to work on certain things. But he's a very, very strong chess player.”

JAVOKHIR SINDAROV
UZBEKISTAN GRANDMASTER

"For Gukesh, I understand. Last year he played a lot of tournaments and he didn't feel very good mentally. He might have felt that he needed to work on certain things. But in my opinion, he's a very, very strong chess player," he says.

Sindarov is toughening up to face the best version of Gukesh. "I've played a lot against him, and I know he can play in-

credibly well. If he's in his top form, like we saw in 2024, anything can happen in the match. So I am preparing for his best form," Sindarov says.

Playing different events in varied conditions has helped Sindarov grow as a player. As luck would have it, he's representing his fourth different franchise in the fourth season of the GCL. Having played for Mumbai Masters, Triveni Continental Kings and Gangs Grandmasters in the first three seasons, Sindarov was picked up by the American Gambits this time at the auction.

The Uzbek says that while he enjoys being a team player, once the game starts, he focuses only on his own board. "In GCL, I'm always playing with new guys, and it's always very enjoyable. In team tournaments, you always need to think about your own chess board, but of course you also need to help your teammates. You need to motivate them, support them. I like being a team player, but when it comes to the game, you need to focus

only on your own game," he says.

He understands the dynamics of a team event well. The format of the GCL is different, but Sindarov still enjoys it. "In team events, you understand when you need to take a risk, when you need to play slowly. There are many things to consider. With White, for example, you don't need to lose. You can play for two results. But GCL is a different kind of tournament. There are six boards, different time controls, and the scoring is completely different. If Black wins, they get four points; if White wins, three. It's a unique format. I would say it's one of the top team tournaments, very enjoyable. Every year I come very close to fighting for first place, and I really like this format," he says.

After playing different roles in the GCT, on the "Prodigy" or "Superstar" board, this time Sindarov will sit at the top: the "Icon" board. He is especially excited about the prospect of facing Magnus Carlsen.

Two Indian-origin finalists, and a tale of two tennis dreams

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, August 26

A LONG-HELD dream came true for Shristi Selvan on August 15, 2026. She received a Gold Ball from Billie Jean King in San Diego. Standing beside her was another Indian-origin girl, Aarini Bhattacharya.

The teenagers, whose parents hail from Chennai and Kolkata respectively, were the two finalists in the girls' singles final at the USTA Under-16 National Championships. Shristi prevailed, earning a wildcard into the US Open Junior Championships. She will now compete against the best under-18 players in the world, starting September 6.

Shristi and Aarini made the final from a 192-player main draw. They trained together at the Junior Tennis Champions Center in Maryland.

Shristi's coach, Paula Coyos, who has worked with her since she was nine, describes her as an aggressive, all-court and "very free-minded" player. "She loves having her favourite patterns, but wants the freedom to make them her own and add little variations depending on what she sees and feels on the court. That creativity is a big part of who she is as a player," Paula tells The Indian Express.

Before Shristi, Paula taught the sport to her elder sister, Shivani. The coach remembers a then seven-year-old Shristi sitting outside with a notebook, taking notes or drawing.

The younger sibling started picking up balls during practice. One day, Paula handed her a spoon in place of a racket, to gauge her hand-eye coordination. Shristi never missed.

She dabbled in ballet, gymnastics and piano too, briefly, but none of it matched the joy of hitting tennis balls cleanly. "She would never come off the court," Shristi's father, Selvan Dhurai, recalls.

Even as Selvan and his wife, Subash Dhuranji, managers in software engineering and HR respectively, were focused on Shivani's game, Paula kept insisting that Shristi's talent was different. The parents soon saw it too.

"She was very fast on court. Though the technique was not there, her willingness to put the ball back in play and challenge bigger, older players told us there was something special."

Then there was the mental side. Shristi still showed tenacity and ambition in her pre-teen years, when being called "Shivaan's sister" stopped sitting right with her.

"No, no, no, I'm not Shivani's sister anymore. I'm Shristi Selvan," she said at the time. Cut to August 15, 2026, when she battled debilitating cramps in the third set of her final against Aarini.

The cramping began in Shristi's hand and spread to her quads and calves. She took medical timeout, but was still writhing in pain afterward. Denied a second timeout, and barely able to move, Shristi gritted it out. The cramps eventually eased, and she won her ticket to Flushing Meadows.

Unlike Selvan and Sub-



Indian-origin Shristi Selvan (L) and Aarini Bhattacharya were the girls' singles finalists at the USTA U-16 C'ship. JON MULVEY/USTA

athra, Aarini's parents don't believe their daughter has a special talent. "We are very critical of her. We think she just likes to play and that's it," says Aarun Bhattacharya, a partner at a global consulting firm. Academics come first for Aarini and her family, and they make no secret of it.

Aarun's father retired as additional chief secretary of West Bengal, and his mother is a doctor. His wife, Moomita, is a controller at a life sciences company, and her father is an IT graduate. Rather than turning pro or chasing an ITF title, Aarini's goal is an Ivy League college.

Aarun explains the reasoning. "What happens if being pro doesn't work out? Then you have something else to fall back on, because very few people make it. And then the financial investment needed is very difficult."

He adds, matter-of-factly: "If these people might really want to go pro, and it's very impressive, kudos to them; we hope to see them on TV. Some people are also realistic."

Eye on academics

The Bhattacharyas fall firmly into the second category. Aarini wants to become a genetic engineer. "It's a very good academic institution possible, unless something remarkable happens along the way."

"She will play some entry-level pro tournaments starting next year. Her goal is to play the junior Grand Slams on the way. If something dramatic happens, sure, she'll try. But that's not the goal right now," Aarun says.

Coach Mira Vleek describes Aarini as an attacking baseliner with "a quality serve and aggressive forehand." He credits her high first-serve percentage, paired with her forehand, for shaping her strong run at the Under-16 Nationals.

Playing a junior Grand Slam is her short-term goal, per Mira, but there's no pressure from her parents in that regard. Aarun adds, "Moomita has always told her that when we see the US Open finals or Wimbledon finals, you'll be the person handing out the checks. That balance has helped her, freed her from a lot."

Shristi and Aarini still train on the same courts at the JTCC, most days, alongside each other. One is picturing herself lifting a trophy. The other is picturing herself handing one out.

Bodo/Glimt return to CL, debuts for Sabah, LASK

Associated Press
Geneva, August 26

The draw for the 36-team group stage will be made on Thursday in Monaco.

THE CHAMPIONS League's feel-good story Bodo/Glimt is back for a second season joined by two debutants, Sabah of Azerbaijan just nine years after being formed and - remarkably - LASK of Austria.

Bodo/Glimt eased through the second leg of its qualifying playoff Tuesday against NEC Nijmegen and Sabah denied Hapoel Beer-Sheva in extra time after a last-gasp goal in regulation time to level the aggregate score.

LASK seemed all-but out after a 4-0 aggregate away trailing 4-0 on aggregate to Celtic who had taken a three-goal win from the first leg last week in Glasgow.

Still, LASK had already raised scoring chances on Celtic's goal even before falling further behind and somehow only retrieved three goals of the

deficit when the clock passed 90 minutes.

Then Florian Flecker's close-range header forced extra time, during which the Scottish champion continued to implode.

A fifth unanswered goal for LASK came in the 109th by Samuel Adeniran, who then had a penalty saved as the score stood 5-1 on the night and 5-4 on aggregate. Celtic drops into the second-tier Europa League.

Four more playoff second-leg games Wednesday will confirm the final entries in the 36-team main phase. The draw for those games is made Thursday in Monaco.

WOMEN'S HOCKEY WORLD CUP: INDIA VS GERMANY

India seek winning finish and best result in 52 years

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 26

AFTER JUST one loss in five games, India have a final chance to turn an impressive Women's World Cup campaign into a memorable one when they take on Germany in the fifth-place playoff on Thursday.

Victory over the higher-ranked two-time champions would give India its best finish at the World Cup since they came fourth in the inaugural edition in 1974. More importantly, it would offer Sjoerd Marjine's side a much-needed lift after their semifinal hopes ended in disappointment with a goalless draw against Australia.

The disappointment of Sunday, however, has had time to settle. India have had a three-day break to recover, regroup and shift their attention to a match that could provide valuable momentum ahead of next

month's Asian Games, where a gold medal will secure direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

"This rest was crucial to recover from the setback in the previous match. Now, the team will play against Germany with renewed vigour and freshness," Marjine was quoted as saying by PTI. "The team has overcome the disappointment of not reaching the semifinals and is now fully focused on defeating Germany and leaving the tournament with a win. We want to improve our game and perform better for the Asian Games."

India's run to the fifth-place playoff has been built on consistency and a defence that has stood up against some of the world's strongest teams.

Their only defeat in five matches came against defending champions and co-hosts Netherlands, who were restricted to two goals, both from



Indian players during a training session in Amstelveen. PTI

penalty corners.

India began with a 2-2 draw against Paris Olympics silver medalists China before beating South Africa 6-1, with six different players scoring. A goalless draw against England took them into the second

round, where they ran the Dutch close before holding Australia in the match they needed to win to reach the semifinals.

Despite the heartbreak of that result, India are assured of their best World Cup finish in

more than five decades, irrespective of Wednesday's outcome.

The tournament has also offered encouraging signs for a side featuring 11 World Cup debutants. Goalkeepers Bichoo Devi and Savita have made important interventions, while India's defence has remained composed before pressure. Captain Salima Tete has been among their most influential players, using her pace and attacking runs to drive the team forward.

In midfield, Sunelitta Toppo, Sakshi and Neha have provided control and energy, while youngsters Ishika and Baliset have contributed alongside the more experienced Navneet Kaur, Deepika and Lalremsiami in attack.

Germany, however, will present a different kind of challenge. Ranked fifth in the world, they had beaten India twice in practice matches be-

fore the tournament.

Adding another layer to the contest is the presence of Janne Schopman in the German dugout. The former India head coach knows many of the players well, having first worked alongside Marjine as his assistant during India's run to fourth place at the Tokyo Olympics before succeeding him as head coach in 2021.

Germany finished third in Pool F after beating Scotland and the USA, losing to Argentina and then going down to co-hosts Belgium in the second round. They sealed third place in their pool with a victory over Spain.

"We couldn't beat them in the two practice matches before the World Cup. However, our focus will be on improving our performance," Marjine said. "It doesn't matter who we play, the focus is on us."

Live on Star Sports Network & JioHotstar, 6.30pm